

Søren Kierkegaard as Philosopher

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Translated from the Danish
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“What is the significance of a primitive genius? It is not so much to bring forth something absolutely new; for there is really nothing new under the sun; but it is to revise the universally human, the fundamental questions. This, in the deepest sense, is honesty. And to lack primitivity altogether—that is, the revising element—to take everything without further ado as given custom and usage, and to let it suffice that it is custom and usage, that is, to withdraw from responsibility for doing likewise: that is dishonesty.”

Søren Kierkegaard's Papers, 1847.

Translator's note

This is an English translation of Harald Høffding's *Søren Kierkegaard som Filosof*, first published by P. G. Philipsen (Copenhagen, 1892) and here rendered from the revised edition (© 1919 Lindhardt og Ringhof; e-book, 2020). Because that Danish edition remains under the publisher's copyright, the Danish text is not reproduced alongside the translation; the Danish may be obtained from the publisher (see the catalog entry for a link). Page ranges given in the source correspond to the 1892 first edition and serve only as navigational aids. Høffding's own notes, printed as endnotes in the modern edition, are restored here to footnotes at their anchors. German titles and verse are left in the original; Greek is reproduced as printed.

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Introduction

It was a melancholy thought for Søren Kierkegaard that the time would come when he too would fall into “the Lecturer’s, the Professor’s” hand and be made an object of exposition. Indeed, he foresaw that this very melancholy thought would be lectured on as well. What he found repugnant in this was surely not the prospect of being made an object of criticism. Rather, it was something bound up very closely with his whole cast of thought. In the first place, he detested the “treacherous” admiration that comes afterwards, when the struggle is over, when renown has been won, and that whitewashes the prophet’s tomb—forgetting that it is in the relation of contemporaneity to what is great that it must show itself what sense and will one has to acknowledge it. His life’s work was to expose the self-deception in which we so easily entangle ourselves with respect to what he called “the historically corked-up Ideality.” But in the second place it was also one of his central thoughts that there is no continuous psychological and historical development. To exhibit a spiritual phenomenon—a thinker’s or an author’s activity—as a link in a development, as borne by definite inner and outer conditions and as bearing and conditioning the subsequent development: that, for him, was to drag it down, to rob it of its value. He would not be “set down in a Paragraph.”

If my attempt to give a characterization and an appraisal of this greatest thinker of our people should stand in need of a defense against his own protest, then I must first observe that I proceed from an entirely different conception of the relation between psychology and ethics than his. I hold the conviction that, just as those figures who stand before us with an ideal stamp arise under quite definite psychological and historical conditions, so their ideal significance—insofar as it is really present—is not weakened by their being seen in their definite limitation and conditionedness. On the contrary, the demonstration of this is absolutely necessary if the abiding value is to be distinguished from what is due only to transient and purely individual circumstances. And this holds not least of a thinker of so pronounced and singular a peculiarity as Søren Kierkegaard. If those who are to learn from him are themselves, or wish to be, personalities, they must first have *his* personal peculiarity determined, so that they can decide what, according to

their nature and under their circumstances, they can carry over from him. Precisely in consequence, then, of the great weight that Søren Kierkegaard has taught us to place on personal appropriation, on personal truth, we must undertake a psychological-historical and a critically examining treatment of his personality and activity.

And as for the fact that we easily come into a self-deceiving relation to the figures of the past, I must be permitted to make the personal confession that when I now (1890), after an interval of some twenty-odd years, have again taken up the study of Søren Kierkegaard's writings, I have once more had to experience the power he has to make us turn our gaze upon ourselves, to wound us by awakening a self-knowledge we are otherwise so inclined to avoid. There is a sting in these writings that no one who earnestly immerses himself in them will fail to feel, whatever presuppositions he may otherwise bring. To them applies a word from the book of Ecclesiastes that Søren Kierkegaard often uses in his journals and discourses: "Keep thy foot when thou goest to the house of the Lord!" His interpretation of this word was: You might easily come to learn that the ideal was higher, the demand stricter, than you had imagined; beware, therefore, lest you come to hear the ideal!—The presuppositions with which I now [1890] resumed the reading of these writings were, to be sure, very different from those with which, nearly 30 years ago, as a young theological student, I began my acquaintance with them. At that time they led me into inner struggles and conflicts, partly of a practical-personal, partly of a theoretical kind. After long reluctance I had to acknowledge his strict conception of the Christian as far more justified than the usual, idyllic and harmonious one. If Christianity is really to be one and all for us, in life as in faith, Søren Kierkegaard has drawn the consequences of it. For a time I tried to keep going by distinguishing between faith and knowledge and between ideal and reality. But I learned, more through personal life-experience than through study, that it was an impossibility to slip through in this way. The main decision had, after all, to be whether in my personal life, in my spiritual household, I could really say myself to be borne by supernatural help, and whether in my way of conducting my life I could be said to let myself be guided by the ideals and commands of religious ethics. Self-knowledge gradually gave me, after a long time of unrest and torment, a clear answer to this, which for me has been decisive for my whole life. Confining myself here to what concerns the public, I will remark that I was now led, through studies in the history of philosophy and investigations in the domains of psychology and ethics, to trace the conditions, forms, and laws of the human life of the spirit. I was led to see that "the Humane" is by no means, as Søren Kierkegaard says in one of his journals, merely evaporated Christianity, but that it denotes a view of life and a

conduct of life which—founded by the Greeks, deepened and inwardized by Christianity, expanded and clarified by the theoretical and practical labor of the modern age—cannot, to be sure, easily be summed up in brief formulas, but which nonetheless exercises its power even over those who combat it, just as its steady development is not hindered by transient excesses and caricatures. It is from this standpoint of humanism (if we must, after all, have a word ending in “-ism”) that I now look back on Kierkegaard’s activity. But for me it has been significant to see how valuable his appearance must be said to be even from this point of view. It is by no means with polemical intent that I have returned to him, although several views with which I have also otherwise collided appear in him with the clarity and consistency of genius, which makes it especially instructive to bring them forward. But in that, by the homage I can still bring the great thinker, I render my thanks for what he has given me for my personal development, I will at the same time bear witness that he can be much to many who stand far from him in faith. In that respect he does not cease to be our contemporary.—I hope it will be excused that I have here spoken so much about myself. My concern was to give a single example, the one nearest to me, of Søren Kierkegaard’s influence.

I. The Romantic-Speculative Philosophy of Religion

1. The nineteenth century began with a union of religion, philosophy, and art as the watchword in the world of spirit. People cherished an enthusiastic faith that truth was one, and that everything of value, in whatever domain and in whatever form it might appear, was comprised in this one truth, if only one immersed oneself in it with open sense. No barriers to thought—and yet preservation of harmony with religious feeling and with artistic imagination: that was the great idea that filled the leading thinkers in the first decades. They believed that in the strict form of thought they were only expressing what the newly awakening religious sense and the so mighty poetic urge, under other forms, lived and breathed in. The faith of the philosophers of religion was, in form and content, not very different from that which Faust expresses when Gretchen is anxious about how things stand with his religion. Faust expresses a feeling of infinity, inwardness, and fullness, awakened by life in nature and among human beings, and which cannot be summed up in any finite expression, nor exhausted in any name—»Name ist Schall und Rauch!« And Gretchen thinks:

So ungefähr sagt das Pfarrer auch,
Nur mit ein bischen anderen Worten.

These words might serve as a motto for the age's conception of the relation between faith and knowledge, as it appears—with characteristic and significant differences—in Schleiermacher and in Hegel.

2. Right at the century's beginning (1799) *Friedrich Schleiermacher* (b. 1768, d. 1834) published his »Reden über die Religion an die Gebildeten unter ihren Verächtern«. He here conceived of religion as an immediate consciousness that everything finite has its subsistence in and through an infinite, everything temporal in an eternal—not in such a way that the eternal and infinite falls outside the temporal and finite, but in such a

way that it is the latter's inner essence and soul. While in our knowing and our acting we direct ourselves toward the finite, the determinate and the limited, in order to grasp it or to change it, in our feeling we live a whole and undivided life, a universal life, in which opposition and limitation are annulled, and in which the one-sidedness that clings to every theoretical and practical striving falls away. Feeling is the domain of religion, because it is a life in the whole and the universal—because there announces itself in it that “instinct for the Universe” which is precisely one with religion. Every feeling, according to Schleiermacher, has a religious character when it is not morbid and corrupted. And as the religious feeling thus expresses itself not in opposition to, but as a deepening of, life in the world of experience, so the deity too stands not as a being separated from this world, but as its inner unity and its animating power. And immortality is not an existence that is to replace the present one, but consists in this: to feel, in the midst of time, the eternal within oneself.

Later Schleiermacher developed, in more theological form, his conception of religion in »Der christliche Glaube« (1821). He here determines the religious feeling as unconditioned feeling of dependence, and thereby establishes a moment of the greatest importance for religious psychology. It is, on the whole, Schleiermacher's fine psychological sense that gives his works their abiding significance. Both his earlier description of the religious feeling as universal feeling of unity, as a centralization of the life of feeling in relation to existence, and the later determination of it as feeling of dependence are valuable contributions to the psychology of religion, even if more precise determinations are necessary.

Dogma is for Schleiermacher always something derived, something secondary. Dogmatic propositions originally arose as expressions of the religious feeling. First this feeling gives itself air in poetic and rhetorical fashion; the forms of expression thus arising are then developed in the form of doctrine, as confessions. And since the poetic expressions often had to come into apparent conflict with one another, even where the feeling that lay at their basis was in reality the same, a reflective and dialectical treatment became necessary in order to bring about full clarity. Through these intermediate stages the dogmatic propositions came into being, and their validity and significance are therefore different from such propositions as are won by a purely theoretical or philosophical route. Schleiermacher wishes to carry through a definite separation between the doctrine of faith and philosophy, a separation he supports by his theory of knowledge (which we know from the unfinished »Dialektik«, published after his death), which critically demonstrates the limits of knowledge and holds a place open for an

immediate feeling-relation to the deity, of whose essence theoretical thinking, in his view, can form no concluded concept.

By this fine and spirited conception Schleiermacher placed himself in definite opposition to the two dominant tendencies of the age, orthodoxy and rationalism. He rejected the former's external literalism and the latter's superficial explaining-away. His work has an abiding significance for the philosophy of religion, and he stands as the greatest thinker theology can show beside Augustine and Zwingli.

3. But Schleiermacher did not want to be merely a free religious thinker; he wanted to present ecclesiastical theology and believed he could do so from his standpoint. Here he was caught in a great illusion and sacrifices at the altar of the age; for of his personal love of truth there is, despite all that orthodox and radical fanatics have thought, no doubt. He was the most Socratic personality in the philosophy of that time. A rare sense for individualities and a strong feeling of the right and significance of the individual mark his life, as we know it through a rich and interesting collection of letters, and animate his thinking. But he did not see that on such a standpoint an ecclesiastical theologian cannot place himself. The Church as a historical community rests on the assumption of revelation as objective fact, as the absolute and adequate expression of the eternal truth, and therefore comes forward with a claim to unconditional authority over the feeling-life of individuals. For Schleiermacher the dogmas in reality became only symbols, the standard subjective, and from his standpoint there is only one step to Ludwig Feuerbach's, for whom theology is only psychology. Symbols cannot be imposed; they must be freely chosen or produced, and they can be changed without the underlying feeling therefore needing to change. But the Church cannot concede this in the case of its dogmas; for then the very concept of revelation would fall away. For Schleiermacher even God's personality was only a symbolic representation! But if, with respect to all religious representations, a fundamental distinction is to be made between image and reality, then thereby positive religion is abolished, which in any case must, on certain points, maintain that truth has entered the world in its whole fullness and in its adequate form.

And on closer inspection it appears at the same time that the very determination of the religious feeling (both in its older form, as feeling of unity, and in its later form, as feeling of dependence) presupposes several theoretical presuppositions—more philosophy, that is—than Schleiermacher is aware of. The religious feeling has, in his conception, a harmonious character. It is precisely the feeling through which all disharmony, one-sidedness, imperfection, and sin is overcome. The feeling of dependence takes on, in the

end, the character of trust and enthusiasm. But thereby an optimistic and harmonious view of the world is presupposed. It is presupposed that there are no experiences that could bring about a wholly different total-mood toward existence, or in any case give the religious feeling a less harmonious stamp. In Schopenhauer and Søren Kierkegaard the opposition to the romantic, harmonizing conception appears on this point as energetically as can be conceived.

It is, on the whole, characteristic of the development in the domain of spiritual, and especially religious, life in our century that the oppositions grow ever sharper as time advances. The century begins with harmony and reconciliation, but the splitting and division is consummated with increasing emphasis. Schleiermacher did not live to see the radical sharpening that came with Strauss and Feuerbach, whose forerunner he himself is—partly through his critical investigations of the New Testament writings (which led him, among other things, to reject on historical grounds the authenticity of the first letter to Timothy and of the accounts of Jesus' birth), partly through his psychological method. He did, however, live to feel the sharpening on the orthodox wing. When in the year 1821 he published for the third time his "Discourses on Religion to the Educated among its Despisers," he wrote in the preface "that the times had changed so strikingly that the persons to whom these discourses are addressed no longer seem to exist at all, but that when one looked about among the educated, one would rather find it necessary to write discourses to mopers and slaves of the letter, to superstitious people who show both their ignorance and their unkindness by the manner in which they condemn others."—The times had changed, and they were to change still more.

4. Alongside Schleiermacher, and in a polemical posture toward him, there worked at the University of Berlin in the twenties another philosopher of religion who expresses the age's craving for harmony between faith and knowledge to an even higher degree than he. This was *Hegel* (b. 1770, d. 1831). What distinguished this thinker—whose writings¹ abstract form makes it difficult for most present-day readers to penetrate to what he has of really significant in his ideas—was his great sense for the unity of spiritual life under all its different forms and at all its different stages. Since he now saw in human spiritual life a form of the revelation of an eternal world-spirit, it became possible for him to sketch an idealistic doctrine of development, within whose framework he ranged—often with great arbitrariness and with more or less spirited reinterpretation—everything that his rich

¹Hegel's philosophy of religion is most fully presented in the work published after his death, »Philosophie der Religion«; but in his »Encyclopädie der philosophischen Wissenschaften« (1817) it is already stated in more concise form. Most easily accessible, perhaps, is his conception of Christianity in »Philosophie der Geschichte«.

learning placed at his disposal from the various domains. Since the divine expresses itself at all stages of existence and in all forms, Hegel acknowledges no absolute oppositions. All differences and oppositions are moments in the development, which serve to give it fullness of content and energy, but which are themselves continually annulled and united in a higher unity. Through the continual positing and annulling of oppositions the development of the world proceeds. It is in a certain sense the effect of contrast that is for Hegel the fundamental phenomenon illuminating existence. It shows us, indeed, how the oppositions call one another forth and cannot be separated. A higher stage or a higher form of existence is, on the Hegelian conception, characterized by the fact that oppositions have been run through and have deposited their result in a new form of unity. Mediation, the equalization and annulling of oppositions (or, as Hegel incorrectly calls them, contradictions), became the watchword for Hegel's adherents. To remain standing in a relation of opposition was a sign that one was caught in the finite and external; the point was to reach the higher unity, to unite the oppositions of existence in harmony.—An ingenious idea and a great goal! But from the general idea to the special theoretical and practical execution the way is long, and Hegel and his adherents all too often confused the program with the execution.

The relation between philosophy and religion was, according to Hegel, this: that they have the same content, only that philosophy expresses this content in the language of abstract thought, while religion expresses it in the language of feeling and imagination. The difference is thus only a difference of form, which is not to touch the essential. What the believer conceives as historical events—e.g. the creation of the world, God's becoming man in Christ, and so on—are for philosophy eternal truths and laws that hold for all times. The Christian doctrine of the suffering god is thus for philosophy not the expression of a single series of historical events; rather its essential content—which only philosophy grasps in its clear, adequate form—is the truth that the infinite and divine stirs in the finite world, while yet every finite form is imperfect and must be shattered. It is, then, only through the continual perishing of finite forms that the infinite unfolds itself in the world. Only in the infinite process of ever new and ever again perishing forms of life does the eternal life of the deity consist.—

Already from this one example it becomes clear that Hegel, just as much as Schleiermacher, in reality makes the dogmas into symbols, only that with him they become symbols for general ideas, not for subjective feelings. It rested, then, with Hegel as with Schleiermacher on an illusion when he believed he had reconciled faith and knowledge. But it was Hegel's definite conviction that nothing of essential significance was lost

by the content of faith being transposed into philosophical form; on the contrary, he believed that only then did it really become the property of the human spirit. He did not see what Strauss and Feuerbach first sharply demonstrated—that the transposition really meant a transition to a wholly different view of life and the world than that which is characteristic of positive religion, especially of Christianity, of which of course there is here first and foremost question. The whole relation between Christianity and humanity Hegel conceived, like Schleiermacher, as a harmonious relation. Romantic optimism is characteristic of both.

5. But even purely philosophically and humanly there was a misgiving that had to come forward in the face of the Hegelian philosophy's fundamental thought of the unity of oppositions. Even if there should be a higher unity in which all the oppositions of existence find their reconciliation, we are, as existing beings, in the midst of this world of oppositions, far from this unity. The surge of the oppositions raises us and lowers us; we are dependent on experience, we run up against barriers both in our thinking and in our acting, our horizon is limited, and we often end in problematic results or run our head against the wall; *for us*, therefore, that unity is an unattainable ideal, and the reconciliation it contains is only for the imagination, or for faith. This essential point—the difference between metaphysics on the one hand, psychology and ethics on the other—Hegel overlooked, and therein lay his greatest philosophical error. The consequence was that he, and still more his adherents, often confused the purely abstract and logical establishing of the connection of oppositions —e.g. of opposed standpoints—with an overcoming of the oppositions through real work, or, in the ethical domain, through really having *lived* them, having practically attained a reconciliation of the opposed tendencies between which life moves. Add to this that, so long as life lasts, ever new oppositions, and thereby new problems, come forward; “the higher unity” cannot therefore be won once and for all. The theory of the unity of oppositions thus sets up an ideal, but does not give us a real possession. It was Hegel's great error that his endeavor, to use his own words, aimed at “rewriting the ideal into a system.” Thereby he came (as not only his philosophy of religion, but also his ethics and theory of the state show) to violate the right both of reality and of the ideal.

Søren Kierkegaard's opposition to Hegel acquires no small significance through the sharp and penetrating manner in which he attacked this main point in the Hegelian philosophy. And it must be well noted that we are here not confronted with the ideas of a single philosopher. On the contrary, the Hegelian doctrine on this point is really of a typical kind. It represents—in its best meaning—a natural striving, which human spiritual

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life can at no time give up, after finding connection and harmony, after winning by its own powers mastery and survey over life. And—in its more superficial application—it represents a fantasy-relation to existence, an aesthetic-contemplative attitude toward problems, crises, and oppositions, which one lets unfold as an interesting spectacle, by whose conflicts one feels oneself untouched, regarding oneself as the realized “higher unity.”—Even in its best meaning, however, this system—in which the romantic movement from the century’s beginning was clarified in abstract form—stood in need of a serious reaction, one that in practice and theory laid an accent on reality in its definite concrete and individual character. And in that Søren Kierkegaard brings this reaction, as energetically as could be wished, into the ethico-religious domain, he brings it at the same time in a manner that can act as a standing resistance against similar tendencies in human nature, such as later times too present.

Goethe’s Faust, moreover, had already here expressed what was at stake. When in Nostradamus’ book he sees the symbol of the universe, he first exclaims enthusiastically:

Wie Alles sich zum Ganzen webt,
Eins in dem Andern wirkt und lebt!

—but he soon becomes melancholy that this unity of oppositions is not given in the form of reality:

Welch Schauspiel! Aber ach! ein Schauspiel nur!

Søren Kierkegaard conceived it precisely as his life’s task to impress what the preceding romantic-speculative generation had forgotten: that life is something other and more than a spectacle for us.

I. The Romantic-Speculative Philosophy of Religion: Søren Kierkegaard as Philosopher

II. Søren Kierkegaard's Older Contemporaries in Denmark

1. Johan Ludvig Heiberg (1791–1860) was the apostle of Hegelian philosophy in Denmark.² He first spoke up for it in a treatise from 1825, which was a contribution to the deterministic controversy raised by Howitz. Later he applied it especially to aesthetic and theological subjects. He found in Hegel's philosophy an expression of the same thing that Goethe strove for in his view of life and in his poetry. "Hegel's system," he says (*Om Filosofiens Betydning for den nærværende Tid*. Copenhagen 1833, p. 48), "is the same as Goethe's. That two such great minds should at the same time have arrived at the same result cannot but awaken a favorable impression of the result. . . . To characterize the Hegelian philosophy in a few words, one may say that it, like Goethean poetry, reconciles the ideal with reality, our demands with what we possess, our wishes with what has been attained." As for the relation between religion and philosophy in particular, Heiberg expressed himself about it not only in his treatises and in his journal *Perseus*, but also in his great philosophical poems, which are surely the finest of what our literature possesses in this direction. It is Hegel's fundamental thought that he expresses when it is said, in the Reformation cantata, that "Thought ascended to the heights at the very moment it descended into itself." For it is by thought's own path, by thinking's clear elucidation of its own nature, that (according to Hegel) the same ideas are to be found which constitute the essential content of religion. To be sure, there is a great difference in the form: religion, at its immediate stage, commands images and symbols, beside whose splendor of color the forms of thought might seem poor and paltry. But Heiberg consoles us in "Protestantism in Nature," the poem in which he has perhaps reached highest:

Turn your gaze toward your inner self!

²A more detailed treatment of this chapter's subject I have given later in my book *Danske Filosofer* (1909).

What perished in your world
 you will find within your thought.
 All that vanished, in there,
 gained life and existence.

What has vanished is the outer, perceptible form, which the childlike imagination misses, and with which it believes all is lost. But for Heiberg, just as little as for Hegel, does anything go lost. He saw it as peculiar to “the present age” that it wished to *know* what former ages had felt and believed; but this was, in his opinion, “so far from wanting to make an end of feeling and faith that, on the contrary, it wants to consolidate them; for only when we know that they contain the truth can we surrender ourselves to them undisturbed.”—This conception, however, aroused misgivings among the theologians, and it was not in this clear and resolute form that speculative philosophy of religion managed to win wider assent here at home. It first had to undergo a dogmatic modification of a peculiar kind.

2. *Hans Martensen* (1808–1884) felt himself, already as a young man, strongly drawn to Hegel’s forms of thought, which seemed to him to open the possibility of a knowledge of the divine, while Schleiermacher, who at the same time influenced him strongly, in the end let the speculative problems lie. When Schleiermacher, during his visit to Copenhagen the year before his death, was one day walking with the young promising theological graduate, the latter asked him “quite naively” (see *Martensens Levned* I, p. 69) whether he believed that a knowledge of “God’s essence in itself, of the inner eternal life-process in God” was possible. Schleiermacher answered quite calmly: “Ich halte es für eine Täuschung.” But the young theologian’s speculative enthusiasm would not be damped by the old master’s warning. Hegel’s forms of thought enticed him, though he could not remain standing at Hegel, who was too abstractly logical for him. He no doubt also sensed that, carried through consistently, the dogmas could for Hegel, as for Schleiermacher, become only symbols. He credited himself with the power to reach something even greater than these thinkers had considered attainable: he wanted to reconcile faith and knowledge in such a way that he retained the forms of both! Characteristic of Martensen was a union of mysticism and imaginative vision with thinking—that is, a thinking that strove to bring about a certain coherence among the images that thrust themselves forward before the imagination as moved by the temperament. His ideal was the old mystics and theosophists; it was in the tracks of Meister Eckhart and Jakob Böhme that he wished to walk. Of contemporary thinkers he most admired the Catholic philosopher Franz Baader, who likewise wished precisely to renew Jakob Böhme’s

philosophy. His distance from Hegel he expressed early, in a critique of one of Heiberg's treatises (*Maanedsskrift for Litteratur* 1836) and in his dissertation on "The Autonomy of Self-Consciousness in Christian Dogmatics" (1837). Against Hegel he objected above all to the impossibility of thinking without presuppositions. The human being has not, after all, created himself, but is posited by God—and thus has God as his presupposition, his authority. In virtue of the dogma of creation, not independence (autonomy), but dependence on God (theonomy), must become the watchword. The task must become: speculation on the basis of faith. Earnest must be made of the old saying that the fear of God is the beginning of wisdom. Later (in his dogmatics) he expressed this by saying that the doctrine of faith as a science was possible only for the consciousness reborn by faith and grace.

One cannot deny Martensen an eye for the fact that his higher science required a good many presuppositions; whereas it may well cause surprise that he did not ask himself of what value a "science" is that rests on so many and such enormous presuppositions. But the young theologian was enthusiastic, and enthusiastic became those who heard him. People reckoned "a new era" from his appearance and expected a golden age of theology. In his lectures on the history of recent philosophy he first led his hearers to Hegel's philosophy as the necessary result of the development of thought; and when they were impressed by this, there came astonishment and admiration to the second power when he showed them the necessity and possibility of a higher standpoint—beyond the greatest thinker of the age! In his dogmatics he led his hearers, and later his readers, from dogma to dogma without any decisive difficulty halting them. Trinity, incarnation, atonement are presented as a series of images of great events in the world of spirit, often accompanied by spirited and profound remarks, but in such a way that every sting for thought is taken away. That must come, presumably, from the rebirth. Only at one point does the dogmatic thinker halt, without even his reborn consciousness being able to clear the matter up for him: it is at the question of eternal damnation. Here he finds—to the honor of his feeling of humanity, though not to the honor of his orthodoxy—a stumbling-block for thought.

Philosophically, Martensen has, in the first place, offended against the truth that thinking always needs presuppositions. He has not seen that these presuppositions are always sought to be reduced to the least possible, and that they are then (in the theory of knowledge) sought to be demonstrated in their origin from human nature. We construct only those presuppositions that are necessary in order to understand the reality given in experience, and whose basis in human nature can be established.— And

in the second place, he has never shed any light on how it actually comes about that the difficulties the dogmas present to the natural consciousness fall away for the reborn consciousness. Does one then get a different logic when one is reborn? And in that case, would it not be of importance to have this higher logic set forth? Or should the whole difference perhaps be that one no longer thinks? And is it, then, so easy to cease thinking, to take reason captive? At any rate there came one who, on this point, felt the most painful contradiction, the most passionate collision between different forces, and who felt himself deeply outraged by this attempt at a “higher” scientificity.

Seen from the religious point of view, the misgiving had to be this: whether, after having obtained the presuppositions in question, one now really also has the time, the desire, and the strength for speculation? For it might be that those presuppositions were of such a kind that they had to be acquired ever anew, that the appropriation could not take place once and for all, and that the ever-renewed problem of appropriation made “the high unity” impossible—even in the form in which Martensen, in his arrogant attempt to outbid Hegel, had conceived it.

3. It was German speculative philosophy that, with Heiberg and Martensen, made its entry among us. But already before Søren Kierkegaard made his mighty attack on this tendency, it had met able and well-grounded resistance among Danish thinkers. Just as Treschow, at the century’s beginning, had by his sober critical thinking and his sound psychology counteracted the obscurities of Schellingian philosophy, so already in the thirties *Frederik Christian Sibbern* (1785–1872) came forward with a penetrating critique of Hegelian philosophy. Sibbern was, by his innermost nature and by his whole development, unreceptive to a philosophy that wished to spin everything out of itself, and that by its speculative abstractions came into a relation of remoteness from life. Characteristic of him in this last respect is a trait he himself relates. “I remember that Søren Kierkegaard once, in his Hegelian period, met me on Gammeltorv and asked me: what relation there was between philosophy and life in reality? The question startled me, since all my philosophy aimed at studying life and reality; but afterwards I certainly had to become aware that for a Hegelianized thinker the question was natural, since the Hegelians did not study philosophy existentially.”

For Sibbern, thinking always had to have a given, a factual basis. Philosophy must be *explicative*—that is, must make clear and distinct the content presented in given experience—before it can become *speculative*, that is: set up its further-reaching hypotheses on this basis. And to this was added that Sibbern, in the interesting philosophy of development on which he early entered, conceived existence as a great process, or a

system of processes, proceeding from many different starting points. It is the *sporadic* character of development that he especially emphasizes. Since the knower is himself one of these many starting points, and is himself placed in one of these sporadic processes of development, he cannot possibly survey the whole. Although we are links in the universal existence, and its innermost essence must therefore stir in us as well, still we cannot from our vantage point form a closed image of the whole life of the world.

It was therefore firmly grounded in Sibbern's whole philosophical outlook when he came forward with a *Critique of Hegelian Philosophy* (1838), directed especially against Heiberg—a work that contains many sound and able thoughts and does Danish philosophy honor.—That he here called Heiberg a philosophical dilettante caused Heiberg, some years later in “A Soul after Death,” to have Sibbern's writings belong to the library in hell.

Sibbern's philosophy of religion held that the religious content should be taken like any other given content of experience. The point was to live oneself into it and find its value and validity. He was equally opposed to the rationalistic or speculative transposition of living, personal faith into abstract concept, and to the orthodox assertion of the dogmas as outer, objective truths. It was, at first, the opposition to the aridity of rationalism's understanding that determined Sibbern's position here. But as the years went by, he felt himself more and more repelled by the orthodox tendency, and he began to doubt how far the religious content could really be called *given* in the same sense as the experiences that science takes as its basis. A definite critical attitude toward positive religious faith comes forward in Sibbern in a series of remarkable university programs from 1846–1849. It was not so much historical criticism that brought him to doubt how much, in the religious domain, was really *given*, as it was a psychological conviction that what one took to be original expressions of religious emotion could not be immediate outpourings of personal experience, but had to be due to a more composite development, in which manifold traditions and reflections had intervened. He was, on the whole, led more and more away from the objective and historical side of religion to the inner personal life, which is its source of life. And in that he now connected with this his significant thought that all development proceeds sporadically, from individual starting points, he demanded that the right of subjectivity be acknowledged. The aging thinker consistently carried through here what his younger friend, Søren Kierkegaard, had already some years before developed: that subjectivity is the truth—only that he does not, with Kierkegaard, ground it merely on the necessity of personal appropriation, but lays the weight especially on this, that it is in the individual personalities, each for

itself, that the real spiritual life stirs, and that one would stop up these springs of life by imposing on all a common form of view of life.

That Sibbern did not act more strongly on his contemporaries was connected especially with his lacking the ability to shape his thoughts in an easily accessible and condensed form. His expositions suffer from prolixity and from various peculiarities, which stood hinderingly in the way of the proper appreciation of the significance of this remarkable personality.³

4. A younger friend and colleague of Sibbern, the poet and philosopher *Poul Møller* (1794–1838), must be especially remembered when the talk is of Søren Kierkegaard's older contemporaries, since he was the one who stood in the closest personal relation to Kierkegaard. Poul Møller had for a time been strongly occupied with Hegel's philosophy, but later placed himself (as is seen from his treatise on the possibility of proofs for immortality) critically toward it. As a university teacher he worked most through his lectures on the history of philosophy. He had, as is seen from his "Stray Thoughts" (*Strøtanker*), his eye open to the personal side of philosophizing; he kept not merely to the objective content of the philosophical theories, but went back from this content to the philosophizing personality. In his draft of a treatise on affectation, Poul Møller's sense for the significance of personal truth expresses itself especially in a characteristic way. It seems to me that here is something that gives him an interesting position as Søren Kierkegaard's forerunner. In reading these drafts one comes to sense what the continual conversations between Poul Møller and Søren Kierkegaard had turned upon.

Affectation is, according to Poul Møller, a combination of falseness and self-deception. It arises through one's wanting to be what by one's nature one cannot be, and therefore imagining to oneself and to others that one is other than one really is. "The affected person does on purpose what has no significance except where it is called forth by the power and prompting of nature or by a higher necessity." But Poul Møller has a clear eye for the fact that it is something which, by the nature of circumstances, is not to be avoided at certain stages of development. For when the personality is to be developed and expanded, it must necessarily overstep its limits and take foreign matter into itself, without at once being able to make this foreign matter its own real property. Thereby a momentary affectation arises as a point of transition. Affectation becomes fixed when one consistently carries through the foreign principle, although it cannot take root in one's personality. Moral feeling, self-regard, and immorality alike can in this way be shells in which one hides oneself from oneself and others, taking pleasure in them

³A detailed characterization of Sibbern's personality and of his cast of thought I have given in *Mindre Arbejder*. First Series, pp. 61–112.

without, however, really filling them out. The use of terminologies without insight into the corresponding thoughts, and exaggerated symmetry in a scientific system, are more theoretical forms of the same thing.

Poul Møller goes so far in his assertion of the importance of agreement between the inner and the outer that he declares that “no expression of life has truth unless there lies in it a creative self-activity.” He advances this proposition with full awareness that it stands as a paradox. For how much truth, indeed, will there be in the world if we are true only in what we ourselves bring forth? But he holds the conviction that in the falsely assumed, and in the objective common stamp, there is a great danger to the originality and richness of life. “Affectation most often comes from one’s not having the strength to fall out with the world in order to show one’s personality true... Everyone has by nature his deep stamp, but lets it be effaced in order to please others.—He will not come forward with his own person, does not believe in his person’s infinite depth. If each individual man, without fearing the reproach of simplicity, judged of things just as they presented themselves to him, then glorious phenomena would come forth.”—

On his deathbed Poul Møller sent, through Sibbern, a greeting to Søren Kierkegaard. The three men belong together by kinship of thought. The idea of personal truth and its significance they have all three grasped, though only one of them was able to develop it in its whole force and rigor. And a great sympathy did Søren Kierkegaard feel for his two teachers.—In the introduction to the “Posthumous Papers” (*Efterladte Papirer*) the following is told. “One of his somewhat younger schoolfellows has related how he once, weighed down by heavy thoughts, met Søren Kierkegaard in Frederiksberg Garden. ‘Without, moreover, any words being exchanged about the mood that oppressed me,’ the account runs, ‘Søren Kierkegaard suddenly stepped up to me and asked, with a look and voice in which sympathy trembled, whether I knew Professor Sibbern? *Him* I should turn to; *that* was a *whole* man; he was amiability itself, and in intercourse with him there was something calming.’ ”—As for Poul Møller, Kierkegaard gave vent to his enthusiasm for him in the dedication to his memory in *Begrebet Angest* [The Concept of Anxiety]: “The late Professor Poul Martin Møller, the happy lover of Greek culture, admirer of Homer, confidant of Socrates, interpreter of Aristotle—Denmark’s joy in the joy over Denmark, though ‘far traveled’ always ‘remembered in the Danish summer’—my admiration, my loss—to him this writing is consecrated.”

This dedication indicates at the same time that Poul Møller introduced and guided Kierkegaard in the study of the Greeks, which became so significant for him. It means, on the whole, much in Kierkegaard’s mouth when he calls his late teacher the confidant

II. Søren Kierkegaard's Older Contemporaries: Heffding Søren Kierkegaard as Philosopher

of Socrates. There lies in it a hint of a very essential spiritual connection between the two men, of which people have not always been aware.

III. Søren Kierkegaard's Personality

1. There are thoughts that can grow up only in a certain definite kind of soil and in a certain kind of air. And there is no doubt that Søren Kierkegaard's thoughts belong among them. They are like the wine that can grow only on volcanic ground. This ground, then, we must first and foremost learn to know. And the ground lies deep. We are directed back beyond himself to his family and his race, and to the traditions that formed the spiritual atmosphere of his childhood.—For the validity or invalidity of the thoughts, such a demonstration is not decisive. Whatever peculiar conditions their development may be due to, they can in themselves be equally valuable. It might well be that especially valuable thoughts can grow up only under *such* conditions! But these conditions must be brought out and known when the question of the thoughts' vital force under other conditions is to be decided.—

2. His family stems from West Jutland. In the West Jutland race there is found, alongside tenacity, shrewdness, and humor, also no small propensity to melancholy and weariness of life.

On the heath in Sæding parish near Ringkøbing, in the year 1768 a twelve-year-old “herd-boy” walked with his sheep. He endured hunger and cold and was oppressed by loneliness and forsakenness. Then in his despair he went up onto a hill and cursed the God who had given him this wretched life.—This boy was Søren Kierkegaard's father. In a journal entry from 1847 (*Søren Kierkegaards Papirer*, edited by P. A. Heiberg and V. Kuhr, seventh volume) the following passage is found:

“The terrible thing about the man who once, as a little boy tending sheep on the Jutland heath, suffered much evil, hungered and was famished, stood up on a hill and cursed God—and that man was not able to forget it when he was 82 years old.”

When the first editor of Kierkegaard's papers showed Søren Kierkegaard's brother, Bishop P. C. Kierkegaard, this passage, the old bishop burst into tears and said: “That is

our father's history, and ours too!" (H. P. Barfod's biography of Bishop Kierkegaard in *Illustreret Tidende* 1888). In the history of the Kierkegaard family that event plays a great role, both as effect and as cause. It stands as an outflow of the heavy temperament that felt everything more strongly and deeply than others, and of the passion that drove every mood and every thought out to its utmost consequence. But it also comes to stand as a threatening symbol, which set the dark temperament in ever new motion and awakened the thought of the God who visits the sins of the fathers upon the children.

The boy from the heath, Michael Pedersen Kierkegaard, was sent to Copenhagen and apprenticed to a hosier. He worked his way up to becoming a rich man, but never forgot that moment on the heath in which he believed he had committed a sin against the Holy Spirit. His melancholy dread often gave itself vent in despairing words, and it then stamped the life of the home with its darkness, although he was otherwise a mentally lively man who in wit and acumen could hold his own with his highly gifted sons. Already in his fortieth year he had withdrawn from trade and lived thereafter occupied mostly with philosophical reading; he especially studied the German philosopher Wolff eagerly.—For the understanding of the following characterization of Søren Kierkegaard, it must be noted that other hereditary influences made themselves felt than those stemming from the melancholy, brooding father. The mother is described as a nice little woman with an even and contented temperament. A contrast that is not rare, and that recalls the one between Goethe's parents, where likewise "des Lebens ernstes Führen" derived from the father, "die Frohnatur" from the mother. To be sure, the opposite elements appeared in Søren Kierkegaard in a far more contentious and contrasting way than in that grand master of life's harmony.

The younger son, *Søren Aabye Kierkegaard*, was born in Copenhagen on 5 May 1813. Of his outward life there is not much to relate, and yet, when one day all the posthumous papers are available, an interesting biography of him will be able to be written—so true is it that the essential in life, for a nature like his, is not the outward events. In Georg Brandes' book on Søren Kierkegaard a brilliant characterization of his literary personality is given. Something has here been accomplished that cannot be done over. But I believe that Brandes, precisely because his eye was directed especially toward S. Kierkegaard's literary activity, has come to lay *too* great weight on individual events in his life, which certainly became motives and themes in his production, but were not wholly decisive for the direction of his spirit. And neither can I agree with Brandes that piety and contempt were S. Kierkegaard's two fundamental passions. In my view they occupy a more subordinate place in his psychology.—It must, however, be noted,

especially with regard to this last point, that when Brandes wrote his book, only the first two volumes of the "posthumous papers" had appeared.⁴

3. The most decisive element for Søren Kierkegaard's whole personality must be sought in his melancholy, as it lay in his race and in his temperament and was nourished by his upbringing. "I am not a human being; I am melancholy to the very border of insanity," he says (1849) in his notes, where he gives an account of his circumstances of life. It was melancholy that lay at the basis of his great piety and of his reverence for all authority. It brought with it a need for absolute points of support and a shyness before the confusion of the new. He needed something that could hold him up when everything seemed to dissolve for him into a bottomless darkness. Only when such an absolute ground had been laid could other sides of his nature, especially his great dialectical urge, unfold freely and powerfully. In religious respects this led to his sharp reflection and criticism being applied only to the question of the appropriation of the religious content, not to the testing of the inner coherence and validity of this content itself. And the feeling of contempt that could stir in him is also easily understood from the consequences of melancholy for his inner life. Accustomed as he was to walking between abysses and terrors, ordinary, "lightly living" people had to make a strange impression on him, just as melancholy itself had to lead him to picture people's conduct and their motives in more unfavorable colors than real experience warranted. But contempt was not an original element in his nature. Rather there was in him a heartfelt compassion—understandable also from the melancholy—with people, especially with those who suffer, or whom he believed to be suffering. From several sides it is attested that he had a remarkable eye for whether something pained those he was together with, and that he knew how to soften and console in a manner as considerate and delicate as no one else. He not only found comfort and relief in going about and talking with common folk in the street, but felt a heartfelt compassion with them and knew how to enter into their affairs. And even at the last, when his conception of Christianity sharpened, and when he felt the hour drawing near when the ideal was to be asserted in all its rigor, he was for a while held back by compassion with the happiness he was to disturb, with the unrest and suffering he was to cause where hitherto a mild and harmonious conception of life had prevailed.

It is naturally impossible to derive the various qualities and tendencies of a human being, especially of a richly endowed one, from a single cause. Such people, whose significance rests precisely on their coming to make spiritual experiences that most

⁴The first edition of Kierkegaard's papers was undertaken by H. P. Barfod and the Swiss theologian Gottsched. A new, critical edition is now being undertaken by P. A. Heiberg and V. Kuhr. I cite according to this edition, so far as it is available.

people are spared or miss, will have in their nature several different starting points, several elements between which they must struggle to bring harmony. The tasks they have to solve are first and foremost set them by their own nature.

Alongside melancholy as the dominant element there has already been named a power of thought, an ability for dialectical work, for dismembering reflection. As he himself expresses it (1849): "Bound in agonizing misery, like a bird whose wings have been clipped, so am I, while I have yet retained all the power of my spirit, that no doubt extraordinary power." Not only in reflection and thinking did this power express itself, but also in an imagination that at every vibration, every flash of mood, could throw out images in full splendor and with striking life, and in an art of language such as had scarcely yet been seen in Danish literature. Favorably situated in outward respects, he could develop these mental powers according to his own pleasure. The use of these powers has, like the use of every natural force, been bound up with pleasure; it was for him an independent need to employ them, even if they were mainly employed in the service of the prevailing moods.

In his work "On My Work as an Author" (*Om Synspunktet for min Forfattervirksomhed*) Kierkegaard attributes to himself, alongside "the enormous melancholy," an "equally enormous facility for concealing it under apparent cheerfulness and joy of life." By this remark he certainly brings—as, on the whole, in the retrospect on his authorial activity—more system and deliberateness into his conduct than there really was. Alongside melancholy there lay an element of a wholly opposite nature, an urge to give oneself over to all kinds of high-spirited play, to let oneself go in wit and other trials of intellectual strength—an urge that naturally connected itself with the urge to use his mental power. According to the characterization his headmaster gave of him, after the old custom, at his transition to the university, the childlikeness is said to have persisted long in him; he had, it appears, a great love of freedom and independence, and his character was lively and cheerful. The same impression others got of him later in life. It cannot, at first, have been dissimulation. There was in him an involuntary tendency in this direction, a tendency that under a different upbringing might have been developed so as to have a happy influence on his character. As it now expressed itself, when melancholy withdrew, or as a contrast-effect of it, it could in fact become a cover for the closed-off-ness of melancholy; but deliberately produced it cannot have been. It was surely the same with this as with his eager and constant roaming about the streets, which he later also presented as part of a thought-out plan, but which at first too was an outflow of an urge for movement, for people, and for changing impressions.

"I am a Janus bifrons—with the one face I laugh, with the other I weep," he writes at 24 years of age. Neither of these faces was assumed, even though the one came out most before others, the other in solitude. For it is the nature of melancholy to withdraw when others are present, just as the dwarfs vanish when the sun rises. This property of melancholy was precisely what made it so fateful an element in Søren Kierkegaard's personality. It was its working to make solitary, to produce isolation and render openness toward others impossible, that became decisive for his fate. The dull grief made him mute—but is it not a sin not to be able to open oneself to those nearest one, not to be able to give oneself inwardly? And do not, at any rate, the most intimate relations of communal life become impossible where such an isolating melancholy prevails? When it is told that Jesus drove out a devil, and it was mute—then Søren Kierkegaard explained this as grief, melancholy, which in its egoism, in order not to lose its dominion over the person, makes him mute, draws him out of connection with others. And herewith there was now set for him an enormous problem in his own inner life: was it insanity or sin that thus possessed him? "It is and remains the heaviest tribulation when a person does not know whether the ground of his suffering is insanity or sin." Here was something that could well set the brooding dialectic in motion. Streams of thought and series of images could develop from the one of the possible points of view, only suddenly to vanish before new series of representations from the other point of view—especially when there was now added to this the emphasis produced by the strictly orthodox upbringing and by the memory of how the father's melancholy had even led him to curse God.

In *Stages on Life's Way* the relation between father and son is depicted: "There was once a father and a son. A son is like a mirror in which the father sees himself, and for the son again the father is like a mirror in which he sees himself in the time to come. Yet they seldom regarded each other thus, for the cheerfulness of a lively, animated conversation was their daily intercourse. Only a few times did it happen that the father stopped, stood before the son with a sorrowful countenance, regarded him and said: Poor child, you are going about in a quiet despair. Nothing further was ever said about how this was to be understood, how true it nevertheless was."—In the posthumous papers Kierkegaard expresses himself far more definitely and sharply about how the father "unloaded all his melancholy onto a poor child," how his father made him unhappy and robbed him of his childhood. "The joy of being a child I have indeed never had." And it is surely also grounded in his own experience when he says: "It is a rape, however well-meant it may be, to force the child's existence into the decisive Christian categories" (*Concluding Unscientific Postscript*).

Kierkegaard's youthful years (from 22 to 25) have been illuminated by the complete publication of his papers and by the investigations an energetic Kierkegaard-scholar has undertaken on their basis.⁵ It appears that there was a period in Kierkegaard's youth that may be called the period of dissipation. He was carried beyond the boundary of what he considered right and pure, and the memory of this has ever since stood as a black spot in his life. When he tried to explain to himself how such a fall was possible, he emphasizes the demonically alluring power of foreboding and dread. The human being stands before evil as before an abyss; a dizziness can seize him at the mere thought of the possibility of casting himself out. Already in 1837 the view of dread is expressed in the notes which he later developed in detail in *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844). It appears thus that there lies personal experience behind the whole series of reflections on this concept that are found in his works. And when in a note from 1837 he warns against awakening in children, by allusions, suspicion, and untimely warnings, representations of the possibility of evil, and thereby "kindling the tinder that is in every soul," he is surely thinking of his own upbringing and of stray remarks of his father. When even the venerable figure he looked up to with admiration for piety and firmness of character turned out to suffer from inner unrest, perhaps to brood over secrets and in any case to know terrible possibilities, this had to work on the son's mind like an "earthquake." And the background of melancholy that in the father lay behind the unrest and dread the son knew sufficiently from his own experience; it was an inheritance that was increased by the strict upbringing and by the father's remarks that the young man was going about "in a quiet despair." It seems to have been in the year 1837 that Søren Kierkegaard received confirmation of his foreboding as to what lay behind the father's unrest. In his Old Testament conception the old man believed that he had committed the sin that cannot be forgiven, because as a child he had cursed God. Of the impression Søren Kierkegaard received of what he had first only suspected, and then knew about the father, he has expressed himself in a note from 1838.

"Then it was that the great earthquake occurred, the frightful upheaval that suddenly forced upon me a new infallible law of interpretation of all the phenomena. Then I suspected that my father's great age was not a divine blessing, but rather a curse; that our family's excellent mental gifts existed only to lacerate one another; then I felt the stillness of death around me...

A guilt must rest on the whole family, a punishment of God must be over it."

⁵P. A. Heiberg: *En Episode i Søren Kierkegaards Ungdomsliv* (Kierkegaard Studier. I) 1912.—*Et Segment af Søren Kierkegaards religiøse Udvikling* (Kierkegaard Studier III). 1918. (See my review of this book in *Tilskueren* 1919.)

Characteristic for Kierkegaard it surely is that the foreboding had for him “worked far more frightfully than the fact by which the truth of the foreboding is confirmed,” as he expresses himself in a note from January 1837. The foreboding and its confirmation put an end for him to the life in speculation and in the mere spectator-relation in which he had an inclination to place himself toward the world. “The quiet despair” could no longer be kept down by such means.

His religious development had thereby, as by his whole temperament and his whole upbringing, received an initial velocity that let his course run high above the most traveled level roads. And the inner brooding to which he was disposed now got a symbol to hold to. He had been led practically into Old Testament religiosity in a way that falls to the lot of the fewest. The patriarchal God-relation did not stand for him in the usual idyllic light. And he was not among those who could make a great distinction between the Old and the New Testament.

Søren Kierkegaard himself found his melancholy akin to the remarkable state of feeling that has not been unusual in the monasteries of the Middle Ages, and that was called *Acedia*.⁶ It expressed itself as spiritual slackening, disinclination for religious exercises, longing for the world, and aversion to confession (*odium professionis*). He believed he found therein what his father called the quiet despair. He interpreted the aversion to confession in a wider sense: of a shyness about expressing oneself to others at all, and believed he could then support the description with his own experience. He also found that it betrayed a deep insight into human nature when the medieval ethicists reckoned *Acedia* among the chief vices. It was a monastery-sickness, and he also says occasionally: “Had I lived in the Middle Ages, I would probably have gone into a monastery.”—His melancholy was in this different from the medieval *Acedia*, that it was far more grounded in nature than the latter. *Acedia* arose, as it seems, especially by contrast-effect, as a slackening after the strong mystical exertion, a reaction after forced devotion—a «désenchantement de dieu,» as a French philosopher has designated it. Yet Kierkegaard's state of feeling surely also had this character in part. There was, in consequence of the “rape” that early, by his own account, was practiced against him (especially against those elements in his nature that pointed in a direction other than melancholy), rich occasion for contrast-effect of the kind mentioned.

4. On the basis of melancholy—as the from the first strongest, and by upbringing and the father's influence further potentiated or inflamed, element of his nature—his engagement story now finds its explanation, when we attend to the utterances in the posthumous

⁶Cf. *Den store Humor*, p. 96 f.

papers.— After he had led an aestheticizing and philosophizing youthful life, broken several times by violent inner agitations, as at that “earthquake” and at the father’s death, he became engaged to a quite young girl, but broke off the engagement the following year, to the great sorrow and offense of the whole circle. He has depicted this episode in the third part of the *Stages*, and in the posthumous papers he returns to it again. It seems to me that all necessary explanation lies in the often-varied exclamation: “Alas, she could not break the silence of my melancholy!” He had no happiness to share with her—on the contrary, it was first by coming to know her bright, light temperament and immediate happiness that he became rightly conscious of how unhappy a temperament his own was: “Precisely her immediate youthful happiness, set beside my dreadful melancholy and in such a relation, had to teach me to understand myself; for how melancholy I was I had never suspected before; I really had no standard for how happy a human being can be.”—As his high spirits and power of thought could grow by the contrast to melancholy, so this again grew when it got happiness as its counterpart. A web of actions and reactions between the elements in his inner life and between his inner life and his outer experiences, which with the power of consistency formed his disposition in an ever more sharply pronounced style!

From what he calls his misery—the fact that “the simplest conditions for being a human being were denied him,” the isolating, demonically inhibiting melancholy—he derives not only the impossibility for him of entering into a relation which, like marriage, rests on openness and inwardness toward another, but also the impossibility of taking on an office. “It has always come easy to me to get on with people, and, accustomed as I am to being bound, it never occurred to me that it should become so hard for me. But here again comes my misery: I cannot, because I am not a human being, because I am melancholy to the border of insanity—something I can indeed gloss over so long as I am independent, but which makes me useless for a position where I do not myself determine everything.” Yet it was, according to what the complete notes show, especially the black spot mentioned above that stood for him as a hindrance, both toward the thought of marriage and toward the thought of becoming a priest.

With admirable clarity and honesty Søren Kierkegaard gives an account of how he came to be placed differently from other people. Had it been up to him, he would have chosen marriage and social position, like so many others. It was his sick temperament that made this impossible for him, while his pecuniary circumstances on the other hand made it possible for him to live (for a time—but it became his lifetime) without seeking paid work. It was by no means the case that he kept from entering into any relation of

communal life on strictly ideal and principled grounds. That he became the individual was due to the inner problems that, by his psychological presuppositions, he got to struggle with. Only when, on psychological-individual grounds, he was placed outside the ordinary way of life of people, on a solitary post, did he there discover something that he otherwise probably would not have caught sight of. What in his eyes stood as the highest ideal showed itself to him with a clarity and a consistency harder to reach for one who lives as a link in the manifold and conditioned life of humanity. Thus from a lighthouse out at sea much is seen that cannot be seen from the mainland; and yet it is not said that those who see it had been drawn out there in order to see it. Melancholy became, so to speak, his lookout station. Already in antiquity it was thought (it is so stated in the so-called Aristotelian "Problems") that the melancholic temperament was peculiar to geniuses. Even if by melancholy they did not then understand quite the same as nowadays, this opinion may fit many cases. There are experiences and discoveries made only by one who, with melancholy as a weight beneath his feet, dives down into the sea of life.

The great personalities whose life and thought acquire decisive and typical significance (whether now by the attraction or by the repulsion they exert) are such as have great inner problems to solve, and who solve them in a way that acquires value for others than themselves. When they come to step forth actively and aggressively, the chief cause will lie in the fact that the inner self-work needs an outer continuation. The sharp eye both for the ideal and for what stands opposed to the ideal they have acquired in their inner life. An inner drama has taken place before the outer one comes to performance. What to contemporaries often looks like, or is by them construed as, vanity, presumption, love of criticism, misanthropy—this is in the really great the outflow of dearly bought experiences that they cannot—without denying themselves—keep to themselves. Søren Kierkegaard belongs decidedly to this class of personalities. That his inner life should acquire significance for others through the clarity he could bring to some of life's most important questions was his own conviction. In that consisted, really, the faith he had in his mission. "Very far back in my recollection," he says (*On My Work as an Author*), "goes the thought that in every generation there are a couple or three who are sacrificed for the others, used to discover in frightful sufferings what comes to benefit the others; thus I melancholically understood myself, that I was singled out for this."

5. When Kierkegaard's melancholy, with its effects, stood for him now as sickness, now as guilt, this surely came in part from the fact that melancholy has a peculiar power to let the mind dwell on possibilities it would otherwise not bring forward, and

to give these possibilities not merely a dark stamp, but a stamp of reality. This will naturally happen all the more where there is a lively imagination and a subtle dialectic to unfold the possibilities and work with them. Every strong feeling has a tendency to spread in the mind and to give all emerging representations partly an absolute character, partly a stamp of reality they otherwise lack, just as it will also call forth recollections and anticipations for its own explanation and clarification. (These phenomena I have described, under the name of the expansion of feeling, in my psychology.) Melancholy disposes to a life in possibilities—partly in anticipation, partly in recollection. That Kierkegaard was well versed in both is seen not only from his writings, where he both inculcates the great importance of living in possibilities and testing oneself in them, and of not confusing possibility and reality, but also from the posthumous papers, which here too show how what he developed in his books was drawn from his personal experience. With melancholy there worked here, naturally, the poetic urge to image-formation, to the concrete development of the representations that could serve as an expression of the moods, now a direct expression of these, now, by contrast-effect, an expression of their opposite. The following utterances show what power anticipation and recollection had over him, and what danger he saw therein.

In the year 1839 (25 July) he writes in his diary: “This is why I find so little joy in existence: that when the thought of something awakens in my soul, it awakens with such an energy, in so supernatural a magnitude, that I really *overstrain* myself upon it, and the ideal anticipation is for me so far from being explanatory of existence that I rather proceed from it too powerless to find what corresponds to the idea, too restless and, so to speak, nerve-shaken to rest in it.”—One easily understands how melancholy had to be increased by such constant re-living of the disproportion between the anticipated and the real.

“For me,” it runs in a note from about the same time, “there is nothing more dangerous than to recollect. Once I have recollected a life-relation, it is impossible for me to get any interest in it again... Once I get time to make the experience I have all too often enough made, that recollection satiates more richly than all reality—then it is over.”—Here again it is the life in representation that gets the precedence over the life in reality. In the same direction points a note occasioned by a brother's death: “I have noticed that my grief is not one that apprehends momentarily, but one that increases in the long run, and I am sure that when I some day grow old I shall really come to think of the departed... As for my now deceased brother, I am sure that the grief will first really awaken after a long lapse of time.”

If melancholy, by its propensity to call forth and dwell in possibilities and representations, gave the poetic urge and the dialectical drive wind in their sails, there was thereby attained, on the other hand, a diverting effect on melancholy; the latter was kept down by the work of thought and imagination, which laid claim to the whole force and attention of the mind. The whole first grand period of Kierkegaard's production (1843–46), in which his most brilliant works fall, he himself has explained from this point of view: "Like that princess in the *Thousand and One Nights* I saved my life by telling stories, i.e. by producing. To produce was my life. An enormous melancholy, inner sufferings of a sympathetic kind—all this I could master when I was allowed to produce."—Had there not been this deep urge to work of thought and imagination, he would have gone under spiritually.⁷ It was an independent element in his nature, which under other circumstances could have been developed in other forms than it was. It sought an outlet, and the direction of the outlet was determined by what else stirred in his mind. But the whole authorial activity was hardly, from the first, laid out so clearly and definitely in one direction or with one purpose as he later believed. There was from the first far more that was involuntary in him than he would admit when he looked back on his activity.⁸

6. If we stopped at the elements of his being hitherto brought out, we could not expect to find in him more than—what is naturally no small thing—a poet-nature, and perhaps also a thinker of a psychological cast. Søren Kierkegaard has also often enough warned against himself in this respect. When it was his conviction that people, especially in his time, all too often confused a thought- and imagination-relation to life and to life's great exemplars with a relation of reality, he knew, as has been shown, this danger from himself. But he also knew the counterweight. For just as characteristic of him as the strongly tensed life of mood, the tireless dialectic, and the imagination obedient to every nuance of feeling and every transition of thought, was the energetic will with which he sought to preserve himself in concentration, to hold together the elements of his being

⁷The constantly repeated rhythmic play of melancholy and thought-movement is depicted in the following note from 1843: "It is strange how strictly, in a certain sense, I am brought up. From time to time I am set down in the dark hole; there I crawl about in torment and pain, see nothing, no way out. Then suddenly a thought awakens in my soul as vividly as if I had never had it before, though it is not unknown to me; but before I have, as it were, only been wedded to it with the left hand, now I am wedded to it with the right. When it has now settled fast in me, then I am caressed a little, I am taken up in the arms, and I, who had shriveled up like a grasshopper, now grow up again, healthy, thriving, glad, warm-blooded, supple as a newborn. Thereupon I must, as it were, give my word that I will pursue this thought to the utmost; I set my life in pawn, and now I am harnessed in the traces. Stop I cannot, and my powers hold out. Then I am finished, and now everything begins again."

⁸The relation between the involuntary and the deliberate in the design of Kierkegaard's production in those three years I have discussed in *Mindre Arbejder*. Second Series, pp. 181–191.

and lead all the streams of the rich inner life toward one goal. He has with full right maintained that at no stage was he merely a poet or a thinker. Already as a young man of 22 he wrote (at Gilleleje, on a walking tour in the summer of 1835) the following:

“What I really lack is to get clear in my own mind about *what I am to do*, not about what I am to know, except insofar as a knowing must precede every action. The point is to understand my destiny, to see what the Deity really wants *me* to do; the thing is to find a truth that is truth *for me*, to find *the idea for which I am willing to live and die*. And what use would it be to me if I discovered a so-called objective truth... if it had *no* deeper significance for *myself* and for *my life*?... That was what I lacked: to lead *a completely human life* and not merely a life of knowledge, so that I should thereby come not to base my developments of thought upon—yes, upon something one calls objective—something that is at any rate not my own, but upon something that is bound up with the deepest root of my existence, through which I am, so to speak, grown into the Divine, cleave fast to it even if the whole world should collapse. See, *this is what I lack*, and *this is what I strive toward*.” (The emphases are Kierkegaard's own.)

The strong urge to think is thus from the first an urge *to think in existence*, to think in such a way that the innermost personality is involved and is determined thereby in its core and its direction. He wants to think in the same manner as, in one place, he writes that he has read a book (Görres's *Athanasius*): “with my whole body—with the pit of my heart.” But this urge to bend everything in himself toward one purpose, to join the separated, conflicting elements of his being together into unity, had strong resistance to overcome. And yet the thinking of the age seemed to have paved the way. The watchword, after all, was the higher unity, the harmony of oppositions, and all around him he heard young speculative virtuosos repeat these slogans in full assurance of being able to make good on them. The thing was to mediate, to find the mediation; to remain stuck in an either-or, in an extreme or an unreconciled relation of opposition, was a sign of a poor head or of a narrow-minded holding-fast to a “superseded standpoint.” These phrases had to grate on Søren Kierkegaard's ears when he came from his solitary meditations or from his inner struggles, which taught him well enough that here there was no question of a method, a knack, that could be learned once and for all, but that it was something which, when attempted in the reality of life—not merely in fantastic abstraction or on paper—could demand the most strenuous willing, the most painful endurance, and that it was a task that always had to be solved anew. But—as he wrote in

his diary in 1837—"there are many people who arrive at a life-result the way schoolboys do; they cheat their teacher by copying the answer out of the arithmetic book without having worked the problem themselves." Kierkegaard was here the strict auditor—first and foremost toward himself. He lived through the elements of life and learned from his own experience how hard a work it can be to construct a totality of them. A superficial polishing-up so often covers over a botched job. He therefore declared "the higher unity," with its both-and, a struggle for life and death. The distinction, the disjunction, the either-or was given a place of honor, and "repetition" was set in the place of mediation. "All talk of a higher unity that is to unite absolute oppositions is a metaphysical assault on ethics." One presupposes without more ado that everything is in order, and that the elements join together as of themselves, so that no special act of exertion, no new effort is necessary or must always be repeated. But often this comes precisely from one's having no real natural ground in oneself. For his own part he says: "I sit and listen to the tones within me, the glad hint of the music and the deep earnestness of the organ; to work them together, that is a task not for a composer, but for a *human being* who, in default of greater demands on life, restricts himself to the simple one of wanting to understand *himself*.—To mediate is no art when one has no moments in oneself."

As life went on, the oppositions became for him stronger and stronger, the moments more and more contentious, although his power grew at the same time—or perhaps rather because his power grew; for had it not grown (even to sickly overstrain), he would not have been able to hold fast such great disharmonies and operate with them. All rational and natural coherence in life was in the end burst asunder for him, and he passed a sentence of condemnation on the natural life of man as corrupted and depraved in its innermost root.

For it must indeed be well noted, and will in the following be more closely demonstrated, that Søren Kierkegaard's indignation and polemic were most immediately called forth by the romantic-speculative blurring of life's oppositions—a blurring that, especially in the mouth of epigones and parrots, became insipid and superficial—but that it was not merely such a passing tendency of the age or of fashion that he wanted to do away with. He aimed higher. What he wanted to do away with was really all human and natural view of life and conduct of life, faith in life's unbroken power, in its ability by its own natural ways to solve the problems its own unfolding has brought with it. In itself the idea of "the higher unity" is also only a modernized expression for the harmony that Greek thought in its way sought and found, and by which no human thinking can refrain from steering, even though it is of great importance for the richness and depth of

life that one not bargain away the oppositions, and that one not too early and on loose ground celebrate the festivals of "mediation."

Kierkegaard also became ever more clearly conscious of what kind of power it really was that he was fighting against. When the time of "the system" was past, his struggle was not past. He saw clearly that the scientific view of the world, by its naturalistic path, asserted the same continuity and inner coherence in life that the speculative view had, in its idealistic manner, maintained. It was the same enemy in a new shape.—Yet it was a pity that Kierkegaard did not have before him greater representatives of humanism than the speculative epigones. He did not have enough resistance to overcome. His work therefore did not become *as* significant as it otherwise might have become.—

The higher unity was, according to Kierkegaard, so difficult to reach not merely for the reason that there are sharp oppositions, conflicting moments to overcome, but also because all human existence is in a state of *becoming*. Existence means, according to his definition expressly: to be *in time*, and on this last he lays (as we shall see more fully in his theory of knowledge) a very great weight. So long as we are in time, we stand ever before new possibilities and new tasks, whose solution is problematic. All our knowledge and harmony is grounded on hindsight. "Life must be *understood backwards*. But... it must be *lived forwards*." Which proposition, the more it is thought through, ends precisely in this: that life in temporality never becomes rightly intelligible, precisely because at no moment can I get complete rest to take up the position backwards. Every won result must be ventured anew as a stake, put anew up for debate, in order if possible to be won anew under the constant development and the constant work. Here the concept of *repetition* shows itself in its significance for Kierkegaard's thinking. It is closely connected with his emphasis on reality, on existence as being in time. What has been won in the past has only a *possible* value in the future. The point is a conversion of this possibility into reality; but every such conversion is a repetition, since what is to be realized existed beforehand as a possibility, for representation. (To the concept of repetition we shall return in connection with Søren Kierkegaard's ethics.)—

7. The relation between Søren Kierkegaard's poetic gift and his gift as a thinker must still be touched on. The two sides in his nature work constantly together. This places him in a position of his own in literature, outside the usual rubrics. In a certain sense he might perhaps have achieved a greater effect if he had been able to give poetic works that did not require an understanding of philosophical thoughts, and works of thought that did not present so many parentheses, elaborations, and images. Many who would enjoy poetry by itself, or follow pure and rigorous thinking, now pass him by. But the

close cooperation of his poetizing and his thinking sprang from the close connection of both with his own innermost nature. They both work in the service of his personality. His urge to think was an urge to think in connection with life-experiences and moods; therefore he constantly needed concrete situations and examples. And the mood, which constantly accompanies, then undertakes its little excursions, has its side effects, to whose unfolding and clarification the ever-willing and lightning-quick imagination lends its aid. Hence the richness and poetry—in short turns and expressions, after parenthetical outbursts, or in elaborating images—that is scattered about in his works.

“My thinking,” he himself says, “is *presentic*; I have as much imagination as dialectic.” That he did not lose himself in abstractions remote from life and the present he here aptly connects with the fact that imagination and thinking work together in him. Since real experience seldom or never presents us with a character, a passion, or a state of soul in full and consistent development, he takes imagination to his aid and constructs—by a thought-experiment that strictly holds to the decisive conceptual determinations that are to be practiced—figures and situations for the visualization and contemporization of the spiritual conditions and problems he is occupied with. His most famous books—*Either-Or*, *Stages on Life's Way*, *Repetition*—are such “Attempts in Experimenting Psychology.”—Yet I believe that in this respect too there is more involuntariness and less systematic design in his authorial activity than he often himself gives the appearance of. Images have surely thrust themselves forward before their use, and he has—at any rate most often—only afterward seen what they could be used for. And where the constructing deliberateness has intervened more strongly, it has not seldom been to the detriment of the poetic value, and also (as will be sought to be shown in a later section) of the philosophical value of his expositions.

Kierkegaard lays much weight on the need to test oneself through possibilities, since the reality of life is not sufficient to educate the character. But it is characteristic of him that he emphasizes only one drawback of this method of possibilities, namely that one can easily shirk one's way to a greater proficiency than one really possesses. “It is difficult to test oneself in possibility; it is as if someone, without daring to use his voice, were to test whether he had a strong voice. Hitherto in vain I have many times speculated on finding a means of being able to check myself in possibility” (*Stages on Life's Way*). He does not always bring out the other conceivable drawback: that the possibilities constructed could be so dark and abnormal that strength and courage are used up in the struggle with shadows, without any proficiency for taking up the struggle of reality being fetched from this dwelling in the world of possibilities. And moreover:

with reality one can at times get finished; but possibility is like a shadow or a fog that forms again as often as it is cut apart; the struggle with possibilities therefore easily becomes a bailing into the vessel of the Danaids. Kierkegaard has here worked far more as a romantic than he wished and willed. He has for many conjured forth an imaginary world that sucked all the strength and sap out of the real one. There are several for whom his writings have been like the lion's den, where all tracks led in, none back out again. Others have had to free themselves violently from his world of possibility by one of those resolute "jerks of decision" that he himself in another connection recommends.

So great was his zeal for personal truth that he expressly wanted it established that these thought-experiments did not cover his own view. Therefore he poetized not only characters and situations, but also authors. The pseudonymous author-names that stand on most of his writings make up a whole circle of individualities at different standpoints. It is his striving after "thinking in existence" that leads him to these pseudonyms. What virtuosity he possessed in thus psychologically and poetically entering into different possible author-individualities can be seen from the little work *Prefaces (Forord)*, a collection of prefaces to various imagined writings by imagined authors.—

His thinking is not only *present*, bound to perceptible conditions and situations; it is also, what is moreover closely connected therewith, *subjective*, that is: a thinking that proceeds from, and is consumed in, the personal life, in the view of life and the conduct of life of the individual, in the practical relation to life's circumstances and life's possibilities. Such a subjective thinking is bound up with passion, for to exist is an enormous contradiction. The subjective thinker must not swing away from existence into abstraction; his task is rather to understand the abstract and the universal concretely, in his existence as this individual human being. To be the ideal in imagination or on the lecturer's platform is not difficult; but to have to exist as an idealist is an extremely strenuous life-task. The subjective thinker is an artist, not a man of science, for his thinking goes together with a willing.—As such subjective thinkers Kierkegaard especially admired Socrates and Lessing, also Jacobi and Hamann. His doctoral dissertation dealt with Socrates (*Om Begrebet Ironi med stadigt Hensyn til Sokrates*, 1841). Both Socrates and Lessing he has characterized in a brilliant, but also highly one-sided way; in particular he has surely made them more "subjective" than they in reality were.

It is an important idea that Kierkegaard has set up in his demand for subjective thinking. It contains not merely the demand to leave the paths of speculative abstraction and go back to critical reflection on the presuppositions and barriers within which our thought has to work. But it leads him to give a psychological and ethical introduction to

a view of life, or a theory of the art of the view of life. Søren Kierkegaard's philosophy is such a theory. It is, to be sure, first and foremost designed to illuminate the Christian view of life; but it is designed and carried through in such a way that it can acquire significance for every view of life.

Søren Kierkegaard's authorial activity falls essentially into two periods. In the first (1843–46) he is occupied with the struggle against the speculative-aesthetic evaporation of existence, with demonstrating oppositions, transitional relations, and conditions in the domain of the views of life. He here gives a kind of comparative philosophy of life. In the second period (1847–1855) he carries on his great struggle against the Church's mitigating conception and treatment of Christianity. This last period too acquires significance in philosophical respects, since Kierkegaard here draws his last consequences with regard to the relation between religion and humanity.—In the characterization of the first period, however, utterances from a later time may of course very well be used from time to time, provided only that they are expressions of thoughts that were already developed in the earlier time.

IV. Søren Kierkegaard's Philosophy

The task Kierkegaard set himself as a thinker he has himself designated as this: to make difficulties. Everything was being made easier nowadays, he thought. In the outer world, traffic and intercourse were made easier by railways and telegraphs; and in the world of spirit there was promised a reconciliation of all oppositions, a harmonious unity of all conflicting elements. So he set himself, then, to make something difficult;—for otherwise those who wanted to make everything easy would come to lack material in the end.

Of the men here at home by whom he was influenced during his development, there has been talk in the foregoing. Here it shall merely be mentioned that it was especially Martensen's lectures on speculative theology that provoked his criticism. Already in the dissertation on Socrates there appeared hints of a more critical, subjective, and existential conception of thinking, and a doubt whether it should be possible to give our knowledge as smooth and continuous a coherence as speculative philosophy believed it had attained. When Schelling in the year 1841 began the sensational lectures with which he wanted to set a new, higher and more "positive" philosophy in place of Hegel's, Kierkegaard was among the many who hurried from all around to Berlin to become acquainted with the new wisdom. In the beginning it seemed as if the expectations with which he came would be fulfilled. In his diary he wrote: "I am glad to have heard Schelling's second hour—indescribable. I have sighed long enough, and the thoughts have sighed within me; when he mentioned the word '*reality*,' concerning philosophy's relation to reality, then the child of thought leapt within me for joy as in Elizabeth. I remember almost every word he said from that moment. Here perhaps clarity may come. This one word reminded me of all my philosophical sufferings and torments." The expected greater clarity failed to come; for some months later Kierkegaard wrote to his brother: "Dear Peter, Schelling talks the most utter nonsense," and he traveled home before the lectures were at an end. Yet that leap of the child of thought was the beginning of his subsequent life of thought. For Schelling emphasized very strongly that speculative philosophy could not get beyond the possible and the abstract, the universal, and that the relation to the absolute reality—especially as religious faith conceives it—could be posited only by

an act of will, motivated by longing and by practical, personal need: thus, as Kierkegaard later expressed it, by a leap. The opposition between thought and existence, between the universal and the individual, and the impossibility of a continuous transition between them, Kierkegaard here got established so firmly that he did not forget it. He was rightly repelled by the arbitrary and fantastic way in which Schelling philosophized further after having established that break in the continuity of thought, although amid the fantasy there emerge flashes of genius. Schelling's concluding result would hardly have appealed to him either; it aimed at healing the break again by demonstrating a new coherence and by announcing a religiosity of the future, "a third kingdom" (like Lessing earlier, and in our day Henrik Ibsen), to which Christianity is only an introduction, and which in its higher form is to lead beyond the opposition between mythology and revelation through free religious self-understanding. Kierkegaard held to the break that Schelling had established. In his philosophical writings (especially in *The Concept of Anxiety*) one can clearly notice Schelling's influence, in part also his terminology.

A younger German philosopher to whom Kierkegaard owes much is Adolf Trendelenburg. During his Berlin stay mentioned above he was so taken up with Schelling and the Hegelians that he did not get to hear Trendelenburg, which he later regretted. Trendelenburg was the first to give an epistemological critique of the speculative method and to develop a more critical theory of knowledge (*Logische Untersuchungen*, 1840), which has had no small influence on Kierkegaard's cast of thought. Kierkegaard speaks of Trendelenburg as "a man who thinks soundly and is happily formed by the Greeks," and in his posthumous papers he even says: "There is, after all, no modern philosopher from whom I have had the benefit that I have had from Trendelenburg."

But whatever he owed to others, the essential ground was laid in his own personality and in the original nature and direction of his thought. Through solitary brooding and reflection his thoughts soon developed to full maturity. After his return home from Berlin he lived in his studies and his immensely productive authorial activity, from which he diverted himself by walks, by excursions to the wooded regions of North Zealand, and on a single occasion by a new journey to Berlin. By his roaming about the streets and lanes he soon became a well-known Copenhagen figure, just as Socrates was in Athens, and he too found his Aristophanes. He needed movement for the sake of his health. But he also felt an urge to seek relief for his melancholy and his sorrow by talking with common folk and entering into their circumstances, helping and consoling them. He learned, moreover, much both as a psychologist and as an author by hearing plain people talk together: "What one has vainly sought enlightenment about in books, a

light suddenly dawns on it by hearing one servant-girl talk with another; an expression one has vainly tried to squeeze out of one's own brain, sought in vain in dictionaries, even the Academy's, one hears in passing: a common soldier says it, and he does not know what a rich man he is. And as one who walks in the great forest, wondering at the whole, sometimes tears off a branch, sometimes a leaf, now listens for a bird's cry: so one goes among the crowd of people, sees now an utterance of a state of soul, now another, learns and learns and only becomes more eager to learn. Then one does not let oneself be deceived by books, in which the human occurred so seldom; then one does not read about it in newspapers; the best in the utterance, the loveliest, the little psychological trait, is nevertheless sometimes not preserved" (*Stages on Life's Way*).—As the deliberate everywhere comes after the involuntary, it was only later that he conceived this roaming about the streets and lanes as a tactical means: in order that the religious authorial activity, which was his real task, might come to count by its own force, he wanted to weaken the impression of his person. The technique of indirect communication required this! We need not here enter more closely into this artifice. I have merely wanted to sketch his circumstances of life in the time (1843–46) in which his properly philosophical authorial activity falls.

A. Epistemology

1. When Kierkegaard considers the question of what knowledge an existing human being can attain, he is not thinking of every possible kind of knowledge, but only of what he calls *essential* knowledge, by which he means the knowledge that bears specifically on the knowing individual itself in its conditions of existence—ethico-religious knowledge.⁹ All other knowledge—empirical, mathematical, and historical—is a matter of indifference to him, because it has nothing to do with existence. Already here he makes a very important distinction, introduces an Either–Or. For it is surely a great question whether much of that knowledge he regards as indifferent is not—and has not been—of far-reaching significance for ethico-religious knowledge. When the latter is not the same at all times, this is due in part to that apparently “indifferent” knowledge, which consciously and unconsciously comes to exert influence even on those regions of spiritual life that one seeks to close off from it. But Kierkegaard simply takes the correctness of that distinction as given, and thereby marks off the boundary of his investigation.

2. The train of thought in Kierkegaard's epistemology is directed polemically both

⁹The main work here is the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846).

against Hegel and against those who (like Martensen) held that once one had placed oneself on the ground of faith and had one's consciousness reborn, one had thereby obtained the conditions for a higher, hitherto unattainable knowledge. Against Hegel it is observed that he has not really answered Kant's objections to a knowledge of absolute reality. Thought cannot reach reality: for in the very moment it would have reached it, it has converted it into *thought* reality, or into possibility; thought cannot get beyond itself. Against speculative theology it is observed that faith has no interest in understanding itself in any way other than by continually remaining in the passion of faith. Of the highest things in the world one can only be knowing as a happy or as an unhappy lover; by approaching with speculative curiosity one in fact learns nothing. Take away the passion that is ever renewed by uncertainty as a salutary disciplinarian, and faith vanishes at once. The existing individual is always in the process of becoming, and time is never concluded; therefore full certainty can never be reached, and our knowledge can never get beyond approximations and hypotheses, with which in the domains of inessential knowledge we can also perfectly well content ourselves. But if the Eternal and Unconditioned is to be grasped and held fast, this can only happen in passion, because closure cannot be attained. The craving for something finished and concluded is of the Evil One, owing to indolence or impatience. We do not get beyond the eternal striving after truth.—Kierkegaard joins with enthusiasm Lessing's famous words: that if God held in his right hand all truth, and in his left the ever-living striving after truth, he would grasp the left hand, because eternal truth is not for a finite being. Lessing's justification for this choice is, however, somewhat different from Kierkegaard's. Lessing proceeds from the premise that it is not possession, but only acquisition, that gives a human being worth, inasmuch as one's powers are enlarged by seeking and one thereby grows in perfection. This is a more positive and psychological justification than the one we shall find in what follows from Kierkegaard, who is too much the ascetic and too preoccupied with preparing his doctrine of the Paradox to follow Lessing on his natural path.

More precisely, Kierkegaard's epistemology develops through the grounding of two propositions: a logical system can be given; but a system of existence cannot be given.

3. A logical system can be given. We can develop a coherent series of general determinations that hold for our thought. But here one must be careful not to smuggle in concepts that are drawn from reality. The logical system is a hypothesis whose validity for reality is problematic. And it must be investigated in particular whether we form this hypothesis after having come to know reality through experience, that is, as a kind of abbreviated expression (*Abbreviatur*) for it, or whether we form it independently

of experience.—Kierkegaard expresses the wish to treat this last question more fully on another occasion; but it never happened. It is, as one easily sees, the question of whether the empiricist or the rationalist conception of the fundamental presuppositions of thought is the correct one.

A peculiar difficulty in the construction of the logical system lies, for Kierkegaard, in how one can come to *begin* it, i.e. get hold of a starting point. For the simplest presuppositions are discovered by reflection, by going back from derived assumptions to the assumptions on which they rest—but when we have gone back far enough, how can we halt the reflection? It has just as little reason to halt at one point as at another, and will therefore, left to itself, continue indefinitely. Or, as it can also be expressed: doubt cannot halt itself. There must be a break, an arbitrary interruption. A decision must be made to halt the regressive chain of thought and to fix the point one has reached as the principle and starting point of the system. But what then becomes of presuppositionlessness? For the beginning of the logical system is then conditioned by something other than the logical, namely by that which causes me to make the decision!

“What if, instead of talking or dreaming about an absolute beginning, we were to speak of a *leap*?”

—Against Hegel, who wanted to give an absolute system of thought that closed upon itself like a circle, this line of reasoning by Kierkegaard is telling. If one compares it with the superficial catechism-talk with which Martensen “went beyond Hegel,” one has the difference between them as thinkers given in a single example.—Yet it is a question whether there is as great a difficulty about the “beginning” as Kierkegaard thinks. We do indeed find our ultimate presuppositions by reflection, or as Descartes expressed it, by doubt, or as one can perhaps best express it, by analysis. But in our search for presuppositions we always have a definite task in view, which is to be solved with the help of the presuppositions we seek. The task is to understand existence as given in experience, or some part of it. We therefore have a definite standard for how far we need to go—namely until we have found what is necessary for solving that task. If we can go still further, we discover more remotely situated presuppositions that present themselves with the same logical necessity as those first found; but for the time being there will be no use for these presuppositions. Perhaps advancing experience may lead us to make use of them.—It is therefore no arbitrary act that forms the beginning of logic, and its first principles have more than merely arbitrary validity.

4. A system of existence cannot be given. This is due, first, to the fact that all existence is in time, in the process of becoming. The latter point especially must not be forgotten.

Speculative philosophy, which has claimed to explain everything, has forgotten that the one who constructs the speculative system, however insignificant he may be ("such a tiny little thingamajig as the existing Mr. Professor who writes the system"), still himself belongs to the existence that is to be explained, and he is never finished with his own existence. The system would only become possible if one could look back on existence as concluded—but that would presuppose that one no longer existed! As we have already heard: life is lived forwards, but understood backwards.—And even that backward understanding, the insight into the necessity of past development, may rest on an illusion: for how can that which, so long as it is future, is only possible, become necessary by belonging to the past? Should the past be more necessary than the future? We understand the past properly only by making ourselves contemporaneous with it—but then we see it as becoming, not as concluded, and thus still for the most part merely as possible! (See on this point *Philosophical Fragments*.)

For the existing individual, moreover, thought and being are not one but separate. We think either back on what has been or forward to what will come. Simultaneity, absolute unity of thought and being, is impossible for an existing being, and exists only as a fantasy. There can be no continuity in our thinking, since it is continually interrupted by absorption in existence. All unity and continuity is only abstraction.

And finally: only the individual, the concrete, exists; to exist means to be individual. But only the universal and the abstract is the object of thought. Herein too lies a disproportion between thought and existence.¹⁰

Because a system of existence cannot be formed by our thought, it does not follow, according to Kierkegaard, that such a system does not exist. A system of existence is given—but only for "one who is himself outside existence and yet in existence—who in his eternity is eternally concluded and yet includes existence within himself; that is, God." (Since Kierkegaard defines existing as becoming, he consistently says: God does not exist, since He is eternal.)—But for human beings, existence is irrational, is a Paradox. The Paradox, the absurd and contradictory, is according to Kierkegaard no concession but is, as he puts it, an "ontological determination," designating the relation between an existing knowing spirit and the eternal truth.

It must be admitted that a Paradox has been established through the sharp contradiction between the eternal truth (the eternal completedness of existence in God) and the existence that is constantly in the process of becoming. For how can, from any point of view whatsoever and for any thought of which we can form a concept, that which

¹⁰Before Kierkegaard, Sibbern (*Hegels Filosofi betragtet i Forhold til vor Tid*, 1838) had already criticized Hegel's speculation from similar points of view. (See *Danske Filosofer*, pp. 109–112.)

is constantly becoming stand as complete? Kierkegaard maintains firmly that “motion cannot be thought *sub specie aeterni*” [i.e. from the point of view of eternity, apart from time]; but how then can God be knowing about existence, about the whole of existence in its process of becoming, since indeed “existence cannot be thought without motion”?—Here two thoughts have been violently yoked together, both of which Kierkegaard demands be held fast. Epistemology must surely here turn his favourite determination, Either–Or, against him and say: either the concept of the absolute system in God must be an illusion, or else the continual becoming must be a mere appearance.—Kierkegaard would not need, if he chose the first alternative, to give up his theistic presuppositions. Like other philosophical theists he could draw the consequence that God himself must be in the process of becoming, that God’s being is not concluded. This idea was developed simultaneously with Kierkegaard’s philosophical production by the true founder of modern philosophical theism, C. H. Weisse. Thereby the sharp antithesis would be resolved—but the absolutely concluded element in the idea of God would admittedly be sacrificed at the same time.—If one holds to the view that the existence we know unfolds in time, and that we cannot form any conception whatsoever of any other form of existence, then there is no question of a concluded system. But existence then becomes no Paradox either. It becomes irrational in the mathematical sense, inasmuch as only an approximate knowledge of it becomes possible. It stands before us like $\sqrt{2}$, which we can continually determine with more decimal places without exhausting it. Existence could be so rich and many-sided that there would be material enough in it for the most energetic and comprehensive thought we can conceive. But that is something entirely different from its being paradoxical, that is to say, from its presenting us with insurmountable contradictions. The inexhaustibility of existence for thought corresponds exactly to Lessing’s idea of the eternal striving after truth. If we hold fast to this idea, we must as its objective counterpart assume a continually becoming, and in its becoming un-surveillable, existence.¹¹

Kierkegaard proceeds from the premise that we cannot, even with respect to “essential” knowledge, content ourselves with approximations and hypotheses. But why ever not? Provided they are genuine approximations, and provided they are hypotheses that are increasingly verified by experience? Then we have reason enough not to abandon our hope of gaining clearer understanding and of being able practically to hold our own in the struggle with the world. And it is such a hope that sustains all our drive for knowledge.—But it will become apparent in what follows that Kierkegaard treats the

¹¹What is here hinted at, I have developed in detail in *Den menneskelige Tanke*, pp. 306–375.

concept of approximation in a remarkable way.

5. That the “essential” truth is paradoxical is grounded by Kierkegaard in the fact that the thought of God as the absolutely eternal must be held fast in the midst of the unceasing becoming of existence. On this depends also the fact that essential truth can be held fast only with the passion of faith.

If one asks how the idea of God arises for Kierkegaard, his answer is that God is a postulate, a last resort, without which we cannot endure to live. An image that would aptly express his thought would be the following: God is an anchor of distress that we need on the wild sea of existence, and at which, amid the surging waves, there is a constant tugging. We need an absolutely fixed point of support, a hook on which the chain of existence can be fastened, a point where the infinite reflection can find rest. But what is postulated is qualitatively different from the postulating being: not even the concept of existence is supposed to apply to God! God does not, according to Kierkegaard, stand in relation to the human being as a superlative ideal. “Between God and man there is an absolute difference”; “the qualities are absolutely different.”—But then the situation is such that the last resort to which the human being in existence anxiously flies itself creates new difficulties and increases the suffering: for now the task is to unite the absolutely different qualities, to think them together! —Faith in God arises when the human being “with infinite interest inquires after a reality other than its own”—but thereby new problems are immediately posed.

One understands that Kierkegaard, given his conception, could not have it as easy as Martensen in building speculative theology on the ground of faith. This ground was of a volcanic nature, was in constant motion, just as it itself owed its origin to a revolution. Here there was neither time nor place to build, but only to struggle anxiously to preserve what already was.

An objective certainty, a confirmation by experience, can never be obtained. Not only is the future, as has often been remarked, ever equally uncertain, but when one contemplates nature in order to find confirmation of God's omnipotence and wisdom, one finds alongside traces in that direction also traces in the opposite direction. From objective uncertainty, then, we never escape—and since it is nevertheless a matter of life and death, this objective uncertainty is embraced with infinite passion. Truth can be held fast only in the form of subjectivity, as the object of personal feeling and passion.

6. After Kierkegaard has thus developed the claim that truth can be grasped and held fast only in a subjective, personal manner—that truth is subjectivity—he reverses the proposition and maintains: subjectivity is the truth. For only that which is grasped with

subjective energy and passion can be the truth. If there are two people, one of whom prays in personal untruth to the true God, while the other “with the whole passion of infinity” prays to an idol, then the former in reality prays to an idol, while the latter truly prays to God. What matters first and foremost is a *how*, not a *what*; personal inwardness and energy, not the content to which this inwardness attaches itself. And with objective uncertainty, with the contradiction that the content presents to the one who must hold fast to it in personal existence, inwardness and passion increase. Truth is a venture. To the proposition that subjectivity is the truth corresponds the other proposition that truth (objectively considered) is the Paradox.

With this famous proposition of his, that subjectivity is the truth, Kierkegaard has sharpened Lessing's proposition that only in eternal striving can one relate oneself to truth. The entire value is shifted from the objective (dogmatic) to the subjective (psychological) pole. The meaning is really this: only when truth is appropriated and held fast in personal feeling and striving does it have value. It is the personal nutritive value of truth that is decisive. The standard lies in the movement that is awakened in the inner life of the personality.

In fact, Søren Kierkegaard has in his own way stated the same thing that Ludwig Feuerbach had maintained a few years earlier in *The Essence of Christianity*: that theology is psychology. (*The Essence of Christianity* appeared in 1841, the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* in 1846. In this book, and already in *Stages on Life's Way*, Kierkegaard expressly refers to Feuerbach's interpretation of Christianity.) Only through an inconsistency can Kierkegaard demand a definite content, a definite objective faith, of subjectivity: the main thing is that it be in a state of truth-striving; what it relates itself to must be a matter of indifference. It must be the fullness and height of the personal life that matters, and it must provisionally remain an open question whether a certain definite dogmatic content of faith is necessary for the development of such a life.

But he does not draw the full consequence of his proposition. That would have led him to proclaim the principle of the free personality. He does not abandon the assumption of a standard for truth different from the personality itself, which for him is given in ecclesiastical dogmatics. And yet—on closer inspection (which we shall undertake when we have come to know his ethics) it will become apparent that this dogmatic guideline is not the ultimate one. He is too much a thinker to be able to rest content with it. His ultimate standard is of a formal nature: the relation to the dogmatic-ecclesiastical content of faith is for him the highest form of personal life, because in this relation the strongest contradiction, the greatest suffering and passion, comes forth in subjectivity.

The last and decisive objection against him will then prove to be that he has torn the personality loose from the real, natural and social context in which alone its life can acquire a positive content. For only in the free subjectivity, struggling with reality and learning from reality, can truth dwell—not in the subjectivity that through formal, ascetic exercises torments itself into obedience to a content that is contrary to nature and hostile to life.—But only through an examination of Kierkegaard's ethics can this point be more clearly illuminated.

What is great about Søren Kierkegaard's epistemology is the seriousness with which he grasps the connection of thought with personal life. There is something Greek in him. He wants to return from abstract thinking and contemplation to personal, existential thinking.

Our ideas all too easily become soldiers in peacetime. Søren Kierkegaard has led ideas forth from the comfort of contemplation to the strife and unrest of the struggle of life, and has pointed out the arena where the validity of "essential" knowledge must stand its test. Had the dogmatic impediment not been there, his thoughts would have attained a more directly universal significance; as it stands, a translation, a process of sifting, must take place before they can come to play the role for humanity that is rightfully theirs.

B. Ethics

a. The Leap

1. There appears in the history of thought an important opposition between two types of thinkers. For the one type the concern is to find unity, coherence, continuity, to demonstrate successive transitions and intermediate links between the apparently most opposite forms of existence, to show how the apparently qualitatively different phenomena consist of the same elements, only in different proportions of mixture and forms of composition. For the other type the chief interest, by contrast, is to establish the definite differences, to demonstrate how at certain points in existence something qualitatively new emerges, to maintain the abrupt transitions, the sudden swings, the sharp boundaries between different domains. The chief concept of the former thinkers becomes the continuous, successive transition, the difference of degree, the *relation of quantity*; that of the latter, distinction and disjunction, the *difference of quality*. The two types or tendencies collide over a series of great problems in the domains of natural science and the science of spirit. Thus over the question of the unity or original heterogeneity of the

forces of nature, of the unity of matter or the qualitative difference of the elements, of the origin of life, of the origin of species, of the relation of conscious life to the material, of the mutual relation between higher and lower phenomena of consciousness, of the relation of the will's decision to the law of causality, and so on. Where it is impossible to determine quantitatively how great the approximation is, how far the continuity reaches, or how great the distance is between the oppositions appearing in experience—there the difference between the two types of thought will especially assert itself; more strongly, therefore, in the science of the organic than in the science of the inorganic, more strongly in the science of spirit than in natural science. And in philosophy it will become of special importance, since here the concern is to fix the fundamental presuppositions and the points of view of totality themselves.

Both types have their scientific justification. They represent the two fundamental activities of our knowledge: synthesis and analysis, which, as Goethe remarked, are related to each other as inhalation and exhalation.¹² One might perhaps think that the first had to be the properly scientific one, since synthesis is the fundamental form of our spirit and our thought, and since all science aims at finding coherence and unity in existence. But it is no less essential that we become conscious of the whole qualitative richness that existence contains. And synthesis itself first acquires its proper significance when the content of experience is spread out before us in its whole heterogeneity, with all its qualitative nuances and oppositions; only then does synthesis have something to work with. Søren Kierkegaard has taught us: it is no art to proclaim a unity when there are no opposing elements to overcome.

That Søren Kierkegaard belongs decidedly to the latter class of thinkers, of that there is no doubt. He is one of the first in the row of thinkers who introduced that return to critical philosophy which is characteristic of the last generation's philosophizing. He himself designated his thinking, in opposition to Hegel's, as *qualitative dialectic*, by which he wanted to express it as his chief endeavor to make the qualitative distinctions count, to maintain the fixed boundaries between the different domains, whereas the preceding, romantic-speculative period wallowed to excess in unity and continuity. His watchword was *Either–Or*. It was the title of his first significant work; it was the category he maintained as the decisive one; it was the name by which he was known to the boys in the street. He declares war on continuity and successive transition; they are for him the categories of superficiality and softness. Life and reality move, by his assertion, forward

¹²In my exposition of the doctrine of categories (*Den menneskelige Tanke*, pp. 154–162) it is shown how synthesis and relation, continuity and discontinuity, likeness and difference are constantly at strife in fundamental human thinking.

over constant crossroads, through constant leaps. Something decisive is reached only by a jerk, a sudden swing, that cannot be foreseen from, and is not determined by, what precedes.

Spiritual life is in this respect, according to Kierkegaard, subject to wholly different conditions than natural life. He denies most definitely that there is any analogy between spiritual development and organic development. Qualitative metamorphosis, in which the new stage, the higher state, comes into force by a jerk of decision or by a leap, is what is peculiar to the development of spiritual life, whereas organic development, e.g. a plant's growth, consists in a successive unfolding of what essentially was already in the germ. In that the transition is a leap, there comes a break in the inner, natural coherence (in "immanence"); an absolute New is posited. The continuity that thought can produce is purely abstract and in reality illusory: the real coherence must, in spiritual life, be produced by ever-new exertion, by the work of repetition, which in the new reality holds fast what was won from the past, and which by no means continues its subsistence of itself.

2. This peculiarity of Søren Kierkegaard's thinking displays itself especially in the manner in which he conceives *the relation between psychology and ethics*—a relation in which, on the whole, a thinker's peculiarity will as a rule most clearly display itself.

He was a psychologist of the first rank in his ability to grasp the greatest oppositions and the finest nuances, the most violent storms and the smallest ripples within the life of the soul. He was a well-traveled man on the waters of the inner life, and he had poetic power to present what he had seen.—But he did not have merely the observer's interest. He also felt a passionate urge to understand. His whole strong emphasis on the paradox, on the irrational, on the sudden jerk that abolishes coherence, would also be unintelligible if he had not himself felt the urge to hold fast to continuity. The doctrine of truth as the paradox is an expression of the fact that this urge has been disappointed. Those in whom the urge to knowledge is not alive are spared this disappointment, do not discover the irrational, and will wholly lack the presuppositions for understanding the passion an intellect like Kierkegaard's feels in striking against the limit of thought. The pain of the halt is felt only by one who comes at full speed.—"The paradox," says Kierkegaard (*Philosophical Fragments*), "is the passion of thought, and the thinker who is without the paradox is like the lover who is without passion: a mediocre fellow. But the highest potentiation of every passion is always to will its own downfall, and so it is also the understanding's highest passion to will the collision, although in one way or another the collision must become its downfall. This, then, is thinking's highest paradox:

to want to discover something that thought itself cannot think.”

From this it can be seen that, even though one can divide thinkers into two classes, only *that one* can be great within his own class in whom there stirs a strong urge in the direction that characterizes the other class. Only through a strong urge to coherence is the break, the jerk, discovered and felt.

As a psychologist Kierkegaard holds to coherence as far as he can; but as an ethicist he posits the leap, the jerk of decision. He finds the task of psychology in seeking out the possibilities of the new states, the successive and quantitative approximations. It has to do with the approaches, the motives, the preparations. But however far it comes in its “calculation of the angles of possibilities,” when the point comes at which the properly, ethically significant decision takes place, there comes a qualitative jerk by which the new is posited; a radical change occurs that finds no explanation whatsoever in what went before.

3. In the brilliant treatise *The Concept of Anxiety*, whose theme, as we have seen above, played a great role in his youthful life, Kierkegaard develops this relation between the psychological and the ethical way of regarding things.—He here treats the will's decision at “the Fall,” following the narrative in the first book of Moses. It might seem that it would have been more illuminating had he used one of his usual psychological experiments. But the difference is not great, for although he protested against that old narrative being a myth, he in fact treats it as a myth and with all desirable freedom.—The concern is to depict how the Fall could occur, since man is presupposed to be in the state of innocence.

First psychology sets to work to find possibilities and approximations. One such is offered by anxiety. While fear relates to a definite possibility, anxiety relates to an indefinite possibility, a dream that emerges in the imagination of innocence, in itself a nothing—which nevertheless comes to stand as though it were something. And besides this interplay of coming and vanishing, there asserts itself in anxiety yet another interplay: of attraction and repulsion, sympathy and antipathy, approach and recoil. The object of anxiety exerts a power over the mind, draws it to itself—and yet repels it. Thus it is in bashfulness. What is the bashful person ashamed of? Nothing, after all, has been said and nothing done; only a possibility went by, without even being grasped by a definite thought—and this possibility was rejected, though scarcely noticed. What is there to be ashamed of, to blush over? And thus it is with dizziness. The possibility of letting oneself fall, of giving up one's equilibrium, offers itself when the gaze measures the abyss; but it is a possibility that gets no time to fix itself, but is at once rejected, again and again rejected, and yet it causes dread, because it draws.

Here is a possibility, an approximation—but which, according to Kierkegaard, explains nothing when the decision comes, when the Fall really occurs. This comes with a jerk, or as a leap—incomprehensible and ungrounded by all that went before.—Just as suddenly as all possibilities and approximations are thus swept away, ethics steps into the place of psychology. It asks about differences of quality, about the opposition between good and evil, and cares nothing at all about all that psychology has laboriously calculated concerning the “angles of possibilities.” Reality stands in no relation to possibility.—This conception is extended to hold for the relation of the individual action to the acquired character, and for the relation of the individual to the nature inherited from the race: what is given from the past (both the race's and the individual's own) are possibilities, approximations, that in the moment of real decision signify nothing. And this although Kierkegaard admits that by habit and practice the possibilities and dispositions in the individual's character are summed up, just as, in the matter of race- and family-qualities, happens in the whole race. By the quantity the new quality that is posited by the decision is to be *wholly incapable* of being explained! The continuous growth of the possibilities is broken off by the jerk of reality.—

I cannot see it otherwise than that Kierkegaard, by this conception, entangles himself in a very great contradiction. His recognition of psychology in its independence of ethics must rest on the significance that can be attributed to the possibilities and approximations that psychology can demonstrate. But now these are, however far they may go, in the end not to signify the very least! We then get possibilities that are not possibilities of anything, approximations to nothing! Psychological understanding—and with it not merely theoretical psychology, but also practical knowledge of human beings—then becomes useless, indeed illusory.

Kierkegaard has in *The Concept of Anxiety* disavowed his watchword “Either–Or” and wanted to try to carry through a “Both–And.” Indeed, strictly speaking, he has wanted to have *both an* “Either–Or” *and a* “Both–And.” He has not wanted to choose between leap and continuity, but has wanted to combine both! But he has thereby only succeeded in falling into Scylla without avoiding Charybdis. He has offended the interest both of ethics and of psychology by tearing apart the bond between possibility and reality. For just as little as psychology can put up with the possibilities it is able to demonstrate being wholly unable to ground the real decision—even though it be willingly admitted that a complete grounding is an ideal (and that for the reason that not *all* possibilities can be discovered)—just as little can ethics put up with the ethical evaluation concerning only the finished result, the sharp turn, and not also the approaches, the dispositions,

the motives. For the practical ethical way of regarding things the concern is precisely to get hold of the possibilities, in order to arrest the pernicious reality in its growth, and in order to shield and foster the good germs.

On closer inspection Kierkegaard, too, does not avoid extending the evaluation to what precedes the jerk of decision, to the approaches before the leap. He indeed maintains definitely that anxiety is *not* any *imperfection* in the human being; but later he nonetheless declares anxiety to be “the most *selfish*” thing, and speaks of how the indefinite possibility “*burdeningly* causes dread by its sweet anxiousness,” and how anxiety “maintains a *sly* communication with its object.” Here the evaluation is antedated, or a decision is assumed before—the decision—that is to say: the possibility is taken for (what it also is) a partial reality. Kierkegaard has not been able to carry through the sovereign contempt for the approximative and the hypothetical that lay at the basis of his distinction between “essential” and “inessential” knowledge. He protests against “laying out the circle of the leap into a straight line”; but he has not considered that the greater the radius of the circle, the more the arc approaches a straight line, or that a circumference can be conceived as consisting of an infinite number of infinitely small straight lines. Continuity in thought and in nature does not let itself be chased away so easily as Kierkegaard thought.

4. Hitherto we have spoken of the leap or jerk only from the negative side, conceived the decision as an interruption. But can there not be given a positive description or determination of it? It is characteristic of Kierkegaard as a thinker that, although by the category of the leap he wants to break the bridge behind him, his thought nevertheless cannot refrain from circling about the place where the interruption occurs. The incomprehensible leap he wants to approach as closely as possible. He is, so far as I know, the only indeterminist thinker who has attempted to describe the leap. It is, philosophically regarded, one of the most remarkable developments of thought to be found in him.

“The history of the individual life,” he says (in *The Concept of Anxiety*), “proceeds in a movement from state to state. Every state is posited by a leap. . . Prior to every such leap there goes a state as the nearest psychological approximation. This state is the object of psychology.”—Thus the leap lies *between two states*. Or, more precisely, as it is said in another place, *between two moments*. “Anxiety may be compared with dizziness. He whose eye happens to look down into a yawning deep becomes dizzy. . . In this dizziness freedom sinks down. Further psychology cannot go and will not. In that same moment everything is changed, and when freedom rises up again, it sees that it is guilty. Between

these two moments lies the leap, which no science has explained or can explain.”

It seems to be clear that if the leap lies between two states or between two moments, no observation can catch sight of it. The description of it then becomes no description, since it can never become a phenomenon. What Kierkegaard wants to grasp by his description slips away between his fingers. He describes a succession of two moments or states (and what else, indeed, can here be observed or described?), but what lies in between he does not get hold of, and cannot get hold of. And yet he speaks so dogmatically about it as if it were quite possible. I have devoted much reflection to the passages cited from *The Concept of Anxiety*, and was at first inclined to take it as Kierkegaard's meaning that the leap could not be observed. Then his development would be a counterpart to Hume's famous demonstration that causality cannot be observed, since what we observe is always only succession. Just as little as causality or continuity can be observed, just as little can a break in continuity be. The moments succeed one another—but what is the relation between two moments? Here is the great problem that divides the two groups of thinkers characterized above, of which the one maintains continuity (through the causal relation), the other discontinuity (through the indeterminate appearance of new qualities). If observation could decide the matter, the dispute could easily be settled. But even by the most exact, most microscopic observation we succeed only in dividing the moments into smaller moments, and the problem, the fundamental problem in the theory of knowledge, returns.—But on closer consideration I cannot attribute to Kierkegaard a clear eye for the point of principle in the question. His dogmatic presuppositions and his propensity for poetic images have here veiled his eye for the problem in its sharpness. Otherwise he must also have become aware that he really lets the whole decision (the *will's* decision!) take place unconsciously. For what lies between two states of consciousness or moments of consciousness happens unconsciously, does not raise itself above the threshold of consciousness. A decision of the will of the kind Kierkegaard is dealing with must surely be a willing of the highest form, a choice in the proper sense, a resolution, a deliberate act. But how can a resolution lie between two moments? Only that kind of “resolution” can, which one arrives at in one's sleep. Only involuntary acts can be unconscious. But Kierkegaard has surely hardly thought of “the leap” as a reflex effect!—

Looking more closely, Kierkegaard, too, involuntarily comes to place the decision at the first moment, when “the individual sinks down in the impotence of anxiety.” We then get a causal series: anxiety—dizziness—sinking—fall; and where, then, has the leap gone? He who sinks does not leap; sinking is (even if to sink is *to let oneself sink*) nothing

but a beginning fall, a fall that could be prevented—if one were not standing precisely at an abyss.—Still more clearly does this antedating of the decision appear in a passage already cited: “He whose eye happens to look down into a yawning deep becomes dizzy. But *what is the cause? It is just as much his eye as the abyss; for suppose he had not stared down there!*” The guilt, then, lies only in part with the eye; here too Kierkegaard gives up his Either–Or. But the main thing is: has the eye any guilt here? There is an involuntary urge to let the eye roam about, an urge that cannot be said to be of the evil. That the eye, in this its involuntary roaming—which is the way to all significant experiences and thereby to all higher development—now also, among other things, strikes upon the abyss and regards it with involuntary attention, cannot be its own guilt; for it did not know beforehand that the abyss was there, did not even know what an abyss was. And when the dizziness is awakened by the representation of the possible fall arising and working on the mind, there occurs indeed a transition from the involuntary to the deliberate (insofar as by deliberateness one understands a conduct determined by preceding representations), but this transition itself takes place *involuntarily*, in virtue of the laws of the association of representations. Even if the fall occurs with intent, no intent is possible (as Shakespeare and Spinoza have taught us) without memory, and memory can present itself just as involuntarily as the abyss presents itself to the roaming eye. It is thus possible to carry through the psychological continuity even further than Kierkegaard has done; and by his antedating of the point at which he places the decisive guilt, he in effect admits that ethics does not stand or fall with “the leap.”

Kierkegaard has, then, in *The Concept of Anxiety* given psychology far more than he can consistently. But these were only passing concessions. His chief grip is and remains Either–Or, the jerk or leap of qualitative decision; with it he operates everywhere in his ethics. And in his strictly religious writings, especially later on, when his conception of the Christian sharpened, there is no trace of the decision lying *between* two moments of consciousness. There he pushes all psychology away from under his feet by an utterance such as this: “To assert that a person *knowingly* does what is wrong—does what is wrong with his knowledge of the right—Greek antiquity has not the courage” (*The Sickness unto Death*). What happens *knowingly* must fill a moment or a state, which must be capable of being observed. Kierkegaard has, to be sure, not given us this observation. He has not wanted to. But—he has also not been able to.

b. The Stages

The most important contribution to ethical thinking from Søren Kierkegaard's hand is his presentation of what he calls "the stages of life." Each stage is a life-state, a view of life, which Kierkegaard has presented partly in poetic form, partly with conceptual rigor, without—as will be seen in the following—the poetic and the philosophical presentation always agreeing with each other. At no point, however, does his brilliant poetic-psychological endowment appear so clearly as here. To give a comparative philosophy of life he was equipped as few are, and what he in his way and from his vantage point has given in this direction will surely be continued under other forms and from other points of view. Ever more, it seems, the need for "subjective thinking," for thinking about life in close connection with life, asserts itself, and there is here a task that cannot be treated satisfactorily by mere novelists. One must dig deeper than that.

Between the different stages the transition occurs, according to Kierkegaard, by one of those leaps we have just discussed. Within each stage the consequences of the standpoint posited by the leap unfold.—A distinction is made between three main stages: the aesthetic, the ethical, and the religious. Between the aesthetic and the ethical stage irony forms a transitional form, just as humor forms an intermediate form between the ethical and the religious stage.

α. The Aesthetic View of Life

1. The first stage is the aesthetic. It is depicted in the first part of *Either–Or* and in the first section of *Stages on Life's Way*. As far as the general conceptual determinations are concerned, it appears most decisively and clearly for this stage in the essay "The Rotation of Crops" (*Vexeldriften. An Attempt at a Theory of Social Prudence*, in the first part of *Either–Or*).

This way of taking life seeks to transform it into mere possibilities, with which one lets the imagination have its free play. Everything is made an object of enjoyment, but by this one must think not so much of immediate, sensuous enjoyment—though this enters in—as of the arbitrariness with which everything is apprehended and treated: "The whole secret lies in arbitrariness. People think it is no art to be arbitrary in such a way that one does not oneself get lost in it, that one oneself has pleasure from it." What matters is to transform the whole of existence for oneself into a kaleidoscope, which one constantly shakes in order to delight in the various accidental combinations that in this way can arbitrarily be produced.

In order that this free play may stand in one's power, one must not personally bind

oneself in any relation of life, not settle down at any point in existence in such a way that one is held fast, so that continuation and repetition exclude the production of new kaleidoscopic situations. One must keep oneself in "complete hovering." Therefore, to be sure, contact with people, often also for a while accompanying them on the way—but always securing for oneself such a speed that one can break off the fellowship when one wishes.¹³ Friendship is too fixed and solid a relation. And even if a needful rupture should leave behind unpleasant memories, the unpleasant can indeed give a piquant aftertaste that it may be worth taking along. In a similar way it stands with marriage. Love has its time; but if one promises that it shall last eternally, one promises more than one can keep. And besides, there is this danger in marriage, that one loses one's freedom: "one cannot order travel-boots when one wishes, cannot rove about restlessly." ("There has indeed been an example of a gypsy woman carrying her husband on her back through life, but partly this is a rarity, partly also, in the long run, tiring—for the husband.") Finally, by getting involved with marriage one is compelled to come under the dominion that custom and usage exercise; a whole circle of considerations and duties excludes arbitrary roving. Thus, to be sure, eroticism, but not marriage. And just as little any occupation of a calling: thereby one would make oneself a cog in the great social machine, no longer be the master of the enterprise oneself. One should of course not be inactive, but pursue all sorts of breadless arts, take care that the occupation constantly bears the stamp of idleness.

2. This stage shows itself most characteristically in the relation between man and woman. There is, indeed, in this relation too application enough for the rotation-method or the kaleidoscope, since it can run through a whole scale, vibrate in very different directions, branch out into manifold derived relations. There is possibility here for a series of the most opposite moods and passions: from high-spirited jest to deep earnestness, from

¹³The aesthetic view of life, according to Kierkegaard's depiction, especially recalls in this trait Aristippus of Cyrene. What he maintained as the highest was indeed the enjoyment of the moment, but the condition for reaching this was for him precisely the complete freedom that does not let itself be bound and imprisoned. Therefore he would (as he says to Socrates in the conversation in Xenophon: *Memorabilia* II, 1) not enter into any civil relation, but be a stranger or guest everywhere (οὐδ' εἰς πολιτείαν ἑμαυτὸν κατακλείω, ἀλλὰ ξένος πανταχοῦ εἰμι). He wants to be free, neither ruler nor slave. According to the other traits reported of him, it was especially the preservation of freedom in the face of the ensnaring element in enjoyment itself that was his gift. In this respect he was a true virtuoso. The contradiction in his view of life was that so much art and preparation was nevertheless required, with the use of the past's experiences and of prospects for the future, that many moments had to pass without immediate enjoyment. Really, the highest for Aristippus had to become virtuosity itself—and so it is for the modern hedonism Kierkegaard describes. Characteristic of the difference between the modern and the ancient is precisely that in modern hedonism a wholly decisive weight is laid on arbitrariness, on active experimenting, the conscious production of situations. In Aristippus arbitrariness expresses itself merely in the ability to choose without bias among what offers itself; it lacks the somewhat romantic arranging that the modern age's greater self-consciousness, and likewise its less naive and trustful relation to life, brings with it.

frivolous flirtation to heartfelt devotion, from flaring enthusiasm to steady fidelity, from the brutal stirring of a pure natural instinct to the sublime feeling of spiritual belonging-together. And through its consequences the relation of the sexes leads, moreover, beyond the mutual relation of the individuals into connection with the life of society, of the race, intervenes in this and is determined by it in its fate and its character. Here, then, is a great range of play. If one of the many strings is struck with the requisite art, one can get more or fewer of the others to vibrate along, without their yet taking the mastery. No wonder that one of the poets' chief themes has at all times lain here. And it is for the same reason that Kierkegaard especially characterizes his "aesthetic stage" from this point of view. It is one of the points where he has with lavish hand strewn his most brilliant images and presentations, and there are many who know him as an author only from this part of his production. (*The Seducer's Diary* in the first part of *Either–Or*. *The Banquet* in the first section of *Stages on Life's Way*.) Here, where the concern is not an investigation of his literary art and greatness (which would lie beyond my ability and has, besides, been done so brilliantly in Georg Brandes' book that I have merely to refer to it), but the philosophical significance of his presentation, I can content myself with bringing out a couple of the most characteristic passages.

"The Young Man" who is present at "The Banquet" has come to a halt at the contradictory and comic element that for him lies in the erotic relation, in that it seems to concern the individuals' highest desire—and yet it is the species whose propagation is to be secured through the awakened instincts.—"The lovers want to belong to each other for all eternities. This they express in that strange way by enclosing each other in the inwardness of the moment, and all the bliss and desire of love is to lie therein... And yet they are deceived; for in that same moment the species triumphs over the individuals, the species conquers while the individuals are reduced to being in its service... When the lovers have found each other, one should think they were a whole, and therein should lie the truth of their wanting to live for each other in all eternities. But lo, they begin, instead of living for each other, to live in the species, and this they do not suspect." In the face of this irrational element in love the Young Man has come to a halt. He understands well the introduction to it, the being-seized in it—but he does not understand the consequence.¹⁴

Johannes the Seducer, the last in the row of the Banquet's brilliant speakers, states the "aesthetic view of life's" position of principle toward the problem the Young Man has brought out. He tells how the gods feared that man, the original human being, would

¹⁴The thought developed in the young man's speech was at the same time developed, in more natural-historical form, by Schopenhauer in his »Metaphysik der Geschlechtsliebe« (chapter 44 in the fourth book of the second part of »Welt als Wille und Vorstellung«, which appeared in 1844, the year after *Either–Or*).

show himself unwilling to bear their yoke, that he might even bring heaven to totter. By force he could not be compelled; then they produced woman to enchant him and “catch him in all the diffuseness of finitude.” And the bait worked—yet not always. “There were at all times some men, a few, who became aware of the deception. These indeed saw her loveliness, more than anyone else, but they suspected the connection. These I call Erotici, and count myself in their number; the men call them Seducers, woman has no name for them, such a one is for her unnameable. These Erotici are the happy ones. They live more sumptuously than the gods; for they eat constantly only what is more delicious than ambrosia and drink what is more delicious than nectar: they eat the most seductive fancy of the gods’ shrewdest thought, they eat constantly only bait—o voluptuousness without equal, o blessed way of life—they eat constantly only the bait—they are never caught. The other men grab and eat bait as peasants eat cucumber salad, and are caught.”

3. The aesthetic view of life places the highest in being a tangent to the circle of life, in seizing the momentary contact, but then at the right time going away by virtue of the “centrifugal” (midpoint-fleeing) force. It does not let itself be made a planet. At most it engages—for the sake of the “rotation-method”—in tangencing the circle a second time, like a comet, at another point. The erotic relation is precisely a relation where the momentary contact can quite rightly, as the Young Man feared, become constitutive for wholly new, untried life-relations and tasks. But if the hovering of arbitrariness is to be preserved, one must break off in time. Whether greater fullness of life, more inward understanding of life and feeling for life, might be attained if one “let oneself be caught”? The “aesthete” does not know it, will not and cannot know it. If any inkling of this were possible, then the transition from the aesthetic stage to the following one would not be a leap, but could come about by a motivating growth. It is characteristic what Kierkegaard wrote in his own copy of *Either–Or*: “A real falling-in-love could not be used in the first part; for it always grips a person so deeply that he enters the ethical. What I could use was a multiplicity of erotic moods.” Under “the aesthetic stage” Kierkegaard presents figures who have come far beyond the immediate, the involuntary, the nature-forceful, and have practiced an art of arbitrariness, an ability to point up, not merely to seize the piquant, but also to produce the piquant where it does not offer itself of its own accord. It is not a standpoint that people easily reach. It lies, as already remarked, a good stretch further out in reflection than ancient hedonism.

Here there arises, from the standpoint of a comparative philosophy of life, the objection that we are not told how this stage comes to be. As Kierkegaard himself has seen, there can lie in the natural instinct a drawing power that leads beyond the aesthetic

stage, and by whose working the "aesthetic" is only a co-operating element. How, then, did there enter the halt, the deflecting movement, by which the individual went away along the tangent instead of continuing the movement around the center under whose influence it had momentarily come? The childlike forgetting of one moment for the sake of another is something quite different from this artistic or artificial rotation-method. It is the genetic or evolutionary way of viewing that is wholly lacking in the Kierkegaardian presentation of the stages. He even deliberately keeps away the forces that at the one stage could contain an announcement of the next. Thereby each single stage comes (in quite good agreement, to be sure, with the theory of the leap) to stand as something fully finished, which points neither forward nor backward. It is finished figures that he depicts. They have "run themselves fast"—not in any relation of life, but in their way of taking life. They have done away with all possibilities. Even the last possibility—the one that rests on the relation of contrast, on the tendency a strongly tensed state of soul has to strike over into its opposite, a possibility of very great significance during the development of the life of the soul—even that seems to be no longer present for these "aesthetes," in whom enjoyment and reflection have blunted or burned out the force that is presupposed if even the mere contrast-effect (which is really a phenomenon of fatigue) is to be able to take place. The psychological thought-experiment has here given such extreme forms as life probably does not present. It is, then, a little apt name that Kierkegaard uses when he calls what he depicts stages. By a stage one thinks of a link in a development; but about the Kierkegaardian stages one is not told whence they come, and at bottom (for "the leap" is no answer) neither whither they go. His depiction recalls rather Dante's *Divina Commedia* with its three divisions—and the aesthetic stage then corresponds to hell, over whose entrance stands written: You who enter, abandon hope!

Kierkegaard has undeniably—the in other respects masterly quality of his depiction left unmentioned—thereby made the task easier for himself than it is.—How all forms of thought contain temptations! There was a temptation in the quantitative dialectic (the unity of oppositions) in the direction of regarding things as simpler than they are; but the qualitative dialectic, the philosophy of the leap, shows itself also to have a temptation in the same direction.

Everywhere that a development is possible, it is not from the fully finished forms, in which life has as it were run itself fast, but from the more indeterminate, vague, little-differentiated forms. It is only the popular misunderstanding of the doctrine of development that lets one of the species we now have descend from another (man, e.g., from the ape). According to the doctrine of development the now-existing species

descend from forms that had only “a general likeness” with those that have arisen from them in the course of development. This lies simply in the fact that all development is a differentiation, an arising of differences. Such a process is impossible where everything is beforehand pointed up, formed, and driven out to the utmost tip. The tip can be broken off, but no new form comes out of that.

If one wants to understand how a new stage can develop out of a given stage, one must therefore not hold to this in its fully finished form, but must go back to an earlier stage of development, where the now-finished stage was in its becoming and still had a more indeterminate shape. Only where there is becoming and indeterminacy are there possibilities. That Kierkegaard himself has taught us; but he will, once and for all, when it is a matter of decision, have nothing at all to do with the possibilities. One must go back to the point where the way divided—like a railway train that has come onto a wrong track, one must go back to the switch-point. At the switch-point the real decision takes place—but it does not always step up into consciousness; it can happen half-consciously or unconsciously. We are, by a natural psychological illusion, inclined to *postdate* our decisions and, on the whole, to attribute to our conscious choice greater significance than it has. It is often merely the conscious keystone.—Here the psychological and the ethical interest show themselves in their harmony. In the face of the unmotivated and unprepared leap we would stand wholly helpless, and the ethical judgments would be mere outbursts of feeling without practical significance, since they would come afterward and could get no influence at all on the next leap. Only by going back to the possibilities of development, that is, to the unfinished stages, can one do something (however much or however little it may be) to determine the future.

β. The Ethical View of Life

1. In the conception of the ethical view of life there appears a discrepancy between the poetic presentations in *Either–Or* (second part), in *Stages on Life's Way* (second section), and *Fear and Trembling* on the one hand, and the philosophical characterization in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* on the other—a discrepancy that shows itself to be a contradiction pointing to a decisive change in Kierkegaard's ideas.—We hold first to the poetic depictions (and especially to the two first named, since *Fear and Trembling* can better be discussed in connection with the religious view of life).

While the aesthetic stage dissolves all relations of reality into mere possibilities, with which imagination and mood can drive their arbitrary play, reality, earnestness, and responsibility are the chief determinations at the ethical stage. And in that here too

the relation between man and woman is used for the poetic illumination of the view of life, marriage appears as the expression of the ethical. Marriage distinguishes itself from the merely erotic relation in that to falling-in-love there is added a resolution. In the resolution lies, ethically regarded, the whole ideality of the human being. But the question now is: how can deliberation and resolution find application there where immediate feeling and passion alone could seem to have the word? Kierkegaard's answer to this is fine and beautiful. Deliberation and resolution, he says, have nothing to do with falling-in-love itself: "The holy place of falling-in-love, the consecrated ground of immediacy, they dare not tread." What they have to do with is "the relation of falling-in-love to reality." What matters is whether one dares take up the relation posited by falling-in-love and carry it through in reality, in the face of danger and temptation, and with the consciousness of the universally human in the relation of communal life that is founded.—Thus falling-in-love is presupposed as given, as the constituting element, and the resolution appears as the protecting power that guards against inner and outer dangers. While the development given of these thoughts is beautiful and rich (most successful in the *Stages*, rather drawn-out in the second part of *Either–Or*), there are, it seems to me, several psychological determinations lacking. Kierkegaard has too dogmatic a concept of "the resolution." It appears as a *deus ex machina* and stands in a rather external relation to "falling-in-love," with which it is nonetheless to enter into the most inward connection, in order that the marriage may come to be—and, what must especially be noted, by which it must from the first have been called forth and motivated. The resolution here in question must have sprung from the individual's personality, its real self, and have been produced by the manner in which this central element in the individual is determined by the newly awakened passion. A multitude of different relations can here be possible: falling-in-love can, in manifold different ways, affect the innermost I. It can enclose and cover it, but also merely touch it at the periphery; it can bring wholly new elements to life in it, supplement and expand it, but it can also work as a demonic power that narrows and isolates. And these different ways of affecting can appear successively in the same individual, in the same erotic relation. The ground on which the resolution in question rests—namely the relation between the new feeling and the central element in the I—can therefore be indeterminate and shifting; there is possibility for several illusions and anticipations in the motivating presuppositions of the resolution. And to this is added, further, that in the period of life in which marriages are most frequently founded, the characters are not yet fully developed. Even if there is now present the agreement or the supplementing opposition that makes the communal

life possible and happy, it is not thereby said that the continued development of the two characters will remain in the same tracks: they can each for itself develop ably and soundly—and yet the tracks can part. The problems that thereby arise, and the tragedies that thereby become possible, Kierkegaard does not go into. This is connected with the psychological dogmatism in his concept of the resolution; but it is also connected with a dogmatism in his concept of marriage. He sees it merely as fully finished in its ideal shape and then declares: all or nothing. Finally, it is also connected with his regarding marriage as a religious institution. That resolution becomes in his eyes impossible without religious assurance. And—characteristic of his conception of woman—in the case of women there is no question of resolution: “A feminine soul has not, and shall not have, the reflection that man has. Thus she shall therefore not reach the resolution. But swift as the bird she reaches from aesthetic immediacy to the religious.” In the case of woman, then, the ethical stage falls away! And in the case of man too, really, since “the resolution” is not to be thinkable without religious presuppositions.—It will also appear in the following, from several sides, how the ethical view of life comes up short in Kierkegaard's presentations.

2. In the transition from the aesthetic to the ethical stage the concept of *Repetition* plays an important role. It is akin to the resolution, but does not coincide with it. It forms, like the resolution, a boundary between the aesthetic and the ethical. Aesthetic it is to rock oneself in moods and impressions; but these had then best be new, shifting impressions. Ethically one returns with inwardness and fidelity to the same; repetition is in a certain sense the ethical art: “the watchword in every ethical view.” But repetition plays a role not only in the coming to be of the resolution; it comes forward again in the resolution's transition to action: in the resolution I have, after all, anticipated the action; the resolution is an ideal, a possible action; but now it is a question of whether I can repeat, that is, convert the possible into reality, although reality here is only a repetition of what was contained in the possibility. And yet once more repetition comes forward, when I have victoriously carried through my resolution, won my cause. For in the intoxication of victory the concern is not to forget the task of maintaining what has been won, of continuing what has been carried out: “Character is not so much to conquer as to endure after having conquered, to preserve oneself in character” (cf. *Repetition. An Attempt in Experimenting Psychology*).

The concept of repetition places Kierkegaard's philosophy in a characteristic contrast to Hegel's doctrine of the reconciliation of oppositions (mediation) in a higher unity. “Repetition,” says Kierkegaard, “is really what, by a mistake, has been called mediation.”

The mistake consisted in regarding the reconciliation of oppositions as self-evident, as determined by the very nature of the terms of the opposition. In the domain of the will it is, according to Kierkegaard, otherwise. There a psychologically inexplicable act of will is required to connect the conflicting elements; a new factor, then, is added besides these. It is this that makes him, as already mentioned, deny the analogy between spiritual and organic development. According to Hegel's conception the higher unity arises by one's returning from the second term of the opposition to the first: but precisely this return is the great problem for Kierkegaard, the one that marks the boundary between the aesthetic and the ethical way of taking life. It marks the point where the will's intervention—thus, according to Kierkegaard: the jerk, the leap—has its place. Aesthetically one goes away along the tangent; a peculiar force must be postulated that can hold the sphere fast in an orbit around the same center.

In the writing *Repetition* Kierkegaard has developed the significance of this concept with a lavishness of poetic ornament that makes it a pearl in the rich treasury of his works, although it cannot be denied that the poetic apparatus spreads out at the expense of the concept and the thought. Kierkegaard complains loudly of Heiberg's misunderstanding of his meaning; but he had not done enough to secure a clear understanding.—I cannot refrain from citing a piece of the said writing, which in the most beautiful way expresses the thinker's idea.

“Hope is a new garment, stiff and taut and glittering, yet one has never had it on, and therefore does not know how it will suit one, or how it sits. Recollection is a discarded garment which, however beautiful it may be, does not fit, since one has outgrown it. Repetition is an indestructible garment that fits closely and tenderly, neither pinches nor flaps. Hope is a lovely maiden who slips away between one's hands; recollection is a beautiful old woman with whom one is nevertheless never served in the moment; repetition is a beloved wife of whom one never grows weary... It takes youth to hope, youth to recollect, but it takes courage to will repetition. He who will merely hope is cowardly; he who will merely recollect is voluptuous; but he who wills repetition is a man, and the more emphatically he has known how to make it clear to himself, the deeper a human being he is. But he who does not grasp that life is a repetition, and that this is the beauty of life, he has condemned himself and deserves nothing better than what will befall him: to perish; for hope is a beckoning fruit that does not satisfy; recollection is a paltry pittance that does not satisfy; but repetition is the daily bread that

satisfies with blessing. When one has sailed around existence, then it will show itself whether one has courage to understand that life is a repetition, and desire to rejoice in this. Yea, if there were no repetition, what then would life be? Who could wish to be a tablet on which time wrote a new script each moment, or a memorial of the past? Who could wish to let himself be moved by all the fleeting, the new, that always softly delights the soul?"

It shows itself, however, in the concept of repetition too, that the ethical stage is not kept apart from the religious. For repetition—which in Kierkegaard really means willing, acting, active intervention, and which he therefore calls the watchword of the ethical view—is nonetheless for him really a religious category. The young man depicted in *Repetition* only attains to "repeating," to living life, through a religious movement. Repetition means, on the whole, concentration, return and immersion in oneself—and since now the deepest self-understanding, according to Kierkegaard, occurs in the religious, it is explicable how repetition, which first marks the boundary between the aesthetic and the ethical, can also appear as a religious concept.

But whether repetition is conceived ethically or religiously, it is, according to Kierkegaard, not to be grounded psychologically. It is "transcendent," presupposes on the one side a "jerk of decision," on the other a relation to a supernatural principle. Here too he has surely himself leapt too early from psychology. For the feelings that are attached to a richer content of thought—and of this kind are especially those due to the relation to other personalities—repetition is very well intelligible in virtue of general psychological laws. But since I have elsewhere (in my *Psychology*) expressed myself more fully on this, and with special regard to Kierkegaard, I shall not here go further into it.

3. While Kierkegaard in his poetic presentations posited marriage as the characteristic of the ethical stage, it is later (in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*) a wholly different concept that becomes for him the ethical chief concept: *the single individual*. Ethically regarded, the individual has to do only with himself, he maintains. "The individual's own ethical reality is the only reality." "Ethically there is no direct relation between subject and subject." The other's inner life I know only as possibility; immediately real to me is only my own inner life: it is there that the domain for my action lies.

There is between the poetic and the philosophical presentation a contradiction that Kierkegaard has not been aware of. When an enormous distance is placed between individual and individual, and each has to do only with himself: how then can a relation of communal life without more ado be made into a type for the ethical?—This transition from emphasizing a relation of communal life to emphasizing the single individual by

himself signifies the emergence of one of Kierkegaard's most significant thoughts, and it agrees with his fundamental view; but it signifies at the same time, by the further developments attached to it, a transition to a religious-ascetic ethics. He leaves the relation of communal life in such a way that he later cannot find his way back to it.

The first time, so far as I know, "the single individual" appears is in the preface to *Two Edifying Discourses*, which appeared in the spring of 1843 (some months after *Either–Or*). Kierkegaard here relates how he let his eye follow the little book on its wandering. "I saw then how it went its way along solitary paths, or solitary along the frequented ones. After some little misunderstanding it at last met that single individual whom I with joy and gratitude call *my* reader, that single individual whom it seeks, after whom it as it were stretches out its arms."—Kierkegaard tells that he had decided to strike out this preface and therefore went up to the printing house, where it was already set; but the typesetter, who had been moved by it, begged that it might after all remain standing, and Kierkegaard then thought for a moment of having only two copies printed and presenting the typesetter with one: then *he* could indeed be the single individual!—So literally he did not take it with his "single" reader; but in his ethics he made all the stricter earnest of this concept. If one takes account of what is found here and there in his writings and posthumous papers to illuminate his grounding of this concept's significance, then the following points of view show themselves to be the most important.

a) In the single individual there occur the events that give spiritual life its value; there lie the tasks, and there the decisions are to take place. The race is a phantom, a fantastic medium; only the single individuals are realities, and each only for itself an immediate reality. If the race has a goal, then it in any case does not concern the single individual.

b) What others can do for me can only be to render awakening influences, and this is more indirect than direct, and is a difficult art, the one Socrates practiced, but which few can practice as he did. The single individual is "the category of the awakening of spirit," the narrow pass through which the race must go in order to reach the highest. The one human being cannot judge the other, because he cannot know him in his reality; but on the other hand it is also very little that the one human being can do and be for the other, and Kierkegaard says of himself: "As far back as I can remember, I was agreed with myself on one thing, that for me there was no comfort or help to be sought from others."

c) And not only, ethically regarded, does everything on the whole depend on self-activity; but also in the special determination of the degree and height to which the single individual is to attain in his willing and acting, he is referred to himself. "The

quantum satis of manly will” (to use Henrik Ibsen’s expression in *Brand*, whose work is here, as at several points, a poetic commentary on Søren Kierkegaard)—this only the single individual himself can find. No other can tell him where the boundary lies between lack of will and lack of ability, between sluggishness and selfishness and the limitation to which every finite being is subject. Others will rather hinder him from venturing too far out, say to him: “Spare yourself! This shall by no means happen to you!” “A human being can demand of himself exertions that the most well-meaning friend, if he knew of them, would advise against. . . . Everyone who has in truth ventured his life has had the standard of silence.” And this is all the more important, since it is only by venturing that one becomes rightly aware of oneself, gets one’s innermost being forth!

d) It is of importance that one act *at once*, as soon as the right knowledge is won. If an interval is inserted, then “the knowledge boils away.” And this will then easily be the consequence when I wait to apply it until I can transform the world, instead of beginning with what I have right at hand: myself. Hence it comes that our actions relate to our understanding—not as the faithful imprint of a picture, but—“as the blotting-paper to the writing by which it has lain!”

e) “Every human being is gloriously constituted, but what ruins so many is, among other things, also this unhappy talkativeness between man and man about what is to be suffered, but also matured, in silence.” The single individual—“not a single distinguished one, but every single one”—stands above the race. Here is the properly human, that by which the human being distinguishes himself from the animal. About the highest in me I therefore have no permission to speak with other human beings.—Hereby is understood, what has already been touched on, that irony is a transitional form between the aesthetic and the ethical. The ironist can (like Socrates) be seized by the ethical demand, but he is also seized by the opposition between what he thus has in his inner life and the outer reality; the incommensurability between the inner and the outer he expresses by treating himself as a finite and indifferent thing among existence’s many finitudes and indifferences. An ethicist can use irony as an incognito, in order not to become comic through the disproportion between what occupies him and what occupies the world. He thereby distinguishes himself from “an immediately enthusiastic person who bawls out into the world early and late, and always on the buskin plagues people with his enthusiasm, without noticing that it does not enthuse them.” But the ironist need not be an ethicist; he can have practiced the mere form. Kierkegaard hereby corrects his own earlier, more negative conception of Socratic irony in his doctoral dissertation.

The great ethical significance of the concept of “the single individual,” in the direction

both of realization and of inwardization, does not need to be demonstrated more closely. By it there is pointed, with sure energy, to what is and remains the ethical's first and most important domain, and at the same time its source and its constant abode: the single personality and the relation between the ideal that has here formed itself and the willing that here stirs. It is the first ethical idea, and it is emphasized in Kierkegaard partly over against the evaporation to which the contemplative and aesthetic tendency easily leads, in that the will is left out of consideration and the ideal becomes an object of mere beholding—partly over against the tendency to lose oneself in the social and historical way of regarding things, which does not worry about what goes on in the single inner life, provided only that the race on the whole or on the average shows changes in a certain direction. It seemed to Kierkegaard that existence would become meaningless if one did not see the highest value in the single individual: for how else is one to explain “the divine prodigality that uses the infinite host of individuals in one generation after another to get the world-historical development going”? How comfortless, if the highest were to be “the play of colors of the generation, like that of the herring-shoal in the sea,” while “the single herrings are not worth much”! Otherwise if the highest task lies in and for the single subjectivity: though the individuals be numberless as the sand of the sea, still the task of becoming a personality is set to each of them. World-history one must then leave to God, “the royal poet,” who alone can survey it.—“To the category of the single individual,” says Kierkegaard rightly in his “Report to History” (*The Point of View for My Work as an Author*), “my possible ethical significance is unconditionally attached.”

4. The concept of the single individual as the chief concept in ethics corresponds to the proposition “Subjectivity is the truth” as the chief proposition in the theory of knowledge. In analogy with this proposition one could set up the one: Subjectivity is the good. It does not depend on the content, the object, one relates oneself to in one's acting, or in one's knowing, but it depends on the inner, subjective movement. And Kierkegaard has really also set up this proposition, in that he expressly declares that the good cannot be defined, since it is nothing different from freedom (the will, subjectivity) (*The Concept of Anxiety*). But the same formal and inward willing could indeed be thought to have the most different content! If Kierkegaard had wanted to make earnest of his principle of subjectivity in ethics, then he must not have isolated the single individual from all relations of reality, all relations to other human beings: for it is only here that the ethical subjectivity can acquire a real content. An exclusive self-occupation is only possible in a monastic life, where there are no real tasks, but where the labors undertaken serve only for formal exercises. Here again it shows itself that the ethical stage gets no independence

in Kierkegaard. All the ethics he acknowledges is in reality religious and ascetic. The only content is the single individual's obedience to God. The ethical stands for him in absolute opposition to everything that can step forth and acquire significance for other human beings or in history. He could imagine "that God, without doing wrong, and without denying his essence, which is love, could create a human being equipped with abilities like no other, and set him in a remote place and say to him: now live through, in exertion like no other, the human; work, so that the half might be enough to transform a contemporary age; but you and I, we are agreed on this, *all your striving shall have no significance whatsoever for any other human being*, and yet you shall, you understand, you shall will the ethical, and you shall, you understand, you shall be enthusiastic, because this is the highest." When Kierkegaard accuses the social and historical way of regarding things of establishing an incomprehensible prodigality in the world, then it seems to me that he here squanders quite as much of human powers in his zeal to maintain the formal obedience, the subjective tension in the inner life, which for him is really the highest. To use an image I have already used about this (*On the Foundation of Humane Ethics*): Kierkegaard's ethics is here realized by the Egyptian monks who spent their lives watering sticks they had planted in the sand. It was a work that had absolutely nothing "social" or "world-historical" in it, and where there was truly need for "repetition" and for subjective exertion, if it was to be continued through a life. If obedience is the highest, no matter what it concerns, then here the highest is accomplished. But prodigality it is, for no real good, no purpose is attained thereby.

The purely subjective and formal ethics for which Kierkegaard pleads overlooks that the single personality is precisely first developed by life in the real human relations and through the work on tasks that have real significance, apart from the exercise attained by the work itself. The social ethical tasks are all such as aim at furthering the personal life in as many as possible; it is not externality, not compliance with "what the age demands" or world-historical self-importance, but a sound human feeling that wills that our work shall have more significance than merely being an exercise-lesson for us. When Kierkegaard himself thought that his "ethical significance" was attached to the category of the single individual, did he then merely mean that it had been beneficial for himself to occupy himself with this thought—or could he not here have written "historical significance" instead of "ethical" significance?—Only the intention of the action matters, according to Kierkegaard; the effects of the action are indifferent; ethics has only to do with the intention, world-history with the effects, and ethics has not to worry about world-history. But this separation between intention and effect is untenable. It must be

the task to foresee as many of my action's effects as possible, and if they do not occur, or if wholly different ones occur, then it can be my fault. All ethics rests on its being possible, to a certain degree, within a certain range, to foresee the effects of our actions. And we give up (when we are not ascetics) such actions whose effects are worthless.

Kierkegaard's forced one-sidedness on this point displays itself in that he can speak of human relations of communal life only in a mocking and sneering way. "It may indeed," he says thus in one place, "be very praiseworthy for the single individual that he is a councillor, a capable worker in the office, first lover in the Permanent, next to a virtuoso on the flute, king of the marksmen, director of an asylum, a noble father with dignity, in short a devil of a fellow who can do *both-and* and find time for everything." However apt his mockery is of the finitude and externality in human bustle, it is nonetheless strange that an author who wants to depict the ethical stage as a special form of life has no other tone to speak of human communal life in than this. It is misunderstood idealism. It is a romantic lack of ability to find the ideality in the seemingly prosaic and everyday. It is also a lack of ability to find the significance that relations and endeavors which seem low and comic in the eyes of a distinguished romantic can nevertheless have for the development of the personality. At the same time as Kierkegaard, under the depiction of the ethical stage, hastens forward toward the religious stage, he has retained not a little of the aesthetic in himself. In this respect the following journal entry is especially characteristic: "The ages one can learn from with respect to ideality are: the child, the youth, the young girl, the old man;—from the active man, from the busy housewife one does not learn in that respect, and why not? because they are essentially occupied with the purposes of finitude." Here it shows itself that Kierkegaard has forgotten his own book on repetition; he now praises hope and recollection as the only forms of ideality; reality itself becomes lost to him. For if he is right that there must always be striving and working *by* single individuals, it is no less true that there must always be working and laboring *in* and *on* single, definite, and therefore finite tasks. Here the concern is for the ethicist to have the psychological and historical eye that can see the great in the small, the significant in the insignificant. But both psychology and history are regarded by Kierkegaard as the enemies of ethics.

Finally, I cannot hold back the remark that Kierkegaard's absolute rejection of all social ethics is also connected with his conservative disposition and absolute respect for all authorities. He who at an audience with Christian VIII condescended to say to the king: "Your Majesty's only misfortune is that your wisdom and shrewdness are too great and the country too small; it is a misfortune to be a genius in a market town"

[alas, the little country could very well have had use for the whole royal wisdom—and more besides],—he who in the policeman's baton saw a reflection of the absolute principle of authority,—he thought at bottom that everything concerning society was the government's business to take care of, and that it was only self-importance and externality when single individuals thought about it. The single individual had to leave the public to itself and attend to his own private exercises in ethics.—When 1848 came, the only point of view he had was that it was an absolute dissolution, and that Denmark's downfall was near, not through the danger from Germany, which he thought imaginary, but through political freedom.

5. Really, in Søren Kierkegaard the ethical only comes to be in order in the same moment to be recalled. It goes with it, to use one of his own images, as with the child who stuck its head into the world but at once drew it back again when it saw how evil the world was. The ethical sets up an unconditioned ideal, which is to be brought into reality, whereas it is not its task to bring reality up to the ideal. The ethical does not haggle, holds fast to its demand (which it is *impossible* for the human being to fulfill) without “letting itself be disturbed by the chatter that it does not help to demand the impossible.” It then runs aground—and through repentance the transition to the religious then occurs. “The ethical sphere is a sphere of transition, and therefore its highest expression is repentance.”

Ethics stands, then, from the first in a purely negative relation to the human being's power and drive. The Greek ethics, which willed a positive development of the human powers and drives, Kierkegaard does not acknowledge as a real ethics. And consistently: the possibilities he has referred to psychology, the effects to world-history; ethics retains only the impossibilities. There is therefore in Kierkegaard also a tendency to push out the ethical as a special stage. This holds from the first in the case of woman; for since she lacks the ability for deliberation and resolution [!!], she must at once pass over from aesthetic immediacy to the religious. But it really comes to hold in the case of man too. “Between poetry and religiosity,” it is said, “worldly life-wisdom performs its vaudeville. Every individual who does not live either poetically or religiously is stupid.” Here the ethical stage is eliminated *in optima forma*. Kierkegaard's lack of ability to discover the ideality in real life shows itself here again. It is certain that the ethical is doomed to death when it excludes the poetic. But there is also a poetry of life which is only experienced and felt during the work itself, only breaks out at the will's collision with life's hard flint, and which the hermit oscillating between aesthetics and asceticism does not know. He speaks here like the blind man about colors.—For the rest, it must still be noted that the opposition between the poetic and the religious does not correspond to

the opposition between Kierkegaard's aesthetic and religious stage. By living poetically he must understand something other than living like the aesthetes or hedonists he has depicted. This points to the previously demonstrated defect in the depiction of the aesthetic view of life.

γ. The Religious View of Life

1. It is only through religious presuppositions that Kierkegaard's ethics acquires a content, or perhaps rather an object. It is the relation to God, the eternal being qualitatively different from the human, and to the eternal blessedness that can be won by the single individual through the relation to God—this is what lies at the basis of the ethical striving. Kierkegaard therefore does not really know the ethical; he knows only the ethico-religious. This is very closely connected with the fact that the religious for him is absorbed in religious ethics. The dogmatic he indeed presupposes, but it does not condition any special relation; the will is at once taken into service, and there is no time for contemplation or mysticism. Neither does he acknowledge the religious as comfort—or rather, he acknowledges the comfort in religion only in such a way that he at once adds: this comfort brings with it a hitherto unknown suffering.

Here too there can—as in the ethical view of life—be traced a change in Kierkegaard's conception. Earlier he had, in the writing *Fear and Trembling*, depicted the relation between the ethical and the properly religious as a relation of opposition, arising in that, in virtue of the human being's personal relation to God, a break occurred in the universal ethical law. This is shown in a presentation borne by mighty pathos, by Abraham's example: he is willing to sacrifice Isaac at God's command, although the ethical law says: thou shalt not kill. The religious faith is the single individual's affair, because the suspension of the ethical that it can demand cannot be made intelligible to others, since it is conditioned and explained only by the individual's own personal God-relation. The ethical, on the other hand, is the universal, that about which there can be common understanding among human beings. Kierkegaard stands, in this conception of the ethical as the universal, here still—as in *Either-Or* and in *Stages*—closer to Hegel than in the purely philosophical account in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, where, as previously emphasized, "the single individual" and his personal, isolated existence become a chief concept for the ethical view of life too. According to Hegel, ethics was essentially social; the spheres of ethical life were family, civil society, and state, where universal rules hold, and where the single individual is only a moment. With this conception Kierkegaard breaks first on religious grounds, in order to maintain

the personal God-relation in its absolute validity; but the break, which is one with the bringing-out of the concept of the single individual, acquires a retroactive significance for the conception of the ethical. The conception he develops in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* is that the ethical first acquires its proper object, its absolute purpose, through the religious, and that, on the other hand, the religious is essentially of an ethical kind, is a life in striving, willing, acting. That there must occur a transition from the ethical stage to the religious stage then really comes to mean that all ethics, more closely regarded, must be religious ethics if it is to be anything other than externality and loss in the relative. It shows itself that the single individual can maintain his own personal reality only by means of the relation to an absolute personality.

By the relation to God and eternal blessedness there is set the single individual an absolute purpose, an absolute object. The religious is different from the ethical in that, while the single individual ethically has to do only with himself, his own reality, he is religiously infinitely occupied with a reality other than his own. But besides the absolute object and the absolute purpose, the single individual stands in relation to a surrounding world of finitude and a circle of relative purposes that belong there. What matters is to relate oneself absolutely, with unconditioned respect, to the absolute purpose, and to relate oneself relatively to the relative purposes; for it is a self-contradiction to relate oneself unconditionally to, to set everything on, a relative, finite purpose. But the task thus set is very difficult, since there is a yawning deep between the absolute purpose and the relative ones, and since there is at the same time an immediate urge in the human being to be absorbed in (relate himself absolutely to) the relative purposes. And to this is added, further, that the human being feels pleasure and satisfaction in using his own power: but over against God and the highest purpose his work is nothing; here the concern is precisely to see oneself in one's nothingness. The tearing-loose of the will from the finite purposes and relations given in the world of experience, the learning to die away from immediacy, demands a painful exertion that cannot be applied once and for all, but must again and again be repeated; and when to this is now added that one—in spite of all exertion—is to learn to be as though one were nothing, then it is seen that the religious life is an initiation into suffering and self-annihilation. “What wonder that the Jew assumed that the sight of God was death, and the heathen that the God-relation was the beginning of madness!”—

The religious suffering distinguishes itself from other suffering in that it is not accidental, not called forth by outer causes that could also be thought absent, but is necessarily effected by the very nature of the religious relation. The relation to God

is the relation to a being absolutely different from the human, who cannot stand over against the human being as superlative or ideal—and yet is to rule in his inner life! Here is a doubleness that cannot be dispensed with, but gives birth to ever new pain when it is to be held fast. It holds, then, of the religious as of the ethical: the task is not to develop, heighten, and ennoble human nature, not “to bring reality up into ideality,” but “to bring ideality into reality,” to bring an absolutely new element into nature—an element as hostile to nature as the absolute (which demands *all* power) is to the relative (which nonetheless demands *some* power)! The absolute is cruel, because it demands *everything*.

It is a wholly new medium, opposed to its nature, that the human being is to live in when he enters into the religious relation: though a finite being, he is nonetheless to live in the infinite and absolute. He finds himself here in the world like a fish on dry land: he has come into a world where wholly other instincts are required than those that lie in his nature. It is a nature-opposed life that he is to lead.—Henrik Ibsen's *Brand* has here an image that in high degree recalls the one Kierkegaard uses to depict religious existence:

I pictured to myself a dark-frighted owl,
a fish with water-dread. Loudly I laughed;
I would have smuggled them out of my mind,
but they hung on with tooth and claw.
What came of that fit of laughter?
Why, of the dimly felt discord
between the thing as it is,
and the thing as it ought to be,—
between the having to bear
and finding the burden all too heavy.

A fish with water-dread, that must nonetheless live in the water, or a fish (with its nature suited only to life in the water) on dry land—it comes to the same.¹⁵ When Brand tells that as a boy he laughed at this thought, then Kierkegaard too has been aware that in the disproportion, the contradiction peculiar to the religious, there could lie something comic; but he holds nonetheless that the religious is raised above this comedy by the conscious taking-over of the contradiction and of the suffering.—

Just as irony was a transitional form to the ethical and could serve as an incognito for it, so humor is a transitional form to the religious and can be its incognito; humor sees the finite in its nothingness and indifference in the face of the infinite; but the humorist

¹⁵On the religio-psychological type that under various historical conditions has found expression in images of this kind, see under *Religionsfilosofi*, § 36.

need not himself positively have a God-relation. The religious person can use humor in order to hide the inward movement in his inner life, which can never lay itself directly and completely open in any positive utterance. He appears as “the knight of hidden inwardness”—until the religious relation assumes for him such an energy that it demands outward appearance and a break with the world.¹⁶

2. By this conception of the religious Kierkegaard has from the very first cut the bond between it and human nature. It is a foreign thing that comes into the world and is to be forced together with nature without ever being able to become one with it. He proceeds from an idea of perfection that is formed without any regard whatsoever to real human nature. For the historical conception, on the other hand, the religious ideas are anticipations and idealizations on the basis of what is given in experience and moves in the human spirit. Under the influence of inwardly and powerfully moved feeling there form themselves, for imagination and thought, ideas and exemplars that are able to react back on the soil from which they have grown up. But if one cuts away the possibility that the highest ideals of human life can have developed out of life itself, out of the mind moved by life-experiences, then one really cuts away at the same time the possibility that the ideals can work on nature. The qualitative or absolute difference abolishes the possibility of a positive relation. The mighty power of the religions over mind and will rests on their being the great treasures in which the human spirit has laid down some of its most inward experiences. But the religious striving contradicts itself when, in its zeal to set religion's object as high as possible, it places a gaping gulf between it and the life whose exemplar it is to be. A God who is not ideal and exemplar is no God. There have therefore also constantly asserted themselves ethico-religious misgivings about going along with the assertion that the divine being should be qualitatively different from the human. It is on this point, where the religious passion establishes the absolute difference between the divine and the human, that the break occurs between the religious and the humane ethics; for an ethics grounded from a principle absolutely different from human nature must necessarily—when it is consistent—become a life- and man-hostile doctrine. But it is at the same time an ethics contradicting itself: for when the absolute relation lays claim to *all* power, how can there then be *any* power left over to live in the relative relations?¹⁷ Here even the great qualitative dialectician enters into a compromise, a both-and, and only thereby does he halt the complete self-annihilation.

¹⁶On Kierkegaard's conception of irony and humor see more closely in my book *Den store Humor*, §§ 16, 18, 30, 39.

¹⁷Cf. what Brøchner has already remarked on this in his acute critique of Kierkegaard's conception, *Problemet om Tro og Viden*, p. 221: “The absolute purpose must, conceived as Kierkegaard conceives it, take up the whole power of the human spirit, and let no [power] be left over for the relative relations.”

Really Kierkegaard was on the same road as Schopenhauer: the road to Nirvana. Just as Schopenhauer, in the midst of the nineteenth century's culture, declared Buddhism's life-denial to be the highest truth, so Kierkegaard, who in several respects was his kindred spirit, proclaimed strict, ascetic Christianity to be the highest—in the last instance the only thing. It is, in ethical and cultural-historical respects, of the very greatest interest to see two of the most superbly gifted thinkers of our time pass such a sentence of death over all our vaunted cultural development. It indicates that there must be defects and injuries in this which we, with frivolous optimism, are accustomed to overlook. In Leo Tolstoy there comes forth in the most recent time a partly kindred train of thought; yet he stands closer to the natural and human.

From Schopenhauer, Kierkegaard distinguishes himself by his ethical-practical tendency. Schopenhauer bows to the ascetic ideal, but himself prefers the intellectual and aesthetic liberation of the will. Kierkegaard works his way constantly forward in order, if possible, to become one of those on whom the highest determinations could find application. He stakes his personality quite differently, seeks the practical struggle and suffering as an honor—and finds them too.—In his last years Kierkegaard occupied himself with the study of Schopenhauer's writings and was much taken up with them. But his views were then fully developed, and he had merely to note the agreements and oppositions between himself and the German thinker.

3. The religious view of life appears in two chief forms that are so different in their character that the transition from the one to the other is possible only by a leap, a qualitative change. The difference between them consists especially in what is the object of faith. The first form of religiosity (Kierkegaard calls it Religiousness A) relates to the eternal as to the general background of life and existence. The contradiction that here calls forth suffering is then only the one connected with the fact that the consciousness of eternity and the relation to the absolute purpose are to be held fast in the midst of the world of finitude and time. The single individual feels at the same time, the more deeply he takes the relation, ever more the distance at which he is from the highest, and notices the resistance he himself makes to it. For the nearer one comes to the highest, the more one notices one's distance from it! The advance becomes, in so far, here a retreat. There arises a consciousness of guilt that increases the pathos peculiar to the religious standpoint. But even so, this form of religiosity keeps itself within what is accessible to the natural human being. This form of religiosity lies within "immanence," presupposes no decisive break in the natural world-order, and is possible within paganism.—In *Philosophical Fragments* Kierkegaard had referred to Socrates as

the representative of this form of religiosity. This can scarcely be historically defended. Such a view of life as the one Kierkegaard depicts under the rubric Religiousness A does not occur within the Greek world before toward its close: in Neoplatonism. Only there is such a decisive weight laid on the relation to the eternal in definite opposition to all outer and human purposes. The Greek world-view was a calmed harmony; life's natural elements were united into an ethical work of art, but the beyond was not set as the highest or only purpose, however deep a feeling of life's dark sides and of sensuousness's resistance to clarity of thought and purity of will may often be expressed by poets and philosophers.

From this humane or immanent religiosity is distinguished the paradoxical, transcendent religiosity (Religiousness B). Here all determinations are sharpened by the fact that the contradictions become greater.

The single individual relates himself not merely to existence's omnipresent eternal ground. The eternal and divine has appeared in time, in historical shape, as a single human being who has suffered and died. And precisely the fact that the essential revelation does not spread out in existence, but is restricted to a definite time and place, expresses that existence for the rest is forsaken of spirit: nothing has worth, nothing has decisive significance except this one figure—and on the relation to it, to “the God in time,” everything depends. The object of faith is the paradox in the highest sense, the self-contradictory, the absurd. Only by one way is it possible to enter into faith's relation to the highest paradox: when the consciousness of guilt is potentiated into consciousness of sin, that is, when the single individual discovers in himself not merely a resistance to the eternal, but a complete and self-willed change in his nature. The consciousness of this is called forth and conditioned precisely by the appearance of the divine paradox: only by a revelation can the human being discover the total change of his nature and of human nature on the whole. By the paradox as the object of faith and by the consciousness of sin as its presupposition, the greatest immersion in existence, the greatest inwardness, and the greatest suffering are reached. It is the standpoint that appears in Christianity.—

As a moment that sharpens the suffering at the highest religious standpoint, Kierkegaard names the pain of sympathy that arises in that the single individual can no longer sympathize with every human being as a human being, but essentially only with the Christians. His nearest ones he must perhaps even hate: “for is it not as it were to hate them, when he has his blessedness attached to a condition which he knows they do not accept?”—Not always has Kierkegaard given sympathy the right to speak a word of pain. In his journals

he cites with assent a Mohammedan legend, according to which Adam exclaims: "O Lord, only save my soul; I care neither about Eve nor about Abel." The saying "Take heed to yourselves" (Mark XIII, 9) he interprets in a similar direction. And even where he lets the pain of sympathy come forth, he nonetheless does not let it acquire influence on faith; he does not draw, like Schleiermacher, the consequence that with this pain of sympathy no eternal blessedness is possible. Psychologically and ethically regarded, here lies perhaps the greatest and most crying, not to say revolting, of the contradictions in the paradoxical religiosity. Kierkegaard has named this contradiction—but he nonetheless places it last in the row. It is a consequence of the principle of the single individual: what does it concern me *when all is said and done* whether the others also become blessed or not!—

The romantic-speculative doctrine of harmony, which had already received several fundamental shocks by the qualitative jerks between the stages, now finally runs completely aground on the sharp and steep cliff of the paradox.—Of Kierkegaard's conception of Christianity on the whole we shall have occasion to speak when we come to his last appearance.

c. The Standard

1. In his presentation and evaluation of "the Stages" Kierkegaard applies a definite standard. In a single place he himself expressly brings out this standard, in that he seeks to show that "all conceptions of existence rank in relation to the determination of the individual's dialectical inwardization." But the inwardization grows again with the qualitative and quantitative oppositions or contradictions that assert themselves in the individual's inner life. It is the degree of tension that determines the height of the standpoint. It is the increasing tension that—without, however, the higher degrees of tension being understood as successively arisen out of the lower—leads from stage to stage, and at last (when there is no bargaining-down or sluggishness) to the paradoxical religiosity, in that life without supernatural help becomes despair. Kierkegaard constructs, by means of this formal standard, a series of life-stages, interrupted at definite nodal points. The relation of opposition thereby appears in two forms: as successive, by the leap, the crisis, that effects the transition from one stage to another, and as simultaneous, within one and the same stage, by the tension between the conflicting elements that are to be held together.

One will scarcely go wrong in supposing that in this formal standard there is an after-effect of Hegel's method, which consisted in driving thought forward by the constant positing of oppositions, which it then became the task to reconcile. The difference is that

Kierkegaard does not believe that the oppositions unfold out of one another, nor that their reconciliation occurs of itself. He therefore sets the concept of repetition in the place of mediation. But he has nonetheless preserved a remnant of the method, even if he applies it far more cautiously. He constructs by its help possible standpoints and then looks to see how they are found in reality. Against this procedure nothing in itself can be objected; it marks, on the contrary, a great advance in relation to the speculative method, which did not distinguish between the constructed possibilities and the given realities; but it is the very justification of the standard that must be asked about. On the answer to this question depends the final significance that can be attributed to Kierkegaard's ethico-religious standpoint.

2. Of the leap there has been spoken earlier. I here return to the successive relation of opposition in order to investigate whether Kierkegaard is right in attributing to it so decisive a significance for the personal life as he does.

A transition is for him always a break. Of crises there can, according to his conception, really be no question "within immanence," that is, within a view of life that assumes a natural and continuous development in the spiritual domain. Here Kierkegaard's polemic against speculative philosophy's smooth transitions, which were consummated only in imagination or on paper, has decidedly led him too far. The significant thing in his appearance is that he maintains the significance of the *real* transitions in opposition to the *thought* ones, in which people wallowed, in that, over the historical knowledge they had won about various *possible* standpoints, they forgot to investigate on which they now themselves *in reality* stood. But the difference between the thought and the real transitions need not consist in the former being continuous, the latter not. A transition by which a goal significant for the personal life is reached can very well occur continuously. The water moves forward in the streaming river just as well as in the plunging waterfall, and it is only for the outer, sensuous apprehension that the latter movement has more reality than the former. However eagerly Kierkegaard fights for life, he nonetheless does not here let life come to its right; he does not see the small things, the small increments, that quietly join together and imperceptibly often produce what is prized as great and high. Only he gives life its right who acknowledges that it has many ways and forms for its unfolding. Why is it to be narrowed down according to one method? A jerk, a plunge, a crisis can be necessary where a resistance is to be overcome, a decisive turn undertaken. But even then continuity is not broken when one looks more closely. The stillness before the catastrophe (as when—to use one of Kierkegaard's most splendid images—the beast of prey lies quite still before the decisive spring) signifies precisely that

power is being gathered, which is released in the moment of decision. Thus the water is dammed up, so that, when the sluice-gate is taken away, it can plunge with gathered power. It must be the task of knowledge in the spiritual domain, as everywhere, to investigate whether the apparent leap could not be explained as a release of energy long gathered in stillness. There then remains the great and significant difference between such a spiritual development, which resembles more the evenly streaming river, and such a one as resembles more the waterfall's plunge. Here one must acknowledge, if one will stand on the very ground of life, that the inner and outer conditions are not the same for all, wherefore development for different people occurs in different ways. Such an acknowledgment is really contained in the proposition: Subjectivity is the truth. But Kierkegaard has, as already demonstrated, not been able and not willing to draw this proposition's great consequences.

3. Still more does he sin against life by making tension and suffering into criteria of a standpoint's height. Here something similar holds as with the crisis or the leap. The relation of tension can be necessary for life's truth and power, a sign that it does not push away tasks that it can and must solve. Each time a new element, a new relation comes into force and is to be taken up into life's coherence, there can come a relation of tension before the taking-up has succeeded. But in itself the relation of tension is nonetheless a sign of a state of transition, and the standard cannot be sought in it. There can be richness and fullness in life even when it masters its elements and is able to maintain its unity; even when oppositions assert themselves, they can enrich without splitting and paining. In the general nature of consciousness as synthesis, comprehending unity, it lies that not only opposition but also concentration must assert itself so long as the life of consciousness exists. When one fetches life's standard from life itself, one cannot one-sidedly see the decisive thing in the relation of tension.¹⁸

For the humane ethics, which fetches the standard from life itself, and for which the ethical development can consist only in a higher, harmonious unfolding of the life that is, it is not to drag the ideal and the demand down to acknowledge that they must be determined according to the single individual's nature. That for which, in spite of all seeking and awakening, no germs or possibilities are found in the individual's nature, cannot be an ethical law for him. And even if tension and unrest *could* be awakened, this would only be defensible if there were powers present to overcome the tension. The

¹⁸A certain spiritual kinship between Kierkegaard and Nietzsche shows itself especially in the standard for the work of spiritual life that they both apply. Yet a kinship appears also at other points, thus in their weight on the concentrated personal life over against absorption in art and science, and in their circling about the problem of repetition. In a treatise on Kierkegaard and Nietzsche (*Mindre Arbejder*, Third Series, pp. 189–195) I have demonstrated this.

responsibility lies with the one who abolishes the secure harmony without being able to lead forward to a new harmony. The Greek ethics, which Kierkegaard would not acknowledge, in reality contains the fundamental thoughts with which all ethics that is not life-hostile stands and falls. The ethical good is the harmonious unfolding of life's powers in the single personalities, which again demands that harmony be brought about between the single personalities' development in relation to one another.

But Kierkegaard will give no definition at all of the good. The only standard he can get therefore becomes formal and is determined by his religious conception. His construction of the stages is (like his theory of knowledge) determined by the purpose: to prepare the paradoxical religiosity, to bring the psychological conditions to hand for the passionate surrender to the absurd. Therefore he constantly operates with relations of tension and lets the whip-lashes of the increasing suffering fall ever more violently on "the single individual's" back. What would be to admire in such an ethics, when it was realized, would be the passionate energy, the strength of will, with which one holds out in spite of the tension. But such qualities can also be displayed in the service of wholly other purposes, as when the gold-maker in his way seeks "the absolute," which here too is cruel, early and late, with increasing passion and pain, "hating" and sacrificing wife and children for its sake. (Balzac: *La recherche de l'absolu*.) The humane ethicist stands over against the ascetic as the chemist over against the alchemist. He admires the energy, the endurance, the passion, and the many new and deep thoughts produced during the solitary work; but he wishes all these noble powers applied in the service of other purposes.

The purely formal way of regarding things that Kierkegaard applies in the presentation and evaluation of the stages leads him to consequences he himself shudders back from. If contradiction and suffering were the marks of the highest, then it would have to be—it seems to be necessary—the absolute paradox where God not merely became man, but became it in such a way that he was unrecognizable, because he lived quite like other human beings and in the usual human relations, without either way of life or supernatural events and actions drawing attention to him! And must he not at the same time be tried in what appeared to Kierkegaard, from his own experience, to be the most crushing suffering, melancholy, the sickness of the soul? These thoughts have gone through Kierkegaard's mind and have received expression both in *Philosophical Fragments* and in several places in the journals. "God help the poor head that has to do with that kind of doubt!" he exclaims.—To this exclamation it is answered that only great and strong heads, who from the presuppositions they have once assumed think

consistently and do not halve their thoughts, only they get that kind of doubt to do with.

For Kierkegaard the solution lay in a distinction between the *absolute* paradox and the *divine* paradox. Since God is love, he would not be able to reveal himself in the form of the absolute paradox, which would not be a real revelation, since the connection between God and man could not be brought about. This solution here, at the conclusion of Kierkegaard's trains of thought, makes the same effect as, at the conclusion of *Brand*, the cry that is heard through the crash of thunder: "He is *deus caritatis*!"—This appeal to love takes the ground away from under the whole preceding formal construction and evaluation of life's stages and points out toward a law of life that does not begin by demanding life's own power and drive broken. If the love here appealed to were not "qualitatively, absolutely different" from what human beings can know and understand as love, then life's inwardization and deepening would have to be attainable by another way than the one Kierkegaard prescribed. But he does not, at any rate, give that appeal retroactive force. On the contrary, suffering and disharmony as life's laws acquire an ever sharper and more prominent place in his consideration. Suffering is like a fatalistic necessity, under which even the divine will must bow, and which—precisely because the deity is nonetheless conceived as love—casts its dark shadows into eternity's world of light. It is said in a journal entry from Kierkegaard's last years: "In my childhood I heard much about there being great joy, sheer joy in heaven; I believed it too, and I imagined God blessed in sheer joy. Alas, but the more I think about it, I come rather to imagine God sitting in sorrow, as the one who most of all knows what sorrow is." Here Kierkegaard draws the consequence that in another connection he would not draw. The human sympathy that he would not let shake the dogma of the eternal un-blessedness for human beings has here grown to shake the dogma of the very blessedness of the deity. The voice of nature makes itself heard even in the highest theological circle of ideas: a confirmation of the proposition that theology is psychology. After the result of the inner life's experiences the content of the idea of God is determined.

V. Søren Kierkegaard and Christianity

A. Personal Breakthrough

1. After the enormous production that filled the years 1843–46, Søren Kierkegaard had a feeling that he had said what for the time being lay on his mind. “Now I am finished with the books,” he wrote in his diary in the summer of 1847. In the year 1847 itself *Works of Love* appeared, which belongs among his finest purely religious writings; but there are in it no new thoughts of decisive significance for the understanding of his view. On the other hand, there is noticeable in the notes from this year intimations of an important and far-reaching change in his personal life. Hitherto Christianity had indeed been for him the highest, and in his religious discourses he had developed Christian thoughts. But in his presenting and inculcating of the Christian view of life he had nonetheless predominantly chosen the indirect method. He had let it be maintained by a pseudonym (Johannes Climacus) who himself declared that he was not a Christian. He could not yet, in the strictest sense, find that his personal life and the Christian faith covered each other. What he especially had to struggle with, melancholy, he had hitherto kept down—not by directly letting the good cheer of faith combat it, but by diverting it, in that the exertion of the authorial activity laid claim to all his power. So long as he could produce, melancholy was checked. We have above brought out the rhythmic relation between these two elements in his nature. But now he felt an urge for a more inward, more direct settling with the dark power in his inner life: “I now feel,” he writes in August 1847, “an urge in a deeper sense to come to myself by coming nearer to God in the understanding of myself... My melancholy I must see to get hold of more closely. It has hitherto rested deepest at the bottom, and the enormous exertion of spirit has helped to keep it down... Now God wills it otherwise. Something stirs in me that points to a metamorphosis... I shall therefore now keep still, ... see to come to myself, rightly to think my melancholy’s

thought together with God on the spot. In that way my melancholy must be lifted, and the Christian come nearer to me.”

The metamorphosis whose approach he noticed seems to have set in for him at a definite time, namely at Easter 1848. The diaries from 1848 and 1849 point back frequently to this time as a decisive turning point.—“I now believe that Christ will help me to conquer my melancholy, and then I shall become a priest,” he writes on 19 April 1848. Hitherto he had held himself in resignation in the face of “the fundamental misery of his being,” and the production had, by its diverting influence, helped him to this. But shortly after that breakthrough he writes: “Now I am in faith in the deepest sense... For God all things are possible; this thought is now in the deepest sense my watchword, has won a significance for me that I had never imagined.” “Only now, now in my 34th year, have I perhaps learned so much dying-away from the world that for me there can be question of finding my whole life and my whole blessedness in faith in the forgiveness of sins.”

What he had several times let his pseudonyms develop about the difference between resignation and Christian faith (see for example *Repetition* and the depiction of the difference between “Religiousness A” and “Religiousness B” in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*), this he could only now find again and recognize in his own personal life, as inner, real experience. How the man’s great honesty toward himself here comes strikingly forth! And what a great ability has he not had, in the form of imagination and reflection, to develop standpoints and views of life in full, concrete illumination, without, however, succumbing to the temptation to confuse what he could in this way construct with personal experience! He is in truth a *critical* philosopher, if the critical consists first and foremost in a sharp distinction between what is hypothesis and speculation and what is given reality. Scarcely anyone has been his equal in such criticism within the subjective world, which was his world. And how one understands his program: to find difficulties! For what so many think to reach easily and cheerfully, the simplest Christian determinations, that required in his case a long development and strenuous work to reach. He could rightly say that it was *honesty* he willed. He demanded it of himself before he demanded it of others.

2. It could now seem as if his public activity could be concluded, and he could withdraw to a parsonage in the country. His economic circumstances must also have urged him to obtain a salaried position, since his fortune would in a few years be used up. But the personal breakthrough led to a new, religious production of a more positive and at the same time polemical nature than the earlier one. Besides, he saw that he could not live

without producing. “I keep the sorcery of productivity in order to forget all life’s shabby pettinesses” (5 November 1846). He thought he had a talent that must not be buried. “Should the whole wealth of thoughts that still lies in my soul be conjured back—that becomes a torment, an agony” (1847). And there were also other circumstances that made him think he ought not to halt his authorial activity.

Offended that the satirical paper *Corsaren* (The Corsair), published by Goldschmidt, mocked and caricatured so much and so many who in his eyes did not deserve it, while it frequently spoke of *him* with admiration and reverence, he demanded (in an article in *Fædrelandet*) henceforth not to be praised but to be ridiculed in this paper. From that time he became a standing figure in *Corsaren*, with his thin legs and short trousers. Since he moved about much in the street and was well known, the public attention to him was thereby increased in a perhaps not very pleasant way, which he in his melancholy manner interpreted in the very worst sense. He was indignant in his innermost at what he regarded as a mockery and attributed to it far greater dimensions than it in reality had. It pained him deeply that the plain people whom he inwardly loved and among whom he so gladly moved now—as he believed—regarded him as a comic figure or perhaps even suspected him. But most he was indignant that the esteemed and distinguished men in the literary circles who had long, like him, been offended at the abuses of the press, now left him in the lurch, or, as he thought, even got nourishment for their envy from the treatment he suffered. It was, he thought, a downright national crime that was being committed against him, and he had by this whole affair got a proof of the wretchedness below and the weakness of character above. To the disgust at “the crowd” there now came the aversion to the authorities. Something was shaken that had hitherto stood fast for him.—While Kierkegaard rightly saw, in the way in which town-gossip busied itself with his person, a proof of the small-market-town character of our conditions, it can surely also rightly be said that he himself took this affair in a small-market-town way. It is with a strange feeling that one sees in his diaries numerous pages devoted to this affair. In his hermit-stillness he expresses to himself the indignation that people have seen that his one trouser-leg is longer than the other, and this most damaging insinuation he then also at once denies—in the diary—as a “lie.”—Were it not for the melancholy and the subjective expansion by which his life’s small events are potentiated into decisions of principle, one would have to call his way of taking this affair petty and unworthy. It now acquired no small significance for him; it contributed to holding him back at his post, since he did not want it to look as if he fled from the popular talk.

To this was added the strong political movement, which in his eyes brought a complete

dissolution, and in the face of which the authorities, especially Bishop Mynster, to whom he had hitherto looked up, appeared without due firmness and authority, in his opinion. It is strange to see how untouched he is by all that stirred in 1848. At the beginning of this year he writes in the diary: "And so I sit here. Out there everything is in movement, nationality surges through all. . . And now I sit in a quiet room (soon, no doubt, I shall be cried down for indifference to the nation's cause); I know only one danger, that of religiosity." How he regarded the outer political conditions is seen from the following remark from the same time: "The whole fear of Germany is an imagination, a game, a new attempt to flatter national vanity."

What most mightily moved him in these years was not what went on in the world, but what went on in his inner life. And that was then also the essential reason that he did not halt his authorial activity and withdraw to a quiet life in the country. The breakthrough that had occurred in him in religious respects had let Christianity acquire a personal reality-significance for him that it had hitherto not had. The more strongly awakened religious consciousness in turn awakened a sharper criticism of the existing Christendom, which found expression in the religious writings he composed in 1848, in a period when the unrest in outer conditions and personal difficulties in economic respects in many ways tormented him. This "new production" he himself set above the earlier. The chief writings were *Practice in Christianity* and *The Sickness unto Death*, to which was added *For Self-Examination* (of which last writing the second part was first published long after his death). In these writings the Christian ideal was expressed in its whole rigor, with a sharp judgment on the existing religious condition and its representatives.

The question was for him now, in the first place: should these writings be published before he sought ecclesiastical appointment, or later? Would he not make himself impossible as a candidate for office if he published them before, and would it not be dishonest to publish them later?—But this question soon drowned in a question far greater for him: should they be published under his own name or pseudonymously? The first would indeed mean that he himself personally took it upon himself to make good the conception of being a Christian that was maintained in these writings. And was it not his duty? Must he not now take all the consequences? How far his deliberations in this respect went can be seen from the fact that he even imagined that he could come to suffer the usual lot of witnesses to the truth, to be slain by the mob under the secret co-operation of the envy of the distinguished! He then investigated, in a separate essay (the first of *Two Ethical-Religious Essays. By H.H.*), whether a human being has the right to let other human beings slay him for the sake of truth, and came to the result that

such a thing only the God-man and the apostle could have the right to; an ordinary human being must not drive the matter out to this point. Later he regarded the whole thought, in his own case, as hypochondria. But it shows how strong the surge in his mind was in these years. Especially the diary from 1849 is extraordinarily interesting in this respect. Now he scolds himself for his weakness, that he will not venture the utmost, now for his pride or his hypochondria, that he thinks himself placed in the utmost trial. It was the latter conception that gained the upper hand. He indeed gave up seeking ecclesiastical appointment (after he had nonetheless sought a conversation with the minister and the bishop—without finding them at home). But he published the said writings pseudonymously, this time choosing a name (Anti-Climacus) that was to express that here was presented a conception of the Christian higher than the one he personally could vouch for, just as his earlier chief pseudonym (Johannes Climacus) had designated a standpoint that did not yet reach the one he himself acknowledged. “In contrast to Climacus, who said of himself that he was not a Christian, Anti-Climacus is the opposite extreme: to be a Christian in an extraordinary degree—if only I myself manage to be quite simply a Christian.” —It was a “battle of ideas” that had been delivered in his inner life. It was in reality a *witness-to-truth struggle* that he here fought out with himself, long before the great public witness-to-truth struggle broke loose. The result was: “*I confess that I am not, in the strictest sense, a witness to the truth.*” Here we have even the very word used in his inner debate—the word that then also grated so hideously in his ears when he later heard it used of the representatives of the official Christianity.—The outer struggle is here clearly seen as the continuation of the inner. So it always is where a struggle is conducted with authority and earnestness.—As a deep humiliation he felt what had happened: “In one sense I would so gladly venture; my imagination beckons and goads me; but I am precisely to learn to be so good as to venture in a lower form. It is indeed the most finished and truest thing I have written; but the relation is not to be such that I should be the one who almost judgingly rushes in upon others—no, I am myself first to be educated by the same; there is perhaps no one who is allowed to humble himself so deeply under it as I, before I am allowed to publish it.”

3. The fundamental thought in the “new production” is that Christianity has really been abolished by being conceived merely as the religion of mildness and comfort. People have accustomed themselves not to understand that the compassion and love that express themselves in Christianity are of a wholly different kind than what people usually understand by these words. This is inculcated by a masterly development of how Christ must have looked in the eyes of contemporaries, and how questionable a matter,

humanly speaking, it could be to let oneself be helped by him. In the strictest, most cutting way it is maintained that there is in Christianity a wholly different conception of misery and of help than the usual, human one. But now people think afterward to have learned that Christ was God, and by the help of this smuggled-in result they do not come into the relation of contemporaneity, while they nonetheless take the comforting and mild words to their own credit.

Only rigor can help here. The true authority has left the Church: "Those who were to command became cowardly; those who were to obey became insolent. Thus was Christianity abolished in Christendom—by mildness. And now there lives in the existing Christendom, where there is indeed never any question of rigor, there lives a pampered, proud, and yet cowardly, defiant, and yet soft generation, which occasionally hears these mild grounds of comfort delivered, but which scarcely knows whether it will make use of them, even when life smiles most beautifully, and which in the hour of need, when it is seen that they are really not so mild after all, takes offense" (*Practice in Christianity*).

What must in any case be demanded of every single individual as well as of the existing Church is sincerity, by admission of how great a distance one finds oneself from the ideal. It is, after all, the least that can be demanded, that one not lie oneself into an ideality one is very far from possessing (cf. "The Moral" in *Practice in Christianity*).

"The strictest thing shall be heard; one shall not have permission to draw a line straight through it and ignore it; it shall be heard, in order that one may humble oneself under it; but it shall not be proclaimed in such a way that one would cruelly force people to want to be spirit according to so terrible a standard. Here is my difference from Mynster: he wants to have it kept quite silent. I want to have it said, and am then, for the rest, willing to declare that, when I say it, it is only poetic, since my life is far from being so spiritual. On the whole I think it is ethical respect that is to be introduced."

If only the admission of the distance from the ideal came from the side of the existing Church, Kierkegaard would raise no strife. It was the personal truth he demanded acknowledged; for it he could rise to battle, even though he did not dare stand as the champion of the ideal itself.—But the admission did not come; instead Bishop Mynster let Kierkegaard know, through an intermediary, that he in the highest degree disapproved of *Practice in Christianity*. A word from Mynster could have prevented the strife. "If I collide with the existing order," it is said in the diaries some years after, "it is Mynster's fault." Out of piety toward the old bishop he nonetheless held himself back—until the challenge came.

4. Yet, for a right understanding of Søren Kierkegaard's personality, it must not be

forgotten that there was something other than the distrust of his own authority and the piety toward Mynster that held him back from appearing in the sharpest way against the usual conception of Christianity. There worked in him also a heartfelt compassion with those who would come to suffer by his appearance—the unhappy, in whose comfort there would come a breach; the happy, whose joy he would disturb.

“Existence occasions one to become attentive to the many, many less gifted, weak, simple people, women, children, the sick and the sorrowful, and so on, among whom one lives. And then existence says to the religious person: can you, against these, find it in your heart to screw up the religious, the price of blessedness, as high as you do, you cruel one? And if the religious person is in truth the religious person, and thus has love, then this objection makes a deep impression on him, on him who so gladly wants to be with the suffering, whose only comfort and joy it really is to comfort the suffering.” This objection is indeed rejected in what follows, on the ground that it speaks the language of human compassion—that Christ is the absolute, and that the absolute is cruel: does not even permit one to bury one’s father.—But the objection has again and again risen in Kierkegaard’s mind. Some time after, it runs thus: “But now these people, the great multitude of people, who must spend most of their time earning their livelihood, in subordinate work: in the relation to them it would indeed be a cruelty to screw up the price for them. Here, surely, humanly speaking, a comforting and a mildness ought to be provided, precisely because it can in such people be their concern, and this true in them, that it precisely pains them not to be able to live for something higher... No, at the educated and well-to-do class, the if not distinguished, then still the distinguished bourgeoisie: there it is to be aimed, there the price is to be screwed up in the salon.”—Yet also in the face of the happy the compassion rises: “When I was to proclaim Christianity in truth, I should thus disturb this whole happy existence, which can take place where one does not come into contact with spirit... At times it is to me as though I went about bearing a crime by this my knowledge of Christianity.” And he felt that by the happy natures the rigor must be felt even more strongly than by himself, who had indeed all his life through been placed in inner suffering: “I now live, once and for all, in melancholy’s separate cabin—but I dare rejoice to see others’ joy... To be healthy and strong, a complete human being, for whom there hopefully lies a long life—now, that was never granted me. But when I then step out from my dreadful pain among the joyful—I thought I dared have the melancholy joy of strengthening them in thus rejoicing in life. Oh, but if it is to be proclaimed: to die away, that to be loved by God is to suffer, and to love God to suffer—then I must, as it were, disturb all the others’

happiness... *At this difficulty I have halted.*"

These utterances I have cited so fully because I do not think one understands Søren Kierkegaard when one does not get as full an impression as possible of the whole side of his nature that displays itself through them: his mild and loving mind. In his writings it does not come forth, it seems to me, with such inwardness as in his settling with himself in his solitude (in notes from the years 1849–1853).

5. That the halt which compassion could effect became for the time being only provisional came from the fact that Kierkegaard's whole conception of Christianity and Church underwent a considerable sharpening after the personal breakthrough and under the changed relation to the authorities that the events of the time had brought about. He got a sharper eye for the weaknesses in the existing order, at the same time as he felt more secure in his conception of the ideal.

His conviction was now that a great betrayal had been committed on the part of human beings against Christianity. It was for them too high and too strict;—and they would indeed feel akin to the high and take its help and comfort, but for as cheap a price as possible. The first bargaining-down occurred when, in the Middle Ages, people began to regard those who made earnest of following Christ in their lives as extraordinary Christians. "There the meaning burst in Christianity!" Luther continued what had thus been begun. He combated the Middle Ages too much, broke out of the monastery too early. If people had earlier one-sidedly had an eye for Christ as exemplar, Luther now forgot the exemplar for the reconciler. He bargained down the Christian—without making it sufficiently recognizable that he bargained down. "Luther, Luther, Luther, you have a great responsibility!" The Reformation became not a return to the original Christianity, but a *modification of the Christian*. Luther's appearance marks the human's reaction against the Christian; he has invented that Christianity essentially exists in order to calm and comfort. And then he was a giddy head, busy casting off burdens, attacking authorities—such as now this unhappy political thing, that he wanted to overthrow the pope!—And yet Luther can still be respected: he came from twenty years of penitential exercises and anguish of soul. But how many Protestants come thus? And nonetheless Protestantism levels everything; it is a plebeian tendency that does not acknowledge the difference between the great and the humble, but—despite all opposition in existence—feels itself on the same line as apostles and witnesses to truth!—It was Kierkegaard's view that Catholicism will never be able to sink so deep as Protestantism, since it in any case constantly has representatives of the strict, ideal conception of Christianity to show. Protestantism lives off the Christian heroic age, the Church's first 300 years, without

producing new heroes; but: “the 300 years’ laboriously acquired working capital, it is used up, ladies and gentlemen; no more can be squeezed out of it by new frauds.”

Yes, perhaps one must go still further back. The abuse began with the very beginning of the Church. For it could not possibly have been quite right when the apostles on one day made 3000 into Christians. In their joy and enthusiasm something human must have befallen them; they forgot what Christianity really was.—And even in the exemplar’s life there can be found traits where he gave the human too much. He went, after all, to the wedding feast at Cana, was here in the joy of life and thereby strengthened people in it! But that he did only at the beginning of his public career, before he had seen how evil the world was. Later he did not go to weddings, and his apostle, who knew nothing but Jesus Christ and him crucified, he did not go to weddings.

People have made Christianity too mild and coddling, into an expedient, a comfort for the worst cases. One loses oneself in the “coddling drivell” about how Christianity satisfies the deepest longings, and so on. God has become a good old grandfather, not a father who with rigor chastens his children. In the place of the Christmas festival in the church Kierkegaard finds especially a symbol for the changed character of Christendom. It is pure paganism that has there been taken up. Christianity has become Christmas-fuss!

(A multitude of utterances in the diaries 1849–55 lie at the basis of this summary. See also *Judge for Yourselves!*, Second Series.)

6. The mitigation and coddling that had corrupted Christianity, Kierkegaard derived from woman—woman, whom Protestantism had especially brought forward by its praise of marriage and family life. Earlier he had praised Luther’s marriage as a heroic deed that in the eyes of contemporaries posited the paradox: the monk’s marriage with the nun! Now he thought that Luther had here too been rather too quick. It is woman who makes it impossible for man to live for spirit, for an unconditioned. Once man is bound with a woman who, through loving her own and hers, loves herself, then the idea can whistle for him: mother-wit egoism holds him fast! “Christianity knows very well that with woman and love and so on, all this weaker and coddling comes up in a human being, and that, in so far as the man does not hit upon it himself, the wife regularly represents it with an unconstraint that is extremely dangerous for the man, especially for the one who is to serve Christianity in a stricter sense” (*Practice in Christianity*). Woman represents the desire for life; man is far more disposed to be spirit. Woman is bait—as Johannes the Seducer has said! (Papers 1854).

How characteristic, that here from the strictest religious standpoint there is a pointing back to the aesthetic: they meet in the same view from wholly opposite sides! The whole

ethical view is pushed out or treated as though it were not there.—One will recall, from the section on the ethical view of life, that this was really not possible for woman, but that she was to pass immediately from the poetic to the religious. Now (1855) the determination is added that the religious she gets access to only by an indirect way; for the existence placed in contradictions, which the Christian is, she really cannot bear: she relates herself to the religious through man, by being witness to how he lifts at the great task. Kierkegaard rejoices to find support for his view of woman in Schopenhauer; he thinks he can also lean on the New Testament.

But from woman and the family the consequence goes to the natural instinct that leads to the formation of the family. Reproduction of the race itself is of the evil. The New Testament presupposes that Christians do not marry. And how, really, should they be able to, how should they be able to set children in the world, when they know that they are born in sin and to misery? Christianity wants to bar reproduction of the race, does not want history's personnel renewed. And if this is so, how thoroughly has not Protestantism, by its praise of family life, corrupted Christianity! (1855).

Here, then, the consequence is drawn. Life is declared to be evil in its very urge and striving after subsistence and renewal, the fundamental urge which directly and indirectly is the source of all human activity. It offers resistance to the implanting of the supernatural element—so it must be rotten, and the branding-iron then stamps its innermost marrow as corrupted. Already in the section on the religious view of life we saw self-annihilation set as the highest. What has just been developed is really only a closer expression of the same thought.

7. When now this whole view of Christianity and of the world was to be made to count, it is not difficult to say how the judgment must come to sound over the existing Church. Already in the diaries Kierkegaard has formulated the two chief propositions about which his later public polemic came to turn. Already here occurs the thought: "Luther had 95 theses; I have only one: Christianity does not exist,"—and the other: "The whole worship of God is a grandiose attempt in the direction of making a fool of God, although one is not conscious of this... Can one defend taking part in such a thing?"

We have heard what for a long time held him back. There came the situation in which nothing could hold him back from loudly uttering the thoughts that had matured in him in solitude.

B. The Last Word

1. The occasion of the strife was a sermon that Martensen, a few days after Bishop Mynster's death, preached in the palace church, and in which he presented the deceased as a link of "the holy chain of witnesses to the truth that stretches through the ages from the days of the Apostles." This utterance offended Søren Kierkegaard in the deepest way. He at once wrote down a powerful protest, which he published three quarters of a year later (in *Fædrelandet* of 18 December 1854), when Martensen had safely and well become Mynster's successor on the episcopal throne of Zealand. The strife thereby awakened, and to which our literature knows no equal, when regard is had to the greatness of the subject and to the passion with which it was conducted from the side of the one who had raised it, I shall not attempt to depict in detail. It deserved its own historian, who would have to be able, with dramatic life, to set the acting personalities over against one another, and who could give an account of the degree to which the great accusation Søren Kierkegaard has raised against Christendom particularly strikes the Danish state church and its representatives in his time. It is an affair of a similar kind to that between Plato and the Sophists, and between Pascal and the Jesuits. Only historical knowledge and historical art can settle it. Here I have to do with the strife only from its universally human side. And quite apart from the strife's result, Kierkegaard's polemical writings have an abiding interest, just as well as Plato's *Dialogues* and Pascal's *Lettres à un provincial*. Scarcely will anyone be able to immerse himself in the violent contributions from Kierkegaard's side without their working on him as "the single individual." It would be highly mistaken if one merely read them with aesthetic interest in the powerful polemic; weighty words are spoken about the relation between ideal and self-deception, which have an errand to everyone, wherever he may otherwise stand.—As for Kierkegaard himself, he showed himself as a violent agitator who shunned no means to give emphasis to his words. He was concerned that no immersion in inessential circumstances and no long-winded zeal to find excuses and exceptions should divert attention from the great proposition he wanted to establish. He thought at the same time that his opponents had indeed acknowledged an absolute standard, and that their motives and their character, seen in its light, must acquire a questionable earthly character. Nevertheless it is strange to see this champion of ideality, this knight of thought, right at the beginning of his polemic come forth with a turn such as this, that Martensen's sermon about Mynster could also be called a memorial address in the sense that it brought Martensen to remembrance for the vacant episcopal throne. And counterparts further on in the polemic are not lacking. Where there is such superiority of spirit and such an ability to use the weapons of satire

and mockery as here, such insinuations must in a double sense be said to be out of place. Kierkegaard's shield would have been brighter without them.—

2. The witness-to-truth struggle really turned on one of the chief thoughts about which Kierkegaard had all his life circled, on the question: continuity or break? Both-And or Either-Or? From the side of the existing Church it was maintained, and it lay especially at the basis of Martensen's appraisal of Mynster, that there was an unbroken coherence between the present-day ecclesiastical representatives and the apostles, the representatives of New Testament Christianity. A holy chain connected them. And there was maintained at the same time a conception of Christianity according to which the Christian had partly entered, partly could enter, union with the purely humane culture, so that a higher unity of both could be reached—as people thought, on Christianity's own ground. Christian state, Christian family life, Christian art and Christian science—these were a series of concepts whose mere setting-up is characteristic of the ecclesiastical doctrine of harmony. For Kierkegaard these concepts mark just as many sense-deceptions and self-deceptions, just as many lies. He maintains a break in the coherence between the now-existing Christendom and the New Testament's Christianity, because he maintains that the Christian in the New Testament's sense is “the deepest, most incurable break with this world” (S. Kierkegaard's newspaper articles). As little as Mynster's sermon expressed the Christian in this meaning or brought about such a break with the world, so little was there a trace of it in Mynster's personality and conduct of life. When one has nonetheless reckoned him among the true witnesses to the truth in the Christian sense, this betrayed, in Kierkegaard's eyes, an impermissible confusion of concepts, and, when one would not admit it, an insolent corruption of the ideal. The ecclesiastically existing order could, he thought, only be defended in the way he had attempted in *Practice in Christianity*, by admission of the great distance between ideal and reality and by fleeing to the divine grace when this admission had been made. But when from the ecclesiastical side one will not make this admission, the ecclesiastically existing order becomes “an insolent indecency, an attempt in the direction of making a fool of God,” and it becomes necessary to set up the thesis, the only one: New Testament Christianity does not exist (newspaper articles. *Fædrelandet* of 28 March 1855).—The coherence with the New Testament is broken, because the coherence with “the world” is not broken: that was Kierkegaard's standpoint in the strife.

He would not let himself be put off with the notion that he maintained a stricter conception of Christianity, Mynster and Martensen (as well as Grundtvig, whom he occasionally also takes along) a milder. For here there is no question of rigor or mildness.

It is a matter of simple *human honesty* in the answering of the question whether one now lives on the conditions that New Testament Christianity presupposes, or not: “For this honesty I will venture. On the other hand, I do not say that it is for Christianity I venture. Suppose it, suppose I became quite literally a sacrifice: I should nonetheless not be a sacrifice for Christianity, but because I willed honesty... I dare not call myself a Christian; but honesty I will, and to that end I will venture” (newspaper articles).

3. After the strife had for half a year (from December 1854 to May 1855) been conducted as a newspaper debate, it assumed from Kierkegaard’s side an even more passionate character, in that he now, through small pamphlets, addressed larger circles with an open and definite summons to break off connection with the Church. This summons was formulated in a pamphlet that appeared in May 1855 (with the title: *This Must Be Said; So Let It Then Be Said*) thus:

“Whoever you are, whatever your life otherwise, my friend—by (if you otherwise take part in it) refraining from taking part in the public worship of God as it now is (with the claim of being New Testament Christianity), you have constantly one, and a great, sin the less; you do not take part in making a fool of God by calling New Testament Christianity what is not New Testament Christianity.” Thereafter followed, in the course of the summer, the nine issues of *The Moment* (May–September 1855), with increasing violence in attack and agitation.—From my boyhood years I still remember the little white pamphlets and the movement they called forth in the minds and talk of the grown-ups. Only later was I myself to experience what a message of earnestness they brought.—Kierkegaard’s language here at times attains a force and at the same time a cutting pithiness that make some of the “Moments” unique in the history of our language.

The Church must go—there is nothing else for it; for it slays Christianity. It has abolished the relation of opposition to the world, the world’s goods and the world’s tasks, and thereby it has abolished Christianity. By a revolt undertaken not in open defiance, but quietly, gradually, in hypocrisy, people have got something quite different out of Christianity than it really is. The corruption began early: it began perhaps already with the apostles. Yes, has Christianity really come into the world? By the help of the dogmas (Kierkegaard thinks especially of the dogma of the atonement) one has pushed the exemplar aside; in the original Christianity’s great funeral march one has found a few mildly sounding rhythms and has from them taken occasion to compose the whole of Christianity over into an idyll (*The Moment* no. 5).

The matter is: “To be a Christian in the sense of the New Testament is, in the upward direction, just as different from being a human being as being a human being, in the

downward direction, is different from being an animal.” But are people nowadays capable of such a spiritual existence, can they still feel the proper religious passion? There has occurred a weakening in character, which is essentially due to marriage and family life (*The Moment* no. 7).

So much is certain: if the present condition in the Church is Christian, then the New Testament can no longer be a guide for Christians, for the presupposition it rests on—the relation of opposition to the world—has fallen away (*The Moment* nos. 2 and 4).

The whole question has a far-reaching significance: it is not restricted to the moment: “It is nothing ephemeral I will, just as little as it is anything ephemeral I have willed; no, it was and is something eternal: by the ideals against the sense-deceptions” (*The Moment* no. 1). For the ideals shall be proclaimed, however it may go; otherwise mediocrity triumphs (no. 9). There is, after all, a way that has at all times been for people an expedient, by which they have got troublesome problems off their necks—the simple one: “Be twaddle—and you shall see, all difficulties vanish” (no. 9). (This last piece everyone ought to read for himself who wants to know what Søren Kierkegaard willed, and how he knew how to express what he willed.)

4. A short time after the last number of *The Moment* had appeared, Søren Kierkegaard became ill in the street, fell down, and was brought to Frederik’s Hospital. He had long been sickly; he suffered from a spinal ailment that he derived from a fall in his childhood. “I come here to die,” he said when he came to the hospital. According to the testimony of those who saw him during his last sickbed, there was an extraordinary clarity and peace over him, and his eyes shone with even greater brilliance than before, when the pains did not quite overwhelm him.

How strangely everything here joined together! When his last word was said—the one toward which he had, as it were, drawn breath all his life through, and the last word that he could say—then his bodily strength too was broken. And at the same time his outer means of existence too were exhausted; a short while before he had drawn out the last money he had. The outer conclusion was like a symbol that he had exhausted the consequence of his spirit and his thought.

And now he felt himself to be one whose strife was ended. Life had indeed been one long strife for him. He fought honestly with himself before he fought with others, and he demanded of them only the same honesty that he had first demanded of himself.—Now this inner and outer strife was at its close. As one will remember, there was, according to his faith, an absolute opposition between the eternal and the human; only in passing inconsistencies have we seen the shadows from the latter stretch over the former. And

thus it was also now his faith that the strife would for him now be relieved by peace, as it is said in some lines of Brorson, which he wished to stand on his grave:

It is a little while,
and I have conquered,
then is the whole strife
at once vanished.

From some interesting conversations he had in his last days with his youth-friend Pastor Boesen, one sees that he did not receive the sacrament of the Lord's Supper, because he would not receive it from any priest, but only from a layman. He died on 11 November 1855.

Conclusion

1. “The rest is silence!”—this last word of Hamlet’s I was most inclined to end with after having brought out Søren Kierkegaard’s last word. For to take the word thereafter can seem presumptuous. A great spirit’s last word about one of history’s and life’s very greatest questions may well make one silent. But silence has worth only when it means that one is thinking, and I break the silence in order to say what thoughts have—since I first came under the influence of Søren Kierkegaard’s “only thesis”—fixed themselves in me.

Not because a definite position toward his last word should be necessary in order to appraise his significance. His great merit lies first and foremost in his wonderful ability to ask, to find difficulties, to wound in such a way that not merely the life of thought, but the personal life on the whole, comes into inward and lasting movement in those who immerse themselves in his writings. And in his proposition that subjectivity is the truth lies this: that it is the personal inwardness, the creative self-activity, which according to his and his teacher Poul Møller’s conviction is possible in every human being, on which everything depends. No handed-down, externally-arriving knowledge is sufficient. Only that is truth for the human being which he himself produces or reproduces. This proposition is so great and rich in its application that it encloses consequences that—as previously intimated—go further than Kierkegaard would acknowledge.

But for our own sake we must discuss whether he is right that the human race has shirked Christianity, has out of softness and in hypocrisy turned its back on the ideal. If it were so, it would have not merely religious significance. Whatever one may think about Christianity’s abiding significance—one thing is nonetheless clear: it would be sad if the race had in *such* a way forsaken the ideals of its past. Ideals one can forsake in a worthy way only either by having outgrown them, or by the circumstances of life having, for other reasons, changed and demanding new exemplars. Thus for purely humane reasons we must seek, as well as we can, to make clear to ourselves the great question, raised by Kierkegaard, of humanity’s relation to the New Testament’s view of life.

2. Kierkegaard remarks in one place that in the New Testament there is no guidance with respect to the problems that can arise from one's being brought up from childhood in Christianity. And in "the Moments" he comes, by another way, back to the thought that the New Testament in any case cannot be a guide for the present-day Christendom. If one pursues the thought he has here touched on, one naturally comes to investigate what the most important difference is between the presuppositions that condition the New Testament view of life and those that prevail nowadays in people whose minds are disposed to take up as much as possible of this view of life. When one asks thus, there will be especially one circumstance that, the more one investigates the New Testament's circle of representations, will show itself to be of decisive significance, namely this: that the New Testament throughout proceeds from the assumption that history will soon—already within the lifetime of the then-living generation—be concluded by Christ's return. If one does not take that circumstance into consideration, one does not understand the New Testament's ethics. It forms the constant background. The kingdom of heaven is near!—The end of all things approaches!—that is the constant refrain, which for the attentive sounds along even where it is not expressly repeated. Since one thus worked with a near horizon, had no outlook to unsurveyable periods of development, to a long wandering for the race, all more comprehensive endeavors, all proper cultural work, all social life had to become insignificant, just as everything had to be avoided that could divert attention from the one, great and near goal. "The end of all things approaches; be therefore sober and watch," writes the apostle Peter (1 Pet. IV, 8), and it is with the same motivation that Paul advises the Christians against marrying and against exchanging the state of slavery for the free state (1 Cor. VII). What had that kind of goods and joys to say in the face of the glory that was to be revealed? They could only divert mind and thought, which now, when the great decision was imminent, it was precisely the concern to keep gathered.

When this presupposition falls away, Christian ethics must be placed quite otherwise. Its commands acquire a wholly different significance when one works with a far horizon than when one worked with a near horizon. The obscurities in the later Church's position toward the original Christianity find their simple explanation in the fact that one has not sufficiently attended to this great difference. When the long historical wandering began, tasks and purposes pressed forward to which one had before attributed no value. On the long journey one has other needs than when one has only a couple of steps to go. Relations asserted themselves with respect to which the New Testament could contain no real guidance; there developed an independent human life in family and state, science

and art—or rather, the life that was already developed in these domains now had to unfold in the Christianized world. But there came then a need for other exemplars and for an ethics that could attribute to this life a positive significance, could regard life as a development and not merely as a time of exercise until the speedy conclusion came. Early, then, one begins to connect Greek ethics with the Christian, most often in a purely external way.

If Kierkegaard is right in his proposition that New Testament Christianity does not exist, then the explanation lies in the fact that the presupposition of the New Testament ethics no longer in the same way fills the mind. For the fact that one still speaks of the last day in all indeterminacy has in this respect not much to say; as one indeed also knows, for the time being, how to arrange oneself quite comfortably.

It has interested me greatly to see that Kierkegaard in a single place touches on this point. It is said in a note from 1849:

“The whole difficulty with Christ’s return being predicted as near at hand, and yet not having occurred, is explained by drawing attention to the fact that it is a subjectively true remark. And thus not only Christ must say it, and next, which is indeed also a fact, the Apostles, but thus every true Christian must say it. That is to say, it is to such a degree tormenting to be the true Christian that it would not be endurable if one did not constantly expect Christ’s return as imminent now. *The torment, the suffering gives birth to a necessary illusion...* One is no true Christian except in the pain and torment that it is to be a true Christian in this world; and if one is in that pain and torment, then this illusion is a necessity.”

This interpretation is completely in consequence of Kierkegaard’s whole conception, and it is at the same time the only one by which the presupposition of the New Testament ethics can be kept up. Who knows whether there are not those who really do it? If there are such, then they have—what Kierkegaard has not emphasized—one contradiction more to bear: the contradiction between the prophesied speedy conclusion and the long historical time with all that it has brought. It is a sharpening of the paradox that Kierkegaard, had he become aware of it, would have been able to develop with force and vigor.—But I think that he reverses the true relation. It is not the tension that from the first has called forth the expectation; it is the promise that has called forth the tension. *The nearness of “the Kingdom” is a part of the original Christian proclamation and lies at the basis of the evaluation of all life’s relations and tasks in the New Testament.* In connection with this an essential correction must be made to Kierkegaard’s conception

of the original Christianity. Christianity was not, as he says, a funeral march (*The Moment* no. 5). It was a march of victory. The joy and jubilation over the imminent glory had far the preponderance over the feeling of suffering. The original Christianity was not so consumptive as it often seems in Kierkegaard's presentation.¹⁹ It lived in great visions, in great and lively expectation, and thereby got power and courage for sacrifices and exertions that later on, when they were to be imitated under wholly other presuppositions, acquired the character of spiritualistic asceticism. The original Christianity is by no means spiritualistic. The time of spiritualism first came when the expectation had ceased, or at least been calmed.

Those who can go along with the conception I have here maintained will be able to agree with Kierkegaard in his proposition that New Testament Christianity does not exist; but they will not explain it in the same way as he. They will see that the changed position toward Christianity is simply due to the fact that a long historical development has taken place. When one now does not assume that the human race's ideals can be prescribed to it once and for all—which is especially impossible when such decisive presuppositions as the one just mentioned can change completely—then one comes to the conviction, not that Christianity's time is past, for that it will in a certain sense never become, but that Christianity's significance, like the significance of every great spiritual movement, is this: under certain definite historical conditions to have awakened feelings and ideas which, though they cannot keep themselves unchanged when the conditions become other, can nonetheless enter as essential elements into the ideal world that humanity can never do without. Christianity has made the ideals of love, of inwardness, and of purity count with a force of feeling such as has not happened before or since. It has, if not from the first awakened, then at least sharpened, the feeling for the suffering and the weak, and maintained the invalidity of the outer differences in the face of the common human (although here the confessional difference early hampered). These elements the race takes with it on its way forward. A noble type of life is not lost, even if the conditions for its complete realization fall away. It is continued as an element in the continued life, which constantly seeks new forms.

The humane view of life stands over against Christianity as it stands over against

¹⁹It is in this respect characteristic that Kierkegaard will give no closer determination of what "blessedness," the "absolute purpose," really is. Every description of the goal will in his eyes divert attention from the way—and "the way is the decisive thing, otherwise we have aesthetics." Of the eternal blessedness he will therefore say nothing other than that it is the good that is reached by venturing everything. The New Testament has not this misgiving. The enthusiastic expectation of the goal's glory and fullness is here precisely also the condition for one's coming forward on the way. See especially the Revelation of John, which in its full depiction of "the goal" differs only in degree, not in kind, from what in the other New Testament writings lies as presupposition.

Greek culture. The Greek manliness, clarity of thought, and harmony we can just as little do without as the love and inwardness that were the greatest and will be the abiding thing in Christianity. Out of the human spirit these ideals and qualities have developed under definite historical conditions; and the same human spirit takes them with it on its continued wandering, in so far as they can be freed from their original presuppositions and worked together with the new qualities and exemplars that the new conditions of life make necessary. We take the good where we can find it.

3. This continued development of life, and its right and ability under the new conditions to form new ideals, Kierkegaard denied in the most definite way. A whole arsenal of scornful words he had ready against such a way of regarding things, which for him became one with directing one's conviction about the highest "according as the time, the public, the profit demands." No one is able, as he is, to caricature what he rejects or—does not understand. And yet there is an evident self-contradiction in his conception, which is closely connected with his at one and the same time pleading the cause of subjectivity, of personality, and holding fast to a foundation of fixed dogmas as an absolute condition.

In his theory of knowledge Kierkegaard maintains that existence cannot be exhausted or comprised by knowledge, but that there is constantly new work to do—that in the world of thought things must constantly be ventured anew. And in his conception of religious faith it is a chief thing that the decisive element is the relation of contemporaneity to the struggling and suffering ideal. He designated it in his last days as the thought of his life: "what you do in contemporaneity is the decisive thing." And earlier he had inculcated that world-historical figures are not suited to be ideals, because they have a concludedness that makes the contemplation secure; "ideality cannot be got historically corked-up."

If earnest is made of this, every dogmatic religion becomes impossible. For in the dogma lies precisely the conclusion: the dogma is a declaration once and for all about the significance of a historical person or event, an establishing of a won result. All positive or dogmatic religion in reality gives ideality historically corked-up—and therefore there was needed a Søren Kierkegaard's enormous exertion of thought and great art of presentation in order again to bring out the great significance of the relation of contemporaneity. All instruction in dogmatic religion is an instruction in answer-keys; the sum has been worked out, and it is in high degree difficult to carry out the re-checking in such a way that one does not make use of one's knowledge of the result. Bad novel-readers peep at the back of the book about the outcome—but thereby miss the tension that alone gives the mood during the reading a likeness to the mood at an experience.—Kierkegaard

saw at last the misfortune in the dogmas; it was by their help that one had pushed the exemplar aside.

Contemporaneous in earnest one can be only with that which is not concluded, and whose result does not lie guaranteed. And that holds only of the real human life itself, with its purposes and tasks, its struggle, its desire and its pain. Kierkegaard's doctrine of the paradox contains the great truth, which also—or: precisely—the humane view of life fully has use for, that the great and significant so often develops under humble and unpretentious surroundings. Its germs are often difficult to discover and easy to misunderstand. The concern is then for an open eye and a firm faith in the value of what will perhaps slowly and late be able to work its way through to recognition. The judgment over us rests especially on our relation to the ideal powers that have lain in the bud or struggled to be able to unfold in our time. A dogmatic guideline cannot be given; the ideal cannot be formed once and for all; it must form itself anew, assume new shapes, and then makes its demands on us under each of these shapes.

Thus, approximately, must Kierkegaard's doctrine of the paradox and of the relation of contemporaneity be adjusted, if it is to have abiding and general significance. As sharply as he, as thinker and ethicist, stepped forth against the harmful effects of the dogmas, he nonetheless did not break with the dogmas; his noble wine he put into the old leathern bottles. If the wine is to be preserved, it must be poured into new vessels.

4. It would be idle to brood over how Søren Kierkegaard would have placed himself if his life had been continued. His sympathy with Catholicism on the one hand, his acknowledgment of free researchers' (Feuerbach's) conception of Christianity on the other, open opposite possibilities. And a new possibility is added when we think of a development like Leo Tolstoy's, which offers several similarities with Kierkegaard's. It could be imagined that he had continued to work as the single individual, in imitation of "the Exemplar," but with increasing contempt for "the Dogmas."—But who can exhaust the possibilities for a great spirit's future course, especially one for whom "the leap" is a favorite thought?—And just as little can the possibilities for his influence be easily calculated. Mainly he has worked as a divider of streams, has made turbid mixtures separate, has brought clarity into the spiritual world. Some he has led to seek more inward immersion in Christianity (as they conceive it). Others he has, in virtue of the principle of personal truth, led beyond it. And the indirect effects and consequences of his thoughts branch out into all the most important movements of spiritual life here in the North—and beyond the North.